

Elder Wilds

Version **0.1.0** — 2026-07-08

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Installation Guide

This document covers everything needed to set up the toolchain and environment for Elder Wilds. The section index and project scope live in [modlist.md](#).

Pre-Installation: Steam, Skyrim, And Creation Kit

Steam & Skyrim Setup

1. Install Steam and Skyrim SE/AE outside [Program Files](#), ideally under a shallow path such as [C:\Games\Skyrim Special Edition](#).
2. Confirm the game is on runtime [1.6.1170](#). The **Anniversary Upgrade** is not used.

Configure Steam

- **Disable the Steam Overlay:** In Steam, go to **Steam > Settings > In-Game** and uncheck "Enable the Steam overlay while in-game." Alternatively, disable it per-game: right-click **The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Special Edition** in your library, select **Properties**, and uncheck "Enable the Steam Overlay while in-game."
- **Update-proof Skyrim:** In Steam, right-click **The Elder Scrolls V: Skyrim Special Edition > Properties > Updates**, set **Automatic Updates** to **"Wait until I launch the game."** Updates will not trigger when launching through MO2 via SKSE. If an update slips through, use the [Skyrim downgrade patcher](#) to roll back.

Vanilla Skyrim First Launch

Launch Skyrim Special Edition through Steam to open the default launcher: click **Options**, select the **Ultra** preset, set **Aspect Ratio** and **Resolution** to your monitor's optimal values, set **Antialiasing** to **Off** (prepares for Community Shaders), ensure **Windowed Mode** is unchecked, click **OK** to save, and exit the launcher.

Install The Creation Kit

- **Skyrim Special Edition: Creation Kit** (https://store.steampowered.com/app/1946180/Skyrim_Special_Edition_Creation_Kit/): Download and install via Steam. Launch the Creation Kit through Steam to allow the **Scripts** folder to extract (automatic on first launch). Exit once loaded. Download the pre-made **CreationKitCustom.ini** and extract it to the Skyrim root folder. This configures the CK to allow multiple masters and load DLC content. If the CK crashes on first launch, add an **outbound firewall rule** for **CreationKit.exe**.
- **Creation Kit Platform Extended** (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/71371>): Download **CK Platform Extended 0.6-b550** and extract directly into the main Skyrim Special Edition folder — NOT into a sub-folder.

Create Modding Folders And Install Core Tools

Create a separate modding path with sub-folders (e.g., **C:\Modding** and **C:\Modding\Tools**) and install the tools from the toolchain list below into **C:\Modding\Tools**.

FOMOD Plus Installation

Install **FOMOD Plus - A Mod Installation Overhaul for Mod Organizer 2** (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspecialedition/mods/141001>) after MO2 setup: extract the archive contents directly into your MO2 installation folder, merging the **plugins** folder. Restart MO2 — FOMOD Plus activates automatically, adding a **FOMOD** column in the left pane and a **FOMOD** tab on the right pane.

Core Setup Goals

- Build and maintain **Elder Wilds** through **Mod Organizer 2** with clean separators and reproducible generated output
- Keep the setup aligned to Steam runtime **1.6.1170**
- Separate source mods, generated outputs, patches, and downloads clearly enough that rebuilds and troubleshooting stay manageable

Recommended Base Toolchain

- **Mod Organizer 2** as the main mod manager and profile system
- **SKSE64** and **Address Library for SKSE Plugins** as the runtime baseline
- **SSEEdit** for conflict review, patch inspection, cleaning guidance, and record-level troubleshooting
- **Wrye Bash** for later leveled-list and compatibility review where it still adds value
- **Synthesis** for selective patcher-based automation once the stack is stable enough to justify it
- **Cathedral Assets Optimizer** for asset cleanup and conversion tasks when a mod actually needs it
- **BethINI Pie** for baseline INI management and graphics/settings normalization
- **Skyrim Special Edition: Creation Kit** for resaving LE plugins to SE format; used alongside **Creation Kit Platform Extended** for stability
- **xLODGen**, **TexGen**, and **DynDOLOD** for terrain/object/tree distant detail workflow
- **BodySlide** and **Outfit Studio** for the chosen body pipeline
- **Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus** for animation behavior generation

Mod Organizer 2 Setup

- Follow STEP's standalone-folder approach: keep the game under a shallow custom path such as **C:\Games\Steam\steamapps\common\Skyrim Special Edition** and keep modding tools under a separate path such as **C:\Modding\Tools**.
- Install **Mod Organizer 2** as a standalone application under **C:\Modding\Tools\Mod Organizer** rather than inside the game folder.
- On first launch, create a **global instance**, select the Steam **Skyrim Special Edition** install, and name the instance something obvious like **Elder Wilds 1.6.1170**.
- If MO2 prompts for profile settings during instance creation, tick every box so the profile keeps its own **INI** files and game-specific settings.
- Connect MO2 to Nexus during first launch and let MO2 handle **nxm** links.
- In **Settings > Workarounds**, tick **Enable archives parsing (experimental)** so MO2 reports asset conflicts more reliably.
- Create at least one clean working profile before major category testing, and keep separators aligned to this repo's structure in **separators.md**.
- Keep generated outputs in their own enabled mods, never mixed into source mod folders.

Output Mods To Create In MO2

Before registering tools, create these empty mods in MO2 under the **Output** separator:

- **xEdit Output**
- **SKSE Scripts**
- **SKSE Output**
- **BodySlide Output**
- **Pandora Output**
- **Grass Cache Output**
- **Terrain LOD Output**
- **TexGen Output**
- **DynDOLOD Output**

- Occlusion Output
- Synthesis Output
- Bashed Patch Output

SKSE64 Installation

- Follow STEP's split install pattern for SKSE64 on Steam runtime 1.6.1170: install the two root files into the Skyrim game folder, but manage the Data portion through MO2 as its own mod.
- Use the current AE 1.6.1170 build of SKSE64, not an older AE build and not a GOG/VR variant.
- Copy skse64_loader.exe and the matching skse64_1_6_1170.dll from the archive into the Skyrim root folder next to SkyrimSE.exe.
- In MO2, create an empty mod named SKSE Scripts, then copy the archive's Data\Scripts folder into that mod so the script portion stays visible and manageable in the left pane.
- If an SKSE\skse.ini is needed later, place it inside the SKSE Scripts mod rather than writing directly into the game folder. Minimal modern baseline:

```
[General]
ClearInvalidRegistrations=1

[Display]
iTintTextureResolution=2048
```

- Register skse64_loader.exe in MO2 as the SKSE Skyrim Launcher executable and launch the game through that entry after the vanilla initialization step.
- Community troubleshooting on r/skyrimmods still clusters around the same mistakes: wrong runtime build, root files copied into the wrong folder, scripts not installed as a mod, or launching outside MO2. Guard against those explicitly.

Register Tools In MO2

- Open MO2's executable editor from the gear icon and add each tool with Add from file....
- Tick Use application's icon for desktop shortcuts for each entry so shortcuts remain readable.
- For tools that generate files, tick Create files in mod instead of overwrite and point them at the correct output mod.
- Arrange the executables in a stable order so the dropdown reflects the real workflow instead of becoming random over time.

MO2 Executable Reference

Tool	Executable	Arguments	Output Handling	Notes
BethINI Pie	Bethini.exe	none	none	Run through MO2 so it edits the active profile INIs instead of global game INIs.
LOOT	LOOT.exe	--game="Skyrim Special Edition"	none	If LOOT fails through MO2, use --single-process --game="Skyrim Special Edition".
SKSE Skyrim Launcher	skse64_loader.exe	none	SKSE Output	Use this to launch the game after the root files are in the game folder and the SKSE Scripts mod is enabled.
xEdit	xEdit.exe	-SSE -IKnowWhatImDoing -AllowMasterFilesEdit	xEdit Output	Main conflict review and manual patching entry.

Tool	Executable	Arguments	Output Handling	Notes
xEditQuickAutoClean	xEditQuickAutoClean.exe	-SSE	xEdit Output	Only use for plugins LOOT explicitly flags for cleaning.
xLODGen	xLODGenx64.exe	-lodgen -SSE -o:"DriveLetter:\Modding\Tools\xLODGen\xLODGen_Output"	Terrain LOD Output	Replace DriveLetter with the actual drive letter used for the modding folder.
TexGen	TexGen64.exe	-SSE	TexGen Output	Keep output isolated and pack it into the dedicated mod immediately after generation.
DynDOLOD	DynDOLODx64.exe	-SSE	DynDOLOD Output	Keep output isolated and enable DynDOLOD.esm / DynDOLOD.esp after generation.
Wrye Bash	Wrye Bash.exe	none	dedicated patch/output mod if used	Register only if the list still needs a Bashed Patch or leveled-list review pass.
Synthesis	Synthesis.exe	none	dedicated patch/output mod if used	Give it its own output mod once the final patcher set is known.
BodySlide	BodySlide x64.exe	none	dedicated body/output mod	Run through MO2 so mesh output respects the active profile and selected body stack.
Pandora	Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus.exe	none	dedicated behavior/output mod if needed	Run through MO2 so behavior generation sees the real virtualized animation stack.

MO2 Operating Rules

- Launch the game through **SKSE**, not through Steam or the stock launcher, after the vanilla initialization step is complete.
- Run **LOOT** before gameplay tests and before any major cleaning or conflict-review pass.
- Use **xEditQuickAutoClean** only for plugins LOOT explicitly marks as needing cleaning.
- Use **xEdit** after each major category to review conflicts instead of waiting until the whole list is assembled. The **Patching Technique And Strategy** section in **modlist-foundations.md** defines the workflow to follow from the first mod.

- Treat the [Overwrite](#) folder as a failure state; if files appear there, either move them into the proper output mod or fix the executable configuration that produced them.
- Rebuild generated outputs after major changes to bodies, animations, grass, LOD, or other systems that produce artifacts.
- Document manual fixes, custom arguments, and tool-specific decisions directly in this repository so the plan stays reproducible.

Elder Wilds

Target build: Skyrim Special Edition / Anniversary Edition runtime [1.6.1170](#) via Steam

Scope notes:

- No paid Anniversary Edition Creation Club content
- Research categories are organized around five pillars: modern graphics, expanded systems, modernized UI, immersive world scale, and third-person-first gameplay. The entire modlist is designed to be completely played in third-person with a gamepad — no interaction should require first-person or keyboard/mouse alone.
- This modlist is also built around [Legacy of the Dragonborn](#) as a major collection, museum, and patch-ecosystem pillar rather than treating it as an optional side add-on

Installation

The full setup and installation guide (Steam config, MO2 setup, SKSE, tool registration, operating rules) lives in [install.md](#).

Research Workflow

- Work through one category at a time
- For each category, define goals, constraints, candidate mods, compatibility risks, and acceptance criteria
- Do not lock final picks until foundations, graphics baseline, animation framework, and UI framework are validated together
- Prefer mods with active maintenance, clear Steam [1.6.1170](#) support, strong patch ecosystem, and stable load-order behavior

Section Index

The file [separators.md](#) is the canonical ordered reference for [Mod Organizer 2](#) separators.

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Foundations and Compatibility

All mods in this section are installed into the appropriate **Foundations** sub-separators as noted per group.

Baseline

Install all core libraries and frameworks upfront — they are non-negotiable dependencies for virtually every mod in the list. Bulk-install prevents missing-master errors and lets every subsequent section work against the real framework stack.

SKSE & Scripts → separator: **Foundations - SKSE & Scripts**

- **SKSE64** — Script extender; required by almost every SKSE plugin. [Nexus](#)

Core Libraries → separator: **Foundations - Core Libraries**

- **Address Library for SKSE Plugins** — Universal SKSE plugin compatibility layer for 1.6.1170.
- **USSEP** — Foundational record patch. Requires the four free CC masters — no paid AE Upgrade needed.
- **SSE Engine Fixes** — Critical engine-level stability and bug fixes.
- **SSE Display Tweaks** — Mandatory display and frame-pacing control.
- **Scrambled Bugs** — Collection of low-level engine tweaks.
- **powerofthree's Tweaks** — SKSE plugin tweak framework; hard dependency for many modern mods.
- **powerofthree's Papyrus Extender** — Extended Papyrus scripting functions.
- **PapyrusUtil** — Papyrus array/map utilities.
- **JContainers** — JSON data storage for Papyrus.
- **Keyword Item Distributor (KID)** — Distributes keywords to items without patching.
- **Spell Perk Item Distributor (SPID)** — Distributes spells/perks to NPCs dynamically.
- **Base Object Swapper (BOS)** — Swaps base objects via rules without direct overrides.
- **Crash Logger SSE AE VR** — Crash dump logging for diagnosing CTDs.
- **SkyPatcher** — SKSE-based vanilla record patcher; hard requirement for several NPC/AI mods.
- **Dual Casting Fix** — Required by Blade and Blunt.
- **Andrealphus' Papyrus Functions** — Required by Dragon War.
- **ConsoleUtilSSE NG** — Required by Dragon War and several animation behavior mods.
- **Kris's Papyrus Extender** — Required by Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed.
- **Animation Queue Fix** — Animation-stack stability for heavy OAR/behavior loads.
- **Papyrus Tweaks NG** — Script-engine performance optimization; widely adopted baseline.
- **Lexicon SKSE** — Required by Actor Value Generator.
- **Actor Value Generator** — Required by Classic Attributes.
- **XEMI Utility** — Required by FYX - Nordic Doors and Traps Collisions.

SkyPatcher And SkyPatched Mods → separator: **Foundations - Core Libraries**

SkyPatcher is an SKSE plugin that patches vanilla records at runtime from INI-style configuration files rather than traditional ESP plugins. No winner-loser override chain, no per-pair patches for the records it covers.

A "**SkyPatched**" variant ships record changes as SkyPatcher configs instead of an ESP. Assets (meshes, textures, scripts) still install in MO2's left pane, but the plugin slot is replaced by files under **SKSE/Plugins/SkyPatcher/**.

When to choose SkyPatched:

- Mod only changes vanilla records (book stats, weapon damage, armor ratings, ingredient values), not new records
- Load order is approaching the 254-plugin cap — each SkyPatched variant saves one ESP slot
- Multiple mods edit the same records — runtime application avoids patch debt
- Author explicitly provides a SkyPatched alternative

When to stick with traditional plugin:

- Mod adds new records (CELL, WRLD, QUST, NPC_ with facegen)
- Mod needs explicit load-order priority — Bashed Patch or xEdit patches give control that "all apply" doesn't
- No SkyPatched variant available

Mods using SkyPatcher in this list:

- [Book Covers Skyrim - SkyPatched](#) (→ 02c)
- [Dawnguard Arsenal SSE - SkyPatched](#) (→ 08)
- [Diverse 4thUnknown Dragons](#) — uses SkyPatcher for combat-mod compatibility (→ 09)
- [Patchifier](#) Synthesis patcher generates SkyPatcher patches (→ 14d)

Mesh & Texture Fixes → separator: **Foundations - Mesh & Texture Fixes**

- **Particle Patch** — Particle shader/LOD corrections, CS-compatible.
- **Assorted Mesh Fixes** — Corrections for common visual mesh errors.
- **Flickering Meshes Fix** — Resolves distant-object mesh flicker in landscape transitions.

Official Masters Cleanup

Clean all six-plus vanilla masters before installing any mod. Use **xEditQuickAutoClean** on each file individually, collect cleaned **.esm** files into a **Cleaned Vanilla Masters** MO2 mod, and restore originals from **xEdit Backups** back into **Data**.

Which Masters To Clean

- **Skyrim.esm**, **Update.esm**, **Dawnguard.esm**, **HearthFires.esm**, **Dragonborn.esm**
- All Creation Club **.esm** files shipped with 1.6.1170
- Do not clean **_ResourcePack.esl** — contains no ITM or UDR records.

Procedure

1. Create empty mod **Cleaned Vanilla Masters** under **Output** separator. Leave disabled.
2. Run LOOT, sort, apply, close.
3. For each **.esm**: select **xEditQuickAutoClean** from MO2 executables, check **ONLY** that master, wait for completion, close.
4. Move cleaned masters (recent mod date) from **Data** into **Cleaned Vanilla Masters** mod folder. Keep only **.esm** files; delete **.backup/.bak**.
5. Restore originals from **xEdit Backups** back into **Data**.
6. Enable **Cleaned Vanilla Masters** in MO2. Run LOOT again — no masters flagged.

Notes

- Cleaning **Update.esm** is standard despite some mod-author cautions; USSEP's records win over cleaned originals.
- Never clean a third-party mod's plugin unless LOOT explicitly flags it — many mods ship ITMs intentionally.
- **Cleaned Vanilla Masters** must remain enabled for the entire playthrough.

Patching Technique And Strategy

Adopt the canonical **xEdit** mod-by-mod patching workflow: install one mod at a time, run **xEdit** in **-veryquickshowconflicts** mode, resolve only new conflicts, use per-pair patches and **ModGroups**. Reserve **Bashed Patch** and **Synthesis** for the categories they genuinely own.

Wrye Bash And The Bashed Patch

The **Bashed Patch** is an automatically generated plugin merging leveled lists, applying game-setting tweaks, and resolving category-tagged record conflicts. Replaces dozens of per-pair patches for the record types it owns.

Rebuild triggers: adding/removing leveled-list mods, changing **.TweakSettings**, adding a mod with **Bash Tags**, form-ID compaction. It is step 2 in the full build order (after **SSEEdit**, before **Synthesis**; see → 14d).

What the Bashed Patch does not do: resolve arbitrary record conflicts (→ **xEdit/Synthesis**), merge plugins (→ ESL flags), or iterative/rule-based patching (→ **Synthesis**).

Mods complementing or requiring Wrye Bash:

- **Leveled-list expanders** (Immersive Weapons, Immersive Armors, Hunterborn) — need **Relev/Delev/Invent.Add** tags
- **World loot frameworks** (Open World Loot, MorrowLoot Ultimate)
- **Economy mods** (Trade and Barter, Ars Metallica, Honed Metal, Apothecary) — need **Stats/Invent.Change**
- **Lighting/weather** (CS Light, True Light, RAID Weathers) — need **C.Light/C.Water/C.Climate**
- **NPC/follower mods** (RDO, Nether's, Serana Dialogue) — need **Actors.*** tags
- **Audio overhauls** (AOS, ISC, Sounds of Skyrim) — need **Sound/C.Acoustic**

Exact **Bash Tag** per plugin, **.TweakSettings** table, and build-order placement → 14d modlist-performance-patches.md.

Cyclic Workflow (per new mod)

1. **Install and place.** Heuristic: broad world-changers early; narrow/local edits late.
2. **Run xEdit with -veryquickshowconflicts.** Register xEdit in MO2 with that argument. Right-click → **Hide no conflict and empty rows**.
3. **Try load order first.** Move mod up/down if that resolves most conflicts; re-run.
4. **Identify bad conflicts.** Only conflicts where the loser was supposed to win.
5. **Build per-pair patch.** Copy as override into... → <new file>.esp [Template] ESL. Name explicitly (e.g., **LoreRim_x_RWT.esp**). Drag missing fields from loser into new record. Accept master addition. Run **Add Masters...** for every referenced mod. Save into **Patches** separator.
6. **Build per-pair ModGroups.** One **ModGroup** per conflicting pair. Move ***.ModGroup** files from **MO2 overwrite** into the source mod's own MO2 folder.
7. **Re-open xEdit and confirm zero visible conflicts.**

Starting State

Clean load order (**Skyrim.esm**, **Update.esm**, three DLCs) plus USSEP. USSEP ships a premade **ModGroup** since xEdit 4.1.7 — keep it.

Cleaning Discipline

Run LOOT after new mod install. If flagged for cleaning, run **Quick Auto Clean** then **Check For Errors**. Red errors = reconsider the mod. QAC only removes ITM/UDR records.

ESL-Flagged Patches

Always use `<new file>.esp [Template] ESL` for patches. Never manually re-flag ESP→ESL unless the mod author or xEdit explicitly says to.

Notes

- Keep Bashed Patch and Synthesis scoped — don't let them absorb every decision.
- Date-stamp patches and re-run xEdit after every source-mod update.
- Patches copying from downstream plugins inherit unresolved conflicts — read the master chain.
- xEdit normal mode writes current loaded state — never use it to save. Save only in fast mode.
- Promote tiny per-pair patches into themed region/feature patches when count becomes unmanageable.
- Deliberately test that disabling one upstream source mod cleanly stops its ModGroup and dependent patches.

ESP To ESL Conversion

Converting ESP to ESL-flagged ESP frees a regular plugin slot (limit 254) by moving into the 4096 light-plugin address space.

What Makes A Plugin Convertible

- Fewer than 2048 new record forms
- No new CELL/WRLD/NAVM/NAVI records
- No QUST/DIAL overrides with hard-coded form ID references
- **Trivially convertible:** Bodyslide outputs, SKSE plugin dummy ESPs, texture-replacer ESPs

Automated Discovery

1. **Built-in script:** Find ESP plugins which could be turned into ESL.pas — ships with SSEEdit.
2. **Fractal's ESP-ESL Finder v1.1** ([Nexus](#))
3. **ESLify** ([Nexus](#)) — batch-convert wrapper. Verify candidates manually first.
4. **SSEEdit Script - Header Change to Version 1.71** ([Nexus](#)) — unlocks full 4095-record range for 1.6.1130+.

Safe Conversion (low risk)

1. Right-click → **Compact Form IDs for ESL**.
2. Right-click → **Set Is-Esl Flag** (ESL only, not ESM).
3. Save. Re-sort with LOOT.

Full Conversion (xEdit workflow)

1. Load plugin + dependencies. Apply **Hide no conflict and empty rows**.
2. Right-click → **Compact Form IDs for ESL**. If zero, skip to step 4.
3. **Check for broken references:** Run **Check for Errors**; for external refs, load full load order → **Referenced By** → **Apply as filter**; or use **List records referencing specific plugins.pas**.
4. Right-click → **Set Is-Esl Flag** (ESL only).
5. Save. Re-sort.

Red Lines

- **Never** convert plugins with CELL/WRLD/NAVM/NAVI records without verifying every cross-reference.
- **Never** convert mid-playthrough.
- **Never** convert a plugin another mod lists as a master without verifying.
- ESL-flagged plugins still count toward the 4096 light-plugin limit.

Recommended Candidates

- Bodyslide outputs, texture-replacer ESPs, SKSE plugin dummies
- Single-weapon/armor/spell mods with <50 new records and no scripts
- Crafting recipe-only ESPs
- Patches created via [\[Template\] ESL](#)

Never Convert

- Major quest mods (LotD, Interesting NPCs, Vigilant)
- City/settlement overhauls with new CELL or WRLD records
- Overhauls with new dialogue branches or follower framework quest aliases
- Any plugin LOOT or SSEEdit flags as not ESL-safe

Targeted Bugfix Mods → separator: **Foundations - Targeted Bugfixes**

Baseline

- **Fuz Ro D-oh - Silent Voice** (Nexus) — Subtitle safety for unvoiced dialogue.
- **Actor Limit Fix** (Nexus) — Crowded scene / facial animation reliability.
- **Equip Enchantment Fix** (Nexus) — Enchantments dropping off while equipped.
- **NPC AI Process Position Fix - NG** (Nexus) — NPC processing after waiting/fast travel.
- **Simple Offence Suppression** (Nexus) — Accidental hostility from stray hits.
- **Bug Fixes SSE** (Nexus) — Crafting-menu, perk-application, and water-behavior fixes.
- **Navigator - Navmesh Fixes** (Nexus) — Follower pathing in complex worldspaces.
- **Barter Limit Fix** (Nexus) — Merchant gold cap overflow.
- **Mum's the Word NG** (Nexus) — Worthless stolen-item tagging.
- **Regional Save Names** (Nexus) — Save labeling for testing hygiene.
- **Better Jumping SE** (Nexus) — Consistent jumping control.
- **LeveledList Crash Fix** (Nexus) — Leveled-list crash protection.
- **Explosion Collision Fix** (Nexus) — Prevents explosion-force spells from launching objects into camera.

Not Installed

- **I'm Walkin' Here NG with Pets** (Nexus) — Ally/pet body-blocking fix.
- **Bard Instrumentals Mostly - Sing Rarely** (Nexus) — Repetitive tavern singing. Not needed — other bard mods cover this. → separator: **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

TODO

- **Alt-Tab Stuck Key Fix** (Nexus) — Stuck modifier keys after alt-tab.

Graphics Pipeline

MO2 Separator: Graphics

Overview

This section owns the full graphics rendering pipeline for **Elder Wilds**: from the post-process shader framework through textures, lighting, weather, water, terrain, characters, and distant detail. Each pillar of the pipeline lives in its own sub-file.

The pipeline is designed to be evaluated in order — each stage depends on the one before it. Do not jump ahead to textures or characters before the Community Shaders framework and its addon modules are locked.

Pipeline Order

Stage	File	Category
1	Graphics - PGPatcher	PGPatcher — parallax/PBR mesh generation
2	Graphics - Community Shaders	Community Shaders — post-process framework and addon modules
3	Graphics - Textures & Meshes	Textures & Meshes — all surface-level asset replacement
4	Graphics - Lighting	Lighting — interior, exterior, and effect lighting
5	Graphics - Weather & Water	Weather & Water — atmospheric and liquid rendering
6	Graphics - Terrain & Flora	Terrain & Flora — ground surfaces, grass, trees
7	Graphics - Characters & Creatures	Characters & Creatures — body, skin, hair, creature textures
8	Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail	LOD & Distant Detail — far-field rendering

Key Principles

- PGPatcher runs after the texture and mesh stack is stable → Graphics - PGPatcher
- Community Shaders is the universal post-process baseline; no ENB is used → Graphics - Community Shaders
- All texture and shader choices must be evaluated for third-person readability at 4K
- Performance budgeting for the pipeline is owned by modlist-performance.md → Performance
- Visual coherence rules (no mixing low-res and high-res in the same category) are owned by modlist-curation.md → Testing & Curation

PGPatcher

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - PGPatcher

All items in this section belong to the Graphics - PGPatcher MO2 separator unless noted.

PGPatcher Workflow

PGPatcher is a post-installation patcher that generates parallax and PBR-compatible meshes from the installed texture and mesh stack. It must run after the main texture, mesh, parallax, and PBR candidate set is mostly chosen so it works against a stable asset baseline.

Baseline

- **PGPatcher** (Nexus) — Post-installation parallax/PBR mesh generator. Keep output in its own generated MO2 folder, separate from source mods.

Workflow Rules

- Run after installing or changing PBR texture packs, parallax-enabled textures, or major mesh/parallax support mods.
- Let the generated patch load after the source texture and mesh mods it supports.
- Re-run whenever a major landscape, architecture, ruins, or clutter texture pack is replaced.
- Only keep the generated output if it produces a visible improvement without new artifacts.
- Hard requirement for mods such as **Steel Armor Redone - PBR and Complex Material**.

Alternatives

- Skip route: rely on hand-authored parallax meshes from individual texture packs and skip post-processing entirely.

Notes

- Running PGPatcher before the texture stack is stable means regenerating the patch each time a texture mod changes.
- Generated output can conflict with hand-authored parallax meshes — always test before committing the generated patch.

Community Shaders

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Community Shaders

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Community Shaders MO2 separator unless a different one is noted.

Community Shaders Core Setup

This section owns the graphics-framework decision for the shader-first visual stack. Build modern visuals around Community Shaders, then layer materials, lighting, weather, water, and distant detail on top.

Baseline

- **Community Shaders** (Nexus) — Core framework.
- Validate prerequisites before judging later graphics layers: SKSE64 (Nexus), Address Library for SKSE Plugins (Nexus), Luma Utility (Nexus), and any current page-listed dependencies.
- Record baseline performance before installing add-ons so module decisions are measured against a real control point.

Alternatives

- Non-CS alternatives (ENB) are out of scope unless the project abandons the shader-first direction.

Notes

- Some CS features are much heavier than the core framework.
- Older ecosystem pages may refer to legacy behavior or outdated version requirements.
- A shader-first stack still needs discipline; enabling every feature isn't the same as building a coherent visual direction.

Community Shaders Add-Ons And Required Features

How aggressive the first CS feature layer should be — improve shadowing, wetness, water response, and material depth without front-loading the full performance cost.

Feature Tiers

Tier	Modules	When To Enable
Conservative	Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Water Effects, Wetness Effects	Start here
Balanced	Conservative + Terrain Shadows	After trees, grass, weather, water, LOD are stable
High-End	Balanced + SSGI, Subsurface Scattering	Luxury, not requirement

Install the CS main download (v1.7+) and enable modules via FOMOD. Install optional plugins separately.

Plugins (separate downloads from core)

- **Skylighting** — Sky-driven ambient occlusion. Pairs cleanly with the conservative tier. Worth including for authentic grim-dark look.

- **Skyrim Upscaler - DLSS FSR2 XeSS (Nexus)** — Only if real performance testing proves it's needed.
- **Embers XD (Nexus)** — The fire-and-ember answer (140K+). Install after lighting overhauls so it inherits their campfire/hearth placements. → separator:
Graphics - Lighting

Optional separate plugin downloads: Cloud Shadows, Hair Specular, HDR, SSGI, Skylighting, Terrain Helper, Terrain Blending, Terrain Variation, Upscaling, Wetness Effects.

Graphics Testing Protocol

Recommended Tool Stack

- Performance capture: PresentMon
- Analysis and graphing: CapFrameX
- Record keeping: Markdown table in this repo first, spreadsheet only if comparison volume grows
- Visual comparison: fixed test saves plus matching screenshot captures

Test Scene Rules

- Use the same character save for all graphics testing.
- Same location, camera angle, FOV, and time of day for each comparison pass.
- Keep one indoor test cell and at least two outdoor test cells: forest and open landscape.
- Record weather state for every run.
- Add or remove only one graphics variable at a time.

Suggested Metrics

- Average FPS
- 1% low FPS
- Frame-time consistency notes
- VRAM pressure notes from monitoring tools
- Shader artifacts, flicker, ghosting, water issues, grass mismatch, shadow instability
- Subjective visual verdict: keep, retest, reject

Markdown Table Format

Date	Build	Test Area	Weather/Time	Mod Change	Avg FPS	1% Low	Visual Notes	Decision
YYYY-MM-DD	Steam 1.6.1170	Falkreath Forest	Overcast / 3 PM	Added Grass Lighting	00	00	Better depth, no flicker	Keep

Notes

- Module stacks that look good in isolation can fight later weather, water, or lighting winners.
- Measuring several shader changes at once makes later decisions impossible to trust.
- Screenshot appeal can hide long-session readability or frame-time problems.

Parallax Framework Dependencies

Auto Parallax and Complex Parallax Materials form the parallax rendering layer bridging CS parallax support with mesh and texture mods downstream.

Baseline

- Install **Auto Parallax (Nexus)** and **Complex Parallax Materials (Nexus)** as infrastructure before adding parallax-enabled textures or meshes. CPM hard-depends on Auto Parallax. Install after the texture stack is mostly chosen but before PGPatcher runs.

Notes

- Without Auto Parallax, Complex Parallax Materials will not function — both must be present.
- Installing too early means regenerating parallax data after texture changes; install after the main texture stack is locked.

Physically Based Rendering (PBR) Support

PBR is an adoption strategy layered on top of Community Shaders, not a separate renderer choice. The real decision is how selectively to use PBR-ready materials and conversions.

Baseline — Balanced PBR Route

Broad AIO base + targeted terrain and rock overrides.

- **Vanilla PBR AIO (Nexus, 11.5 GB)** — Primary base. Covers all architecture, clutter, actors, dungeons with vanilla-faithful art direction.
- **Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k (Nexus, 3.0 GB)** — Fills VPBR's terrain gap. Do NOT install Faultier's Skyrim AIO alongside VPBR.

- **Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR** ([Nexus](#)) — Modern rock/mountain overhaul. Load after VPBR to override its mountain textures. Install both main files (meshes then textures, choose PBR in FOMOD).
- **Tomato's PBR Whiterun** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional Whiterun override. Install 2K (735 MB), skip 4K (2 GB). Optional: [Improved Dragon Carvings](#) (beta, 2K) and [PBR Talos](#).
- **Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional farmhouse override. Install Grey 2K (84 MB), skip 4K. Optional: [WSU PBR Farmhouse windows patch](#) if Window Shadows Ultimate is in the stack.

Community Shaders ships **Dynamic Cubemaps** and **Image-Based Lighting (IBL)** as standard features. Verify the chosen PBR texture set uses both before adding extra reflection/cubemap mods.

Alternatives

- **Minimal PBR:** Enable support but only use a few showcase conversions.
- **Full PBR push:** Broad world coverage with higher maintenance and consistency risk.

Priority Coverage

Priority 1 — seen constantly in travel and third person:

- City architecture; farmhouses and rural buildings
- Nordic ruins and dungeon stonework
- High-visibility clutter and props

Priority 2 — fill in after core look settles:

- Select landscape regions with strong material identity
- City sets from settlement overhauls that survive later testing
- Broader regional packs that fill obvious gaps

Defer for now:

- Full-world landscape replacement
- Low-visibility assets adding patching/VRAM cost without changing moment-to-moment feel
- Niche regional conversions before core city/dungeon/farmhouse look is settled

Priority 2 Candidate Mods

- **A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape** ([Nexus](#))
- **TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO** ([Nexus](#))
- **PBR textures for The Great Cities Collection** ([Nexus](#))
- **PBR Hub** ([Nexus](#)) — Discovery hub for later expansion.

Working Rollout Order

1. Install **Vanilla PBR AIO** — broad PBR base for architecture, clutter, actors, dungeons.
2. Install **Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k** — fills VPBR's terrain gap.
3. Install **Enhanced Rocks and Mountains** after VPBR — overrides VPBR's mountain textures.
4. Optionally install **Tomato's PBR Whiterun** and **Tomato's PBR Farmhouses 2.0** after VPBR.
5. Run **PGPatcher** last — all PBR texture mods above require it.
6. Only after core stack passes review, test optional landscape additions ([Cathedralist's PBR Landscape](#), [TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO](#)).

Notes

- VPBR is newer (March 2026) than Faultier's PBR Skyrim (v3.0) — single-point-of-failure risk if abandoned. Active development so far (v1.0 → v1.32 in ~2 months).
- Faultier's PBR Landscapes 4k + ERM cover VPBR's landscape gap; Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes covers the gear gap.
- VPBR includes mountain textures that must be overridden by ERM. Load ERM after VPBR.
- Do NOT install [Faultier's Skyrim AIO](#) alongside VPBR — same texture paths.
- PBR ambition can outrun the rest of the stack if weather, trees, water, and lighting aren't held to a similar bar.

Candidate TODO Additions

→ Separators: [Community Shaders](#), [Lighting](#), [Weather & Water](#), [Terrain & Flora](#)

Textures, Clutter & Meshes → [Graphics](#) - [Community Shaders](#)

- [Racemenu Enhancer](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspedition/mods/182536> — Character creation RaceMenu enhancer
- [Visual Animated Enchants](#) — Weapon enchantment VFX replacer
- [Apophysis Dragon Priests Masks](#) — Dragon priest mask retexure
- [Runed Nordic Weapons](#) — Nordic weapon mesh/texture replacer
- [Elven Armor replacer glow](#) — Elven armor retexure with glow maps
- [Elsopa Iron weapons redone](#) — Iron weapon retexure

- [Ennead Banners and Shields](#) — Banner/shield retexture
- [Elsopa Quivers Redone](#) — Quiver retexture
- [Believable greatswords sheathed](#) — Greatsword sheath mesh fix
- [ElSopa - HD Medieval anvil](#) — Anvil retexture
- [Elsopa Grindstones](#) — Grindstone retexture
- [Renthal Workbench](#) — Workbench retexture
- [VFX Edit AIO - Spells Retexture](#) — Spell visual effect retexture
- [JFresh's Mead Stein](#) — Mead stein retexture
- [SD's Horn Candles](#) — Candle retexture
- [JS Dragon Claws](#) — Dragon claw retexture
- [Skyrim remastered soul gems](#) — Soul gem retexture
- [Rally's Market Stalls](#) — Market stall retexture
- [KanJS Spell Tomes Animated](#) — Animated spell tome mesh replacer
- [Alt Markarth Forge](#) — Markarth forge retexture
- [HD Unique Handmade signs](#) — Inn/shop sign retexture
- [Stay Arrows Stay](#) — Keeps arrows lodged in bodies and world
- [One Quiver to rule them all](#) — Quiver attachment positioning fix
- [Nordic Windhelm / Tomato's Windhelm](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/174492> — Windhelm city retexture with PBR/Complex Material
- [Distinguished Drapery](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/173894> — Curtain/hanging fabric retexture
- [The Mists of Blackreach](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/179487> — Blackreach mist/fog VFX
- [Better Wine Labels - Vanilla and LotD](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/34698> — Wine bottle label retexture; PBR Patch: <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/175588>
- [Diverse Windmill Sails - BOS](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/121759>
- [Diverse Foods - BOS](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/91599>
- [Diverse Candles - BOS](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/94369>
- [Better Pelts and Hides](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/87277>
- [Fluffy Hanging rabbits](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/89148>
- [FrankBlack's Honey in a Jar](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/104496>
- [slightly Better Nordic Henges - BOS](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/97162>

Lighting → [Graphics](#) - [Lighting](#)

- [KD Realistic Fireplaces](#) — Fireplace visual upgrade
- [EmbersXD Torch Edit](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/134219> — Torch visual edit for Embers XD

Weather & Sky → [Graphics](#) - [Weather & Water](#)

- [Draco's fantasy auroras](#) — Aurora/sky visual replacer
- [Draco's moons](#) — Moon visual replacer

Flora & Landscape → [Graphics](#) - [Terrain & Flora](#)

- [Flora Additions - Water Plants](#) — Water plant flora additions
- [Bigger trees](#) — Tree size multiplier
- [Grassreach - Blackreach Grass](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/179420>
- [Freak's Floral Solstheim](#) — <https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/138161>
- Road texture options: [Simplest Roads](#) (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/111255>), [Simple Complex Parallax Roads](#) (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/173826>), [Blended Roads](#) (<https://www.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/mods/8834>)

Textures & Meshes

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics](#) - [Textures & Meshes](#)

All mods in this section belong to the [Graphics](#) - [Textures & Meshes](#) MO2 separator unless a different one is noted.

Mesh Improvements And Parallax Support

Improve shape quality and silhouette readability without creating an unmaintainable conflict swamp. The best outcome is a stable baseline of mesh improvements, targeted fixes where they matter, and parallax support only where textures benefit from it.

🌀 **Install order:** Core foundation → doors & walls → locks → furniture & city detail → mesh replacers → environment props → alternatives. Follow the grouping below.

Core Foundation

Mod	Description	Nexus
Static Mesh Improvement Mod (SMIM)	Core mesh foundation. → separator: Graphics - Community Shaders	Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Unofficial Material Fix	Corrects material records for Community Shaders PBR. Install after SMIM.	Nexus
Simplicity of Snow v0.26	Main file only (32.8 MB). Skip Parallax Meshes and patches for mods not in the list.	Nexus
XEMI Utility	Prerequisite for FYX collision fixes below.	Nexus
FYX - Nordic Doors and Traps Collisions	Collision geometry fix. Requires XEMI Utility.	Nexus
Flame VFX Edit	Mesh-only fire spell effect improvement. CS-compatible.	Nexus

Doors, Walls & Structures

Mod	Description	Nexus
Glorious Doors of Skyrim (GDOS)	Higher-detail door meshes for all architecture types. FOMOD: 2K textures , install all door categories , include Splendid Mechanized Dwemer Door (ESL).	Nexus
Whiterun Has Walls Redone	3D geometry and parallax textures for Whiterun's exterior walls. Replaces flat walls.	Nexus
Stockades of Skyrim 3D	Base layer for 3D stockade walls and barricades.	Nexus
FYX - 3D Stockades	Overwrites Stockades of Skyrim 3D meshes. Install after the stockade base.	Nexus
Born in a Barn - Door Curtains for Shacks	BOS-based door curtains for shacks and poor homes. No ESP.	Nexus

Security Overhaul SKSE Series

Install together. Use **2K textures** for all — locks are examined up close but 4K is wasted VRAM.

Mod	Nexus
Lock Variations	Nexus
Regional Locks	Nexus
Lock Add-ons	Nexus
Some More Locks	Nexus
Extra Locks	Nexus
PBR	Nexus

Furniture, Clutter & City Detail

Mod	Description	Nexus
Snazzy Furniture and Clutter Overhaul (SFCO)	Clutter objects, geometry, and variety beyond VPBR's base textures.	Nexus

Snazzy City series (BOS-based, city-by-city clutter improvements):

Mod	Nexus
Whiterun AIO	Nexus
Windhelm AIO	Nexus
Solitude AIO	Nexus
Markarth AIO	Nexus
Riften AIO	Nexus
Falkreath AIO	Nexus
Dawnstar AIO	Nexus
Winterhold AIO	Nexus
Towns and Settlements	Nexus
Misc Locations	Nexus
Player Homes	Nexus

Mesh Replacer Series

All mesh-only, no ESP.

Mod	Nexus
V.A.E.R.	Nexus
Thrones Expanded	Nexus
Rustic Repose	Nexus
Use Those Blankets	Nexus
Sleipnir Beds	Nexus
The Royal Seat	Nexus
Divide and Conquer	Nexus
Oddments and Miscellanea	Nexus
Utenlands Nordic Tents	Nexus
Redoran Reverie	Nexus
HF's Archery Target Remodel	Nexus
Diverse Grindstones	Nexus
Blary's Booksets	Nexus
ElSopa Misc Ruins Redone	Nexus
Snazzy Orc Chests	Nexus

Environment & Props

Mod	Description	Nexus
TB's 3D Driftwood	3D driftwood mesh replacer. No ESP. Complements coastal areas.	Nexus
WiZkiD Hunter's Camp Overhaul	Visual overhaul for hunter camps (tents, campfires, pots, clutter). No ESP.	Nexus
Improved Fish SE	Higher-quality fish meshes and textures.	Nexus
Improved Fish PBR	PBR textures for fish. Requires Improved Fish SE as mesh base.	Nexus
CC Fish PBRed	PBR textures for CC fish. Requires free AE fish addon.	Nexus
JS Badges of Office	Replacer for Jarl's crown, court-mage's circlet, steward's key. Mesh-only, no ESP.	Nexus

PGPatcher: Use the PGPatcher workflow in → [Graphics](#) - [PGPatcher](#) for late-stage parallax generation rules.

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
High Poly Project	Optional. Keep only if the extra geometry earns its conflict cost.	Nexus
RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION	Higher-res diffuse/normal replacer. May be redundant with VPBR's clutter coverage — evaluate side-by-side.	Nexus

Mesh Section Notes

- High Poly Project adds overlap and complexity for surprisingly small on-screen gains.
 - Parallax looks excellent on some surfaces and broken on others if support is inconsistent.
 - Snow, rock, landscape, and water meshes should not be finalized independently of texture and weather winners.
-

Furniture, Clutter, And Item Replacers

Texture and mesh upgrades for furniture, clutter, and items beyond the Snazzy city series — Rally's, Arc's, and Kanjs author lines plus standalone BOS replacers. No cell-record edits; all are BOS-based or pure replacers.

Rally's, Arc's, And Snazzy Clutter

Mod	Description	Nexus
Rally's Noble Furniture - BOS		Nexus
Rally's Orc Furniture		Nexus
Rally's Upper Furniture		Nexus
Rally's Barsets		Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Rally's Common Furniture		Nexus
Rally's Dark Elf Furniture (High Poly - ENB Light)		Nexus
Snazzy Common Wardrobes - BOS	Choose the BOS meshes main file.	Nexus
Whiterun Objects SMIMed (and fixes too)		Nexus
Arc's WispMother Redux 2K-4K	Choose 2K.	Nexus
Arc's Kettle REDUX 2K-4K	Choose 2K.	Nexus
Arc's Kitchen Redux 2K-4K	Choose 2K.	Nexus
Arc's MeadBarrel Redux 2K-4K	Stack: install all three (base + Bloody + Distributed). Choose 2K for base.	Nexus
Arc's Bloody MeadBarrel Redux		Nexus
Distributed Arc's Mead Barrels		Nexus
Arc's Tankard Redux		Nexus
ElSopa - HD Iron Tools Redone SE		Nexus
Diverse BOS Kitchenware		Nexus
Dynamic Things Alternative - BOS		Nexus
Nordic Stonewalls		Nexus
Nordic Stonewall Terraces		Nexus
Nordic Stonewalls Complex Material and PBR	PBR upgrade. Install after base Nordic Stonewalls.	Nexus
Snazzy Wall Mounted Trophies - BOS		Nexus
Fluffy Wall Mounted Dead Animals		Nexus
Wall Mounted Dead Animals Fixes	Install after Fluffy Wall Mounted Dead Animals.	Nexus
Snazzy Diverse Carriages - BOS		Nexus
Snazzy Diverse Carriages - Seasonal Patch	Required if Seasonal Landscapes is adopted.	Nexus

Animated Items (mesh replacers)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Kanjs - Sanguine Rose Animated		Nexus
Kanjs - Soup and Stew AIO Animated (SkyPatched)	Choose the SkyPatched version over the base.	Nexus
Kanjs - Human Heart Animated and Beating Motion		Nexus
Kanjs - Taproot Animated and Beating Motion		Nexus
Animated Filled Soul Gems		Nexus
Animated Ingredients		Nexus

Notes

- Kanjs Soup and Stew has two variants: the base animation mod (113104) and a SkyPatched version (113191). The SkyPatched version is recommended for better compatibility.
- Nordic Stonewalls + Complex Material: install the base mod first, then the PBR upgrade on top.
- Most Rally's and Arc's mods are texture-only or mesh-only; verify each against the load order for BOS overrides.
- Snazzy Diverse Carriages Seasonal Patch hard-depends on Seasonal Landscapes (→ [Terrain & Flora](#)).

Unique Entity Replacers

Model and texture upgrades for unique named entities and one-of-a-kind objects — characters, corpses, set-piece models not covered by broad replay packs. Closes visual gaps without swelling into full NPC beautification.

Mod	Description	Nexus
Night Mother	High-quality model/texture replacer for the Night Mother's corpse. ESL-flagged, zero script or record conflicts.	Nexus
Skyland Imperial and Nordic Tents	4K tent textures with new mesh for the large Nordic fur tent. No ESP.	Nexus

Notes

- Verify Night Mother does not conflict with lighting/interior overhauls that modify the sanctuary cell.
- Do not let this subsection grow into general NPC or creature overhaul — those are owned by → [NPCs](#).

Blood, Decals, And Combat Visual Effects

In-world visual effects during combat: blood pools, persistent decals, lingering marks. Separate from lighting/weather (ambient worldstate) and from hit-reaction/stagger (→ [Third-Person Gameplay](#), → [Expanded Systems](#)).

Mod	Description	Nexus
Dynamic Bloodpool Framework	Blood and decal framework. Lock in after weather/lighting baselines are stable (decals must read correctly under both daylight and your night setup).	Nexus
Dragon Breath VFX Edit	Dragon breath projectile/impact VFX replacer. Mesh-only, no ESP.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Improved Sparks	Orange spark effects on metal impacts and grindstones. FOMOD with density options (1X-20X).	Nexus
Lightning VFX Edit	Lightning bolt VFX replacer. Mesh-only, no ESP.	Nexus
Dynamic Footprints SKSE	Persistent footprints on snow, mud, sand. Add after blood/decals baseline is stable.	Nexus

Notes

- Blood/decals can interact poorly with CS weather mods handling screen-space wetness. Verify under a locked weather baseline.
- Persistent blood decals can strain frame-rate and memory in long fights. Check MCM for decal lifetime and density.
- Blood pools can look odd in snowy regions if the framework lacks surface-specific blending.
- Ownership scope: persistent decals/pools, not hit-effect layer.

Book and Paper Visual Overhauls

Visual upgrades for books, notes, and paper — the most-read world objects. Texture and mesh improvements make reading feel more tactile and library exploration more rewarding without touching gameplay records.

🔧 **Install order:** Book Covers Skyrim → Enhanced Textures → SkyPatched → Lost Library (optional content).

Base + Enhancements

Mod	Description	Nexus
Book Covers Skyrim	Core book-cover texture replacer. Every book gets a unique hand-crafted cover. 200K+ endorsements. Choose the Main Files download (not the USSEP Update variant).	Nexus
Book Covers Skyrim Enhanced Textures	2K/4K texture upgrade. Install after base mod and overwrite. Optional but recommended for 4K displays.	Nexus
Book Covers Skyrim - SkyPatched	SkyPatcher-based forward-port resolving record-level conflicts. Choose Recommended Main File .	Nexus
Book Covers Skyrim - Lost Library	Adds 150+ lore books from earlier TES games. Content companion; quest-level decision owned by → Ø8 .	Nexus

Notes

- With USSEP in the load order, use the SkyPatched variant — it handles USSEP forwarding plus broader compatibility.
- Enhanced Textures is recommended for 4K displays. At 2K the base BC7 textures are adequate.
- Verify compatibility with mods touching book inventory records (e.g., Unread Books Glow). SkyPatched resolves most record-level conflicts.
- Base mod is ~600 MB for 2K. Evaluate whether unique book covers earn their VRAM and disk space cost.

Lighting

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics - Lighting](#)

All mods in this section belong to the [Graphics - Lighting](#) MO2 separator unless noted.

Lighting Overhaul Strategy

Build lighting as a coherent layer supporting the shader-first visual direction, stronger world scale, and third-person readability. Interior mood matters, but so do readability, compatibility cost, and coherence with the final weather route. The baseline is a Community Shaders-native stack with much lower patch burden than the LUX family.

🔗 **Install order:** SLT → CS Light + True Light + WSU → Based Lighting Configs → Ambient Templates → DIAL → Embers XD → Luminous Atronachs.

Core CS-Native Stack

- **Standard Lighting Templates - SLT** (Nexus) — Standardized light template records. Replaces the per-cell template work that Lux/ELFX normally do. Foundation layer.
- **CS Light** (Nexus) — CS-native interior and exterior lighting.
- **True Light** (Nexus) — Exterior bulb placement via Light Placer.

Version pin: v3.4.1. v3.5.x has a known bug where ground illumination breaks on Lanterns of Skyrim II lampposts (lamps light up, ground stays dark). Do not upgrade until the fix is confirmed.

FOMOD: Select **Exterior mode** — attaches bulbs to exterior meshes (braziers, campfires, torches, lanterns) via Light Placer. This replaces Lux Orbis's exterior lighting role.

- **Window Shadows Ultimate (WSU)** (Nexus) — Interior shadowed windows.
- **Ambient Templates for Lighting Mods** (Nexus) — Required by the CS-native stack.

Configuration & Ambient

- **Based Lighting Configs** (Nexus) — CS lighting configuration presets. Standardizes tone/behavior across interiors and exteriors.
- **Dynamic Interior Ambient Lighting (DIAL)** (Nexus) — CS-native ambient template adjuster based on time of day and location.

Fire & Effects

- **Embers XD** (Nexus) — Fire-and-ember category answer (140K+ endorsements). Install after main lighting overhauls so it inherits campfire and hearth placements. → separator: Graphics - Lighting
- **Luminous Atronachs** (Nexus) — Self-illuminating flame/frost/storm atronachs via particle lights.

Alternatives

- **Relighting Skyrim SE** (Nexus) + **Luminosity Lighting Overhaul** (Nexus) — Lightest vanilla-plus route. Falls back if the CS-native stack fails compatibility testing.
- **ELFX Shadows** (Nexus) — Strong alternate if CS-native proves insufficient for interior mood. Hard-requires base Enhanced Lights and FX (Nexus).
- **iLuminous Elementals** (Nexus) — Broader elemental-light approach. Alternative to Luminous Atronachs.
- **Window Shadows RT - Updated** (Nexus) / **Ambiance** (Nexus) — Fallback interior shadow mods.

Notes

- The CS-native stack has ~35-55 total patches versus LUX's ~80-120 across the Patch Hub.
- CS Light + True Light + WSU relies on Light Placer non-shadow-casting bulbs — test together before locking.
- WSU can hit shadow-caster limits and flicker in certain interiors — monitor during playtesting.
- Very dark interiors look impressive in screenshots and feel worse in long play sessions.
- Choosing lighting before weather is settled can produce a mismatched visual tone.
- True Light author is doing a major rework — monitor for a post-v3.5.x fix for the LoS II lamp post bug.
- SLT provides template-level standardization; verify it does not conflict with CS Light's template expectations.

Weather & Water

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Weather & Water

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Weather & Water MO2 separator unless noted.

Weather And Atmosphere

Weather should be chosen as part of the Community Shaders presentation layer, not as an isolated plugin choice. The target is a grounded but modern visual tone that preserves forest, mountain, and travel readability in third person.

Primary candidates — test side-by-side:

Mod	Description	Nexus
NAT.CS III	Works on the conservative CS stack (no SSGI required).	Nexus
Azurite III CS	Requires the balanced CS add-on tier or higher (SSGI, Screen Space Shadows, Grass Lighting, Wetness Effects).	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Raid Weathers CS	Gameplay-clarity route. Requires base RAID Weathers.	Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
RAID Weathers (base)		Nexus
Vanilla Weathers for CS	Vanilla-plus CS-native. Has a True Storms patch.	Nexus
Obsidian Weathers	Fallback benchmark.	Nexus
Obsidian CS	Fallback benchmark.	Nexus
Cathedral Weathers	Fallback benchmark.	Nexus
Azurite Weathers III - Enhanced	Later tuning layer, not the first decision.	Nexus
Skydreamus CS Presets	Later tuning layer, not the first decision.	Nexus

Notes

- A weather setup that looks stunning in screenshots can flatten gameplay readability in forests, storms, or dusk travel.
- Overly aggressive fog, contrast, or dark nights work against third-person exploration and combat.
- Preset stacking makes the final visual chain harder to reason about if weather, CS options, and external presets all push tone differently.

Water Visuals

Treat water as a full visual stack: base water look, CS water features, mesh support, foam, waterfalls. Target: cold, readable, grounded water that holds up in motion during travel.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Water Effects - Community Shaders	Baseline shader feature layer. CS 1.5.2+ ships a Unified Water module — evaluate whether it replaces the need for a standalone water base.	Nexus
A Water Made For CS in mind	Primary base-water candidate.	Nexus
Splashes Of Skyrim	Baseline inclusion, not optional. SKSE plugin for water impact effects; CS 1.4.1+ includes FPS optimizations.	Nexus
Loki's Wade In Water	Water-interaction layer for wading. Mesh/anim replacer, no ESP.	Nexus

Alternatives

Evaluate these only after the main water base is selected.

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simplicity of Sea		Nexus
Color and Transparency Tweaks		Nexus
Realistic Water Two SE	Legacy baseline.	Nexus
Water for ENB	Legacy baseline.	Nexus
FYX - Water Mesh Optimization	Only add if it clearly improves shorelines or performance.	
Natural Waterfalls		Nexus
Rally's Water Foam		Nexus
Water Debris	Floating debris VFX.	Nexus
Underwater Bubbles - SKSE Plugin	No ESP, complements surface stack.	Nexus

Notes

- Water can look strong in still shots and distracting in motion if foam, reflections, or wave response are overdone.
- Water tone can clash with the chosen weather route.
- Mesh fixes and waterfall add-ons can help one setup and hurt another.

Sky, Stars, And Auroras

The cosmic visual layer: night-sky stars, aurora rendering, sky-dome enhancements. Kept separate from weather because sky-dome work is about clear-night rendering and long-horizon reads, not precipitation and overcast coverage.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
AURORA S.E.	Adds proper northern-lights rendering. Genuinely upgrades the night vista without bloating the weather or lighting layer.	Nexus

Keep the discipline-first route alive if the weather mod's bundled star/sky textures already read well. Defer a full sky-dome overhaul if playtesting shows the night sky needs more investment.

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Rally's Celestial Canvas	Complete night-sky overhaul: auroras, galaxy, stars, constellations. Hand-drawn (8K galaxy, 4K stars).	Nexus
Realistic Galaxy	Galaxy texture replacer.	Nexus
Ultra Hi-Res Nightsky	Hubble-imagery galaxy, up to 16K.	Nexus
Worlds Behind Glass	High-res night sky for telescope mods.	Nexus

Notes

- Aurora mods can look out of place in non-northern settings; verify southern holds.
- Sky-dome edits can fight with weather mods that tweak the night sky. Give the aurora mod priority for night-sky changes.
- Strong auroras require a real night-darkness baseline from → [Performance](#); bright nights kill the aurora.

Terrain & Flora

MO2 Separator: [Graphics](#) → [Graphics](#) - [Terrain & Flora](#)

All mods in this section belong to the [Graphics](#) - [Terrain & Flora](#) MO2 separator unless noted.

Terrain, Roads, And Snow

Treat terrain, roads, and snow as one connected presentation layer. Must stay coherent with Community Shaders, PBR support, rock meshes, weather, and later LOD generation.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Better Dynamic Snow SE	Snow-and-ash multistage accumulation. Works with Simplicity of Snow ; the BDSPatcher Synthesis patcher handles mod-added objects automatically.	Nexus
Better Dynamic Ash SE	Solstheim ash equivalent.	Nexus

Landscape And Terrain (candidate list — test and narrow)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyking Fantasia Landscapes		Nexus
Atlantean Landscape - Majestic Edition		Nexus
Atlantean Landscape - Complete - Complex Terrain Parallax		Nexus
A Cathedralist's PBR Landscape		Nexus
TomatoRim PBR Landscapes AIO		Nexus
Vanaheimr - Landscapes - AIO - Complex Material - PBR	PBR pipeline support. Evaluate alongside Cathedralist and TomatoRim.	Nexus
Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Complex Material and PBR	Primary mountain/rock identity. CS-native, no plugins, Complex Material support. Drop Majestic Mountains entirely (author inactive since June 2022, mesh misses snow coverage on rock piles).	Nexus
Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - Fix and Addon	Extends ERM to underground spaces and Whiterun Skyforge.	Nexus
Tomato's Complex Parallax Material Landscapes AIO - With DLCs	Older Tomato landscape release. TomatoRim PBR above is the newer version — evaluate which to use.	Nexus
Tomato's Whiterun Remake - PBR or Complex Material	Whiterun-specific terrain retexture.	Nexus
Seasonal Landscapes	Seasonal texture-swap system. Requires extensive patching — evaluate patch debt before locking.	Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Tomato's Whiterun Remake PBR - Seasonal Landscapes Patch	Required if both Whiterun Remake and Seasonal Landscapes are adopted.	Nexus

Roads

Mod	Description	Nexus
Blended Roads - Light Plugin (ESL)		Nexus
HD Remastered Blended Roads	HD hand-made rework. Choose 2K for performance, 4K for visual sweet spot. Requires Blended Roads base.	Nexus

Snow And Support

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simplicity of Snow		Nexus
Nordic Snow		Nexus
Nordic Snow - Complex Material		Nexus
Hyperborean Snow SE - 8K	Comparison candidate, not locked.	Nexus
Better Dynamic Snow SE	Multistage accumulation with terrain-blended coverage.	Nexus
Better Dynamic Ash SE	Solstheim ash equivalent.	Nexus
Enhanced Rocks and Mountains - CM and PBR	See Landscape section above; listed here for snow coherence.	Nexus

Notes

- Snow can look good in isolation and fail once mixed with mountains, roads, and weather-heavy scenes.
- Heavy terrain parallax can look impressive close up while adding artifact risk or visual noise in motion.

Flora Visuals

Flora is the ground-level readability layer between terrain materials and tree coverage. It should improve grass density, wildland texture, and plant variety without making traversal unreadable or creating constant patch work.

Grass

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skoglendi - A Grass Mod	Baseline grass.	Nexus
Merethic Grasslands	Variety enhancer; pairs with Skoglendi for northern grassland texture.	Nexus
Origins Of Forest - 3D Forest Grass	Density enhancer. Add only if forests feel too sparse after terrain and tree choices are locked.	Nexus

Plant Replacers

Mod	Description	Nexus
Mari's flora		Nexus
Freak's Floral Meadows	Meadow flower replacer. No ESP.	Nexus
Freak's Floral Solstheim	Solstheim ash-covered grass/flora replacer.	Nexus
A Nirnroot	Nirnroot mesh/texture replacer with glowing effects. No ESP.	Nexus
Flora Orientalis	Dependency for Vinland Grass Patch + mixed-route coverage.	Nexus
Waterplants	Dependency for Vinland Grass Patch + mixed-route coverage.	Nexus

3D Plant Replacers (mesh-only, no ESP)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Cathedral - 3D Plants (Clover, Deathbell, Dragons Tongue, Lavender, Thistle, Snow Berries)	Full Cathedral 3D series.	
Cathedral - 3D Stonecrop		Nexus
DrJacopo - 3D Tundra Shrubs		Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Cathedral PBR Plants	PBR texture layer for the Cathedral 3D series. Requires original Cathedral plants and PGPatcher.	Nexus
PBR Waterplants	PBR textures for underwater plants.	Nexus

Tree-Adjacent

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyfall's Sleeping Hist Tree Overhaul	Riften Sleeping Hist tree replacement. Mesh/texture only, no ESP.	Nexus
TMD The Rift Leaves	3D leaf particle replacer for The Rift. No ESP.	Nexus

Environment-Plant Extras (visual polish, not baseline)

Mod	Description	Nexus
High Quality Ivy Replacer - BOS	Replaces ivy meshes/textures. Animated/static via FOMOD. No performance cost.	Nexus
Grumbledook Swordferns - Optional PBR	New swordfern meshes/textures. Hard-requires BOS; PBR variant requires CS.	Nexus

Evaluate these after grass, 3D plant replacers, and tree choices are locked. Both layer via BOS (no cell-record edits).

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Folkvangr - Grass and Landscape Overhaul	Main heavier alternate.	Nexus
Vinland Grass Patch	Only after the final grass combination is narrow enough.	Nexus
QW's Grass Patch 2	Only after the final grass combination is narrow enough.	

Notes

- Grass that looks strong in screenshots can make traversal and combat readability worse.
- Layering multiple grass and plant mods creates real patch and cache maintenance cost.
- Forest-floor enhancers can become too dense once weather fog and heavy tree coverage are added.

Tree Overhauls For Dense Forests

Trees are the main large-scale world-shaping layer for wilderness mood, canopy silhouette, and perceived regional scale.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Traverse the Ulvenwald - 3.3	Main dense-forest candidate.	Nexus
Tomato's PBR Vanilla Trees	PBR tree texture option; can layer under whichever tree overhaul wins testing.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Happy Little Trees	Safer fallback baseline.	Nexus
Fabled Forests		Nexus
Nature of the Wild Lands	Compare only if Ulvenwald misses the right balance.	Nexus
Happy Little Trees PBR	Support signal.	Nexus
Fabled Forests - Ulvenwald Patch (BOS)	Support signal.	Nexus

Notes

- Dense tree overhauls can make roads, structures, and combat spaces harder to read in motion.
- Heavier worldspace tree edits create clipping, blocked sightlines, floating objects, and broad patch debt.
- A tree overhaul that looks excellent nearby can still fail if its distant silhouette is weak.

Characters & Creatures

MO2 Separator: Graphics → Graphics - Characters & Creatures

All mods in this section belong to the Graphics - Characters & Creatures MO2 separator unless noted.

Character, Skin, And Creature Visuals

Baseline visual treatment for player bodies, skin textures, and common creature visuals before NPC-specific overhauls are chosen. Target: grounded modern look that holds up in third person without drifting into overly glossy, doll-like, or hyper-stylized presentation.

Body Bases And Skins

🔧 **Install order:** CBBE → CBBE 3BA → HIMBO → RaceMenu → BnP skins → preset.

Female Body

- **CBBE NSFW (Nexus)** — Female body base.
- **CBBE 3BA (3BBB) (Nexus)** — Extension and preset ecosystem.
- **BnP - Female Skin (Nexus)** — Female skin textures.

Male Body

- **HIMBO (Nexus)** — Male body base.
- **BnP - Male Skin (Nexus)** — Male skin textures.

Character Creation

- **RaceMenu SE (Nexus)** — Character creation framework.
- **High Poly Head 1.4 SE** — Official Google Drive mirror: https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1V_jcYzwTiKnSv8Dbv-7Z0hh9SWbkn6Bi
 - If using, pair with **Expressive Facegen Morphs SE**, **Expressive Facial Animation -Female Edition-**, and **Expressive Facial Animation -Male Edition-**.
- **FitnessGoal CBBE 3BA Preset (Nexus)** — Chosen female preset.

Face Mesh Branch Notes

- **High Poly Head 1.4** still has current ecosystem support — used in Wabbajack compilations with a whitelisted Google Drive source.
- Treat it as a player-face and selective NPC-support branch, not a full beauty-overhaul stack.
- The strongest modern alternative (**Alternate High Poly Head**) still depends on the original HPH 1.4 package.
- Headpart mismatches, facegen conflicts, and vampire edge cases are still common — keep downstream patching documented in → **Performance**.

BodySlide And Outfit Studio Setup

- **BodySlide and Outfit Studio (Nexus)**
- Install as a normal mod in MO2.
- Register **BodySlide x64.exe** in MO2 as an executable.
- Create a dedicated **BodySlide Output** mod before generating anything.
- Keep **BodySlide Output** in the **Output** separator.
- Keep CBBE, CBBE 3BA, HIMBO, the chosen preset, and body-aware armor/outfit mods installed before building meshes.

Recommended Setup Order

1. Install CBBE NSFW
2. Install CBBE 3BA (3BBB)
3. Install HIMBO
4. Install BodySlide and Outfit Studio
5. Install FitnessGoal preset
6. Install OBody NG and all body-variety preset packs (before first BodySlide build)
7. Install selected skin textures (if the skin package expects a specific layout)
8. Install armor/clothing packs needing body refits (before first BodySlide build)
9. Add and enable the empty **BodySlide Output** mod before generating anything

BodySlide Configuration

- Run BodySlide through MO2, not from the game folder.
- Set output path to the dedicated **BodySlide Output** mod location.
- **Female meshes:** Select the **FitnessGoal CBBE 3BA 3BBB** preset (not plain CBBE).
- **Male meshes:** Choose the intended HIMBO preset before batch building.
- Use **Batch Build** once the baseline armor/clothing set is stable enough to avoid constant rebuilds.
- If multiple body variants appear, choose the option matching active CBBE 3BA and HIMBO ecosystems.
- Rebuild after installing or replacing major armor packs, outfit conversions, or body-shape presets.

3BA And Preset-Specific Notes

- The chosen female body path is CBBE NSFW + CBBE 3BA + FitnessGoal preset.
- Do not batch build female outfits against plain CBBE if the actual in-list preset requires 3BA/3BBB.
- When armor mods offer both CBBE and 3BA/3BBB options, choose 3BA/3BBB.
- Keep the female body stack consistent across base, preset, and outfit conversions.

Outfit Studio Guidance

- Treat Outfit Studio as the exception tool for fixing problem outfits, not a default for every armor.
- Use when a chosen armor/clothing mod does not match the active CBBE or HIMBO setup cleanly.
- Keep edited/converted outfit output separate from the original source mod.
- Document manual outfit fixes so future rebuilds don't depend on memory.

Body Variety And Distribution

Distributes different BodySlide presets across NPCs so the world doesn't look like everyone shares the same body shape.

Baseline

- **OBody NG** ([Nexus](#)) — Core distribution layer.
- **Real Body - 3BA (3BBB) CBBE Presets** ([Nexus](#)) — Curated semi-realistic 3BA presets for OBody distribution.
- **Realistic Racial Body Diversity - OBody NG Config** ([Nexus](#)) — Per-race body distribution (broader Nords, leaner Elves, heavy Orcs). Covers both CBBE 3BA and HIMBO.
- **Individual presets:** [Rugged Body - 3BA](#), [Skinny Berry - 3BA](#), [Realistic chubby and curvy body - 3BA](#).
- **Male variety:** [HIMBO SliderPresets Pack 02](#) ([Nexus](#)) — 10 presets.

Alternatives

- OBody NG is the only maintained OBody version that works with both OStim and standalone.
- Additional male presets: [The Common Guy - SerketHetyt's HIMBO Preset](#), [Greek God -- HIMBO Bodyslide Preset](#) (adult-content page; review before adding).

Notes

- OBody NG requires building all included presets in BodySlide with [Create Morphs](#) ticked — larger batch build.
- Every additional preset pack increases BodySlide build time. Keep pack size intentional.
- OBody NG works with CBBE 3BA and HIMBO but may need config adjustment for other body mods.
- FitnessGoal preset remains the player-character default; OBody distributes additional presets to NPCs only.

Clothing And Armor Texture Upgrades

- **Immersive Fur Garments** ([Nexus](#)) — New fur garments to leveled lists.
- **Immersive Fur Garments - SPID** ([Nexus](#)) — SPID distribution addon (ESL-flagged). Install base mod (meshes/textures only, delete .esp) + SPID addon.
- **Faultier's PBR Armors and Clothes** ([Nexus](#), 2.9 GB) — Complete PBR retexture of all vanilla armors, weapons, clothes. Requires Community Shaders and PGPatcher.
- **RUSTIC CLOTHING - Special Edition** ([Nexus](#)) — Higher-res clothing textures. Test for style consistency.
- **Dwemer Armors and Weapons Retexture SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Gear-side companion to VPBR's Dwemer ruin textures.
- **Steel Armor Redone - PBR and Complex Material** ([Nexus](#)) — PBR retexture of CC Steel Armor. Requires CC Alternative Armors - Steel Soldier, Community Shaders, PGPatcher. Optional.
- **Robes Retexture SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Higher-quality robe textures for all vanilla robes.
- **Divine Crusader Retexture SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Retexture of the Divine Crusader armor set.
- **Nirn Necessities - SMP Accessories** ([Nexus](#)) — SMP-physics clothing accessories. Install base mod; add the PBR patch ([Nexus](#)) if using CS PBR.

Recommended Creature Baseline

- **Bellyaches Animal and Creature Pack SSE** ([Nexus](#))

General Notes

- Body-base choices create a large armor-refit and outfit-conversion workload later.
- Choosing 3BA/3BBB increases female outfit compatibility requirements versus plain CBBE.
- Letting BodySlide output overwrite source mods makes auditing and rebuilds much harder.
- Skin mods that look strong in screenshots can still appear too polished or glossy in gameplay lighting.
- High Poly Head 1.4 adds headpart and facegen complexity with vampire fixes, NPC overhauls, and custom presets.
- Do not let this section expand into full NPC beautification — that belongs in → [NPCs](#).

Hair, Eyes, And Beards

Per-character face assets: hairstyles, eye textures, and beard options. Ensures character close-ups match the grim-dark tone without pulling in full NPC face-gen overhauls.

Baseline

- **KS Hairdos SSE (Nexus)** — Community-canonical hair pack (141K endorsements).
- **Eyes Nouveaux (Nexus)** — Khisartin-style eye textures fitting grim-dark tone.
- **LDD Clean Cubemap for Eyes 4K (Nexus)** — Cleaner eye cubemap textures. Stacks on top of eye-texture baseline.
- Keep the beard decision minimal; vanilla beards work well with the chosen body and face mesh stack.

Alternatives

- **The Eyes Of Beauty SSE (Nexus)** — Long-standing community-standard alternative to Eyes Nouveaux.
- Discipline-first route: rely on vanilla hair and eye textures entirely.

Notes

- High-poly hair can clash with extreme lighting/shadow setups; verify KS Hairdos works with the CS-native lighting stack.
- Eye textures that lean too stylized look out of place; pick a realistic pack matching grim-dark.
- Hair assets are common in NPC-overhaul conflicts; check for hair-distribution patches when → **NPCs** is active.
- Adding a beard pack without testing creates obvious neck clipping under most lighting.

Skeleton And Bone Replacers

Visual upgrades to in-world skeleton and bone assets: skulls, bone piles, skeleton models in dungeons, Nordic ruins, draugr crypts, dragon priest rooms. Kept separate from the rigged skeleton baseline in → **Animations**.

Baseline

- **Skeleton Replacer HD - SE (Nexus)** — High-resolution skeleton/bone models and textures. Choose the **2K** main file — skeletons are medium-scale clutter, not hero assets; 4K is wasted VRAM.
- **Skeleton Replacer HD - Mesh Patches for Various Mods (Nexus)** — Add only if the modlist includes a creature/content mod needing a mesh patch.

Alternatives

- Discipline-first: rely on vanilla skeleton assets and skip the replacer entirely (most skeleton models are seen briefly during dungeon traversal).

Notes

- Skeleton Replacer HD can conflict with creature mods that ship their own skeleton/bone assets.
- Some vanilla draugr and dragon priest models have unique assets the mod can override; verify they're preserved.
- High-resolution bones can look out of place in a dungeon without matching texture work.

LOD & Distant Detail

MO2 Separator: **Graphics** → **Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail**

All items in this section belong to the **Graphics - LOD & Distant Detail** MO2 separator unless noted.

LOD Generation And Distant Detail

Distant detail determines whether **Elder Wilds** feels large and coherent during travel instead of collapsing into obvious pop-in and flat backgrounds.

Baseline

- **DynDOLOD**-based distant detail is the assumed standard.
- Use the balanced route: strong object and tree LOD quality with targeted support mods.
- Add support mods only where they visibly improve the chosen tree and texture stack.
- Judge distant detail from actual travel routes, mountain overlooks, and city approaches — not static showcase shots.

Required Tools And Dependencies

Core Support Mods

- **DynDOLOD Resources SE 3 (Nexus)**
- **DynDOLOD DLL NG (Nexus)**

Optional Distant Detail Support

- **HD LODs Textures SE (Nexus)**

- **Skyfall's Sleeping Hist Tree Overhaul - DynDOLOD Add-On** ([Nexus](#)) — Billboard generation for the replaced tree. Required for correct distant-LOD display.
- **Happy Little Trees DynDOLOD Optimizations** ([Nexus](#))

Core Workflow Dependencies

- **No Grass In Objects** ([Nexus](#))
- **Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script** ([Nexus](#))
- **Grass Cache Fixes** ([Nexus](#))
- **xLODGen Resource - SSE Terrain Tamriel** ([Nexus](#))

Build Order And Configuration

Setup

- Install [DynDOLOD Resources SE 3](#) and [DynDOLOD DLL NG](#) as normal mods in MO2.
- Install [No Grass In Objects](#), [Grass Cache Fixes](#), and [xLODGen Resource](#) as support content.
- Register **TexGen**, **DynDOLOD**, and **xLODGen** as MO2 executables, not mixed into mod folders.
- Treat occlusion as generated output, not as a separate mod pick.

Dedicated MO2 Output Mods (create before generation)

Output Folder	Purpose
Grass Cache Output	Generated grass cache
Terrain LOD Output	xLODGen terrain output
TexGen Output	Generated billboards
DynDOLOD Output	DynDOLOD output
Occlusion Output	Occlusion data

Keep generated outputs in the [Output](#) separator. Do not generate final outputs until tree, terrain, snow, flora, and large worldspace picks are mostly stable.

Run Order

1. Confirm load order and conflict resolution first.
2. Generate grass cache (No Grass In Objects workflow).
3. Install/update [Grass Cache Output](#).
4. Run **xLODGen** for terrain LOD (once terrain and snow are stable).
5. Install/update [Terrain LOD Output](#).
6. Run **TexGen**.
7. Install/update [TexGen Output](#).
8. Run **DynDOLOD**.
9. Install/update [DynDOLOD Output](#).
10. Generate **occlusion data** near the end, keep in [Occlusion Output](#).

Re-run relevant generated layers when a major tree overhaul, architecture change, landscape shift, grass change, or LOD-relevant texture pack is replaced.

Recommended Starting DynDOLOD Configuration

- **First-pass preset: High** — start here even if the setup is graphics-heavy. Move above only after checking travel performance and distant coherence.
- Generate both object and tree LOD on the first real pass to judge forest silhouette quality early.
- Keep large-reference and ultra-aggressive options off for the first pass.
- First-pass questions: do distant trees match the overhaul? Do mountain/road/city approach views feel coherent? Is performance acceptable in real travel?
- If using **Happy Little Trees**, test baseline output first, then compare DynDOLOD Optimizations.
- If using heavier tree overhauls (**Ulvenwald**, **Fabled Forests**, **Nature of the Wild Lands**), prioritize clean transitions and stable horizons before longer range.

Baseline Starting Profile For Elder Wilds

- **Preset:** High
- **Quality target:** Balanced object and tree LOD with stable travel performance
- **First-pass goal:** Believable distant forests, readable city approaches, clean mountain silhouettes
- Keep optional LOD texture upgrades and tree-specific optimization mods disabled at first

Grass Cache And Occlusion

- Use No Grass In Objects only after the main grass/flora direction is narrow enough that cache generation isn't immediately obsolete.
- Keep Grass Cache Fixes as part of the serious grass-cache path.

- Use Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script if the final setup needs tailored worldspace grass support.
- Treat grass cache as invalid whenever the winning grass combination, landscape coverage, or major worldspace edits change materially.
- Regenerate occlusion near the end of a major graphics pass, after grass, terrain LOD, and DynDOLOD inputs are stable.
- Keep occlusion output separate from all other generated mods for easy identification and replacement.

Validation

- No missing distant objects, giant billboard errors, or broken tree lines
- Near and far tree silhouettes transition cleanly during normal travel
- City approaches, mountain overlooks, and forest horizons look coherent under selected weather/lighting
- Generated outputs are enabled in MO2 and load after source mods
- Old generated outputs are replaced when the visual stack changes, not left active by accident

Notes

- Strong near-field visuals can still look broken in motion if distant terrain and tree lines don't match.
- Optional LOD texture and tree-optimization add-ons create extra maintenance for limited payoff.
- Generating too early produces stale outputs that quietly poison later comparisons.
- Partial rebuild habits leave mismatched terrain, tree, and occlusion outputs active simultaneously.

Rebuild Rules

- **Grass cache:** Rebuild if grass baseline, major flora layering, or worldspace edits change.
- **Terrain LOD:** Rebuild if landscape, snow, mountain, or terrain-color direction changes.
- **TexGen + DynDOLOD:** Rebuild if tree overhauls, large architecture, major LOD-support mods, or visual worldspace edits change.
- **Occlusion:** Refresh when major worldspace edits or the distant-detail pass changes enough to affect visibility/culling.
- If multiple major visual categories change together, prefer a clean full rebuild over partial guesswork.

Modernized UI

MO2 Separators: [UI - Framework & HUD](#), [UI - Inventory & Items](#), [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

All mods in this section belong to one of the three UI separators as noted per subsection.

UI Framework Prerequisites → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

The base menu and interface framework the rest of the UI stack builds on.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
SkyUI	Non-negotiable baseline.	Nexus
Oathvein UI	Locked visual direction. Grim-dark presentation matches the project tone; cleaner dependency chain than Norden UI.	Nexus
UIExtensions	Support infrastructure, not competing UI identity.	Nexus
Constructible Object Custom Keyword System (COCKS)	Crafting-menu category infrastructure.	Nexus
MCM Helper	Persists MCM settings across saves. Hard dependency of TDM, CNO, and others.	Nexus
Stay At The System Page NG	Keeps System page open after loading a save. Most noticeable on gamepad.	Nexus
ImGui Icons	Icon font resource for ImGui-based mods (Dialogue History, etc.).	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Norden UI	Modern-rustic by Nithog, but depends on Extended UI (no official SE port).	Nexus
Vel'dun UI	Dunmer-themed by Nithog; too narrow a fit for Elder Wilds.	Nexus
Prisma UI	Web-UI framework replacing SkyUI. Incompatible with Oathvein UI and UIExtensions mods.	Nexus

HUD Overhaul → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Health, stamina, magicka, target readability, and permanent interface structure during ordinary play.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
SkyHUD	Baseline layout framework: widget positioning, visibility, style consistency.	Nexus
TrueHUD	Combat-feedback: actor info bars, boss bars, player widgets, recent-loot logging. Same author as TDM.	Nexus
Casting Bar	Cast/draw timing for spells, shouts, and bow draw.	Nexus
Floating Damage	Optional combat-feedback overlay. Install only after confirming acceptable visual noise.	Nexus
QuickLoot IE	Container/corpses loot window on interact. Improved controller support, third-person readability. FOMOD with placement presets.	Nexus
Oxygen Meter 2	Breath meter when underwater. Configurable position/opacity.	Nexus
Oxygen Meter 2 - Lung Shaped	Cosmetic lung-shaped icon.	Nexus
Oxygen Meter 2 - Fixes and Additions	Bugfixes and feature tweaks.	Nexus
Detection Meter	Stealth detection meter. Pairs with RAID.	Nexus
Detection Meter - AE Support	Required for 1.6.1170.	Nexus
STB Widgets	Lightweight modular widgets (clock, time, compass-free direction, stat bars). SKSE + MCM.	Nexus
Follower Stats	MCM-based follower stat tracking. Pairs with Nether's.	Nexus
Tween Menu Overhaul Improved	Main-menu and loading-screen visual overhaul. Updated version with additional scenes.	Nexus
RUMINATE - Frost and Snow - Main Menu Video Pack	Frost-and-snow themed main menu cinematic.	Nexus
Skeuomorphism of Skyrim - Immersive Plaque Reading Interface	3D in-world plaque model. Requires BOS. ESL-flagged.	Nexus
Dynamic Location Pop-ups	Location discovery notification banner.	Nexus
Complete Controller Setup	SKSE-based controller config: remapping, radial-menus, camera profiles for gamepad.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Stats Tracker Menu - STM	Brand new (May 2026), very low community signal. Test before locking.	Nexus

Inventory And Item Card Improvements → separator: **UI - Inventory & Items**

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
moreHUD SE	Mandatory. Broader item-information layer.	Nexus
moreHUD Inventory Edition	Mandatory. Extends readability into inventory views.	Nexus
Inventory Interface Information Injector	Value/weight/stat-per-weight columns. Same author as moreHUD.	Nexus
I4 Weapon Icons Overhaul	30+ weapon category icons. Depends on I4.	Nexus
I4 Armor Icons Overhaul		Nexus
I4 Shout Icons Overhaul		Nexus
The Handy Icon Collection Collective (THICC)	Thousands of high-fidelity icons. Additive to I4 family.	Nexus
Favorites Menu Effects Description	Effect descriptions in favorites menu. SKSE plugin, no ESP. Essential for gamepad.	Nexus
B.O.O.B.I.E.S (aka Immersive Icons)	Icon overhaul for SkyUI. 28K+ endorsements. FOMOD: 2K recommended.	Nexus
B.O.O.B.I.E.S - POTIONS	Dedicated potion bottle icons.	Nexus
P.E.N.I.S. for B.O.O.B.I.E.S.	Ingredient icon pack.	Nexus
A.S.S. for B.O.O.B.I.E.S.	Food & drink icon pack.	Nexus
Rotols More Icons	Additional coverage for items B.O.O.B.I.E.S doesn't cover.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
SkyUI Item Card Fixes	Cleaner item-card presentation.	Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Aura's Inventory Tweaks	Stronger sorting and icon structure.	Nexus
Weapon Stat Viewer V2	Weapon-stat overlay. Lock only if rendered cleanly.	Nexus
Enchanted Icon Overhaul	Depends on Dynamic Inventory Icon Injector.	Nexus
Dynamic Inventory Icon Injector		Nexus

Map Improvements → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Flat World Map Framework (FWMF)	Non-negotiable map foundation.	Nexus
Local Map Upgrade	Local-map for interior/close-range navigation.	Nexus
Skyrim and Solstheim Paper Maps by Mirhayasu for FWMF	Strongest first-pass paper-map art.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Nexus
Immersive Paper Map (3rd Edition)	Nexus
Skyrim Paper Map by FreelanceCartography for FWMF	Nexus
Legendary Map	Nexus
HD Local Map	Nexus

Magic And Journal Improvements → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Convenient Reading UI - SE	Reading comfort for normal play.	Nexus
Wider MCM Menu for SkyUI	Support fix for cramped config menus.	Nexus
Modern Wait Menu	Clock-face interface showing time, weather preview. Gamepad-friendly. SKSE plugin, no ESP.	Nexus
Completionist - Skyrim Completion Tracker (NG)	MCM-based quest/item/location/book/shout completion tracker. Run the Automated GUI Patcher.	Nexus
Completionist Addons	Mod-added content tracking.	Nexus
Quest Journal Overhaul	Journal UI redesign with quest tracking improvements.	Nexus
Quest Journal Overhaul - Unofficial Mods Support	Extended mod support patch. Install after the main QJO.	Nexus

Dialogue UI Improvements → separator: UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Better Dialogue Controls	First-pass dialogue friction fix.	Nexus
Better MessageBox Controls	Same for message boxes.	Nexus
Dialogue History	Scrollable dialogue log. Essential for gamepad.	Nexus
Improved Alternate Conversation Camera	Dialogue camera baseline. Test for CS letterbox conflict.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Dialogue Interface ReShaped	Visual dialogue flow.	Nexus
Convenient Dialogue UI - SE		Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Smart Talk (Dialogue Menu Enhancer)	Highlights quest options, reorders choices, gamepad-friendly skip. 5.5K endorsements.	Nexus

Controller-Friendly UI Support → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyrim SE Controller Interface Fix		Nexus
Show Player In Menus	Renders player character in menus for gear previews. Essential for third-person parity.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Gamepad Plus Plus	Broader controller-input answer.	Nexus
Wheeler - Quick Action Wheel	Radial interaction layer.	Nexus
WHEELER - Refined	Updated visuals, better controller support.	Nexus

UI Scaling For Ultrawide And High Resolution → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer	Text readability for 16:9 4K HDR. Prefer Bold V8.9 first.	Nexus
Complete Widescreen Fix	Secondary for ultrawide layouts.	Nexus

Compass, Markers, And Minimal HUD → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Compass Navigation Overhaul	First-pass navigational layer.	Nexus
CoMAP - Common Marker Addon Project	Marker consistency across the FWMF ecosystem.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Immersive HUD - iHUD SE	Minimal-HUD branch.	Nexus
MiniMap	Very optional. Last updated May 2021; occasional crash reports on 1.6.1170.	Nexus

Crafting Menu Improvements → separator: [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Mod	Description	Nexus
COCKS	See Framework Prerequisites above. Directly improves the Constructible Object Menu.	Nexus
SkyUI - Vanilla Crafting menu	Fallback for vanilla-style split categories.	Nexus

Loading Screens → separator: [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Elder Scrolls Legends - Loading Screens	Locked baseline. 110 lore-friendly Legends artworks. Install at 100% frequency in 16:9 with Fixed Height border. At 100% frequency, vanilla lore tips are suppressed.	Nexus

Optional HUD → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Mod	Description	Nexus
Skyrim Party Sheet - Follower and Player HUD	Persistent overlay for player attributes and follower info. v2.7 (June 2026). Research before installing — verify no conflicts with TrueHUD, Oathvein, or Nether's.	Nexus

Candidate TODO Additions

Framework & System UI → separator: [UI - Framework & HUD](#)

Mod	Nexus
Character Menu SE	
Kill feed	Nexus
SKSE Menu Framework	Nexus
Auto Input Switch	Nexus

Inventory → separator: [UI - Inventory & Items](#)

Mod	Nexus
Unread books glow redone	Nexus
Show Player In Inventory	Nexus

HUD, Map & Dialogue → separator: [UI - Map, Dialogue, Menus](#)

Mod	Nexus
Pastel Map Markers	
Smart Talk (Dialogue Menu Enhancer)	Nexus
Even Better Quest Objectives SE	Nexus

Animations and Movement

MO2 Separators: [Animations - Framework](#), [Animations - Movement & Idles](#), [Animations - Combat](#), [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#), [Animations - Creatures](#)

All mods in this section belong to one of the five animation separators as noted per subsection.

Pandora Framework And Prerequisites → separator: [Animations - Framework](#)

Baseline

- **Pandora Behaviour Engine Plus** ([Nexus](#)) — Single behavior-generation owner. Register as MO2 executable; output to dedicated [Pandora Output](#) mod.
- **Universal Behaviour Runtime - Auto Skeleton Patch** ([Nexus](#)) — Runtime skeleton patching for XPMSSSE. Do NOT tick Pandora XPMSSSE patch checkbox.
- **A-Pose Bug Fix - Universal Behavior Runtime** ([Nexus](#)) — Runtime A-pose interception and LE animation backward compatibility.

Notes

- Validate current Pandora install guide and requirements tab during setup.
- Leaving old generated output active or mixing generators makes debugging much harder.

Skeleton And Behavior Prerequisites → separator: [Animations - Framework](#)

Baseline

- **XP32 Maximum Skeleton Special Extended - XPMSSSE** ([Nexus](#)) — Single skeleton baseline.
- **CBPC - Physics with Collisions** ([Nexus](#)) — Default first-pass physics for CBBE 3BA.
- **FSMP - Faster HDT-SMP** ([Nexus](#)) — SMP coverage alongside CBPC. Required by OStim and some outfits.

Alternatives

- **XPMSSSE Fixed Scripts** ([Nexus](#)) — Companion script fix over XPMSSSE.
- **ConsoleUtilISSE NG** ([Nexus](#)) — Keep available for script-dependent pieces.

Parkour, Climbing, And Free-Form Movement → separator: [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Baseline

- **SkyParkour v3 - Procedural Parkour and Climbing Framework (SPPF)** ([Nexus](#)) — Vault, climb, traverse environmental geometry. 10,112 endorsements.

Slope And Terrain Animation

- **EVG CLAMBER - Slope Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Character posture adjusts dynamically on slopes and stairs. Complements SkyParkour for terrain-aware traversal.
- **Feminine EVG Clamber Stair Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Female-specific stair animations for EVG CLAMBER.

Alternatives

- **SkyClimb** ([Nexus](#)) — Climbing-first alternative built around EVGAT. Pick one (not cumulative with SkyParkour).
- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla climbing + TDM + sprint/jump only.

Companion Candidates (evaluate after baseline is locked)

- **Beam Walking Assist** ([Nexus](#))
- **RaySense - Jumping over obstacles** ([Nexus](#))
- **RaySense - Edge Lookdown** ([Nexus](#))
- **Inertia - Physical Movement Response System** ([Nexus](#))

Notes

- SkyClimb and SkyParkour are competing — not harmless companions.
- Parkour can expose navmesh gaps in older worldspaces.
- This subsection owns vertical/lateral movement; dodge, sprint, and camera belong in → [Third-Person](#).

Locomotion → separator: [Animations - Movement & Idles](#)

Baseline

- **Leviathan Animations II - Male Idle Walk And Run** ([Nexus](#))
- **Leviathan Animations II - Female Idle Walk And Run** ([Nexus](#))

Alternatives

- **Vanargand Animations II - Male Idle Walk And Run** ([Nexus](#)) — Main male alternative.
- **Conditional Armor Type Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Add after base locomotion is accepted.
- **Dynamic Female Weather Idles** ([Nexus](#)) — OAR-based weather-aware idles. Complements survival/weather stack.
- **EVG Animated Traversal** ([Nexus](#)) — Belongs in interaction/traversal bucket.
- **Goetia Animations** — Female ([Nexus](#)) / Male ([Nexus](#))

Combat Animation Packs → separator: [Animations - Combat](#)

Baseline

- **Precision - Accurate Melee Collisions** ([Nexus](#))
- **SCAR - Skyrim Combos AI Revolution** ([Nexus](#)) — Add after Precision is proven.
- **Animated Armoury - OAR** ([Nexus](#)) — 12 new weapon types. Requires **Animated Armoury - DAR Version** ([Nexus](#)) for meshes/collision/leveled lists. Install DAR first, then OAR overlay. Run Pandora after.
- **No Spinning Death Animation LITE** ([Nexus](#))

High-Commitment Route (evaluate later)

- **MCO ADXP - Modern Movement Combat Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — System-level decision.
- **Animation Motion Revolution** ([Nexus](#)) and **Payload Interpreter** ([Nexus](#)) — Required MCO support.

Support

- **IFrame Generator RE AE Support** ([Nexus](#)) — Install only when a pack explicitly lists it.

Non-Combat Interaction Animations → separator: [Animations - Interactions & Traversal](#)

Baseline

- **Immersive Interactions - Animated Actions** ([Nexus](#))
- **Go to bed** ([Nexus](#))

Alternatives

- **Animated Interactions SKSE** ([Nexus](#)) — Can coexist only if overlapping actions are deliberately disabled.
- **Take a Seat** ([Nexus](#))
- **Immersive Hunting Animations** ([Nexus](#))
- **Immersive Carcass Carrying** ([Nexus](#))
- **Flute Animation Fix** ([Nexus](#))

- **Witcher Flute** ([Nexus](#))
- **EVG Animated Traversal** ([Nexus](#))
- **Beginner Bard Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — For Skyrim's Got Talent.

Interaction Animation Additions (II companions)

- **Immersive Interactions - Eating ingredients and apply poison animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Add-on for the Immersive Interactions baseline. Adds eating and poison-apply animations.
- **Dynamic Crafting Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Crafting-station interaction animations.
- **Dynamic Looting and Harvesting Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Looting and harvesting interaction animations.
- **Dynamic Horse Petting Animations for Immersive Interactions** ([Nexus](#)) — Horse interaction animations for II.

Conditional Animation Systems → separator: Animations - Framework

Baseline

- **Open Animation Replacer** ([Nexus](#)) — Single condition framework owner.

Alternatives

- **EVG Conditional Idles** ([Nexus](#))
- **Conditional Armor Type Animations** ([Nexus](#))
- **Unique Jarl Throne Sitting Animation (OAR)** ([Nexus](#))

Camera-Aware Animation Support → separator: Animations - Framework

- **Improved Camera SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Only if hybrid perspective is a real playstyle.
- **Comprehensive First Person Animation Overhaul - CFPAO** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional first-person polish.

Equipment Display Framework → separator: Animations - Framework

Equipment visibility, sheathing positions, and draw-sheathe animations. Builds on XPMSE for third-person gamepad parity.

Baseline

- **Immersive Equipment Displays (IED)** ([Nexus](#)) — Equipment visibility and positioning framework. Required by display addons below.
- **Simple Dual Sheath** ([Nexus](#)) — Dual-sheathed weapon support. Requires IED.

Addons

- **Weapon Styles - Draw-Sheathe animations for IED** ([Nexus](#)) — Conditional draw/sheathe animations per weapon type. Requires IED.
- **Walking Stick - Walk with staves or polearms - IED-OAR** ([Nexus](#)) — Staff/polearm walking animation support. Requires IED.

Alternatives

- **Ready to Play IED** ([Nexus](#)) — Pre-configured IED preset. Evaluate only if manual IED configuration proves too time-consuming.

Creature Animations → separator: Animations - Creatures

Baseline

- **New Creature Animation - Giant** ([Nexus](#))
- **New Creature Animation - Werewolf** ([Nexus](#))
- **New Creature Animation - Falmer** ([Nexus](#))
- **DCA - Dragon Combat Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — Dragon combat animation replacer.
- **Draugr Greatsword Animation** ([Nexus](#)) — Greatsword-wielding draugr animation replacer.

Notes

- Validate per-pack combat-animation support individually. Keep layer small and intentional.

Animation Conflict Management → separator: Animations - Framework

Strict ownership: one clear owner per layer.

Owners

- **Behavior generation:** Pandora only
- **Skeleton:** XPMSE only

- **Conditional selection:** Open Animation Replacer only

Workflow

- Keep Pandora output isolated in dedicated MO2 output mod.
- Record which mods rely on generation, which on OAR, and which are pure presentation.
- Test in repeatable scenarios: town walking, idle downtime, dungeon corridors, uneven outdoor combat, interaction-heavy interiors, creature encounters.

Notes

- Animation conflicts look like camera, combat, or skeleton bugs until ownership is checked.
- Mixed generated output hides whether a problem is from load order or stale behavior files.

Candidate TODO Additions

Idles & Expressions → separator: Animations - Movement & Idles

- Poses, Actions and Musical
- More Tavern Idls - Immersive
- Headtracking and Emotions

Combat Animation → separator: Animations - Combat

- Smooth block animation
- Weapon Trails
- Killmove fixes
- Goetia Animations - Magic Spell Casting (Nexus)
- Diverse NPC Movesets (Nexus) — Varied combat stances via SCAR/OAR.

Movement & Parkour → separator: Animations - Interactions & Traversal

- Smooth Jump animation
- Just Shields on your back / Weapons on Back AiO
- Walk Speed Tuner
- Dova Jump (Nexus)

Creature Animation → separator: Animations - Creatures

- Troll - MCO (Nexus)

Third-Person Gameplay

MO2 Separators: Third-Person - Camera & Movement, Third-Person - Combat & Targeting, Third-Person - Mounted

All mods in this section belong to one of the three third-person separators as noted per subsection.

Third-Person Camera Framework → separator: Third-Person - Camera & Movement

Baseline

- **SmoothCam** (Nexus) — Main third-person camera framework.

Alternatives

- **Customizable Camera** (Nexus) — Leaner fallback.
- **True Directional Movement** (Nexus) — Governs movement/targeting, not the camera framework itself.
- **Improved Camera SE** (Nexus) — Perspective support, not main third-person framework.

Notes

- A good preset can hide weak camera behavior — judge the framework, not the preset.
- Over-tuned cameras look impressive in clips but become tiring.

Camera Presets And Shoulder Switching → separator: Third-Person - Camera & Movement

Restrained centered-to-light-offset baseline. Shoulder switching is a support feature for visibility problems, not the main camera identity.

Notes

- Aggressive over-the-shoulder framing creates visibility issues in interiors and dungeons.

- Shoulder switching that feels mandatory too often = poor baseline framing.

True Directional Movement → separator: **Third-Person - Camera & Movement**

- **True Directional Movement - Modernized Third Person Gameplay** (Nexus) — Modern 360-degree character-relative movement.
- Core value: freer facing, cleaner traversal, better animation-stack alignment.
- May feel awkward in tight interiors, stairs, or precision positioning.

Target Lock And Targeting Behavior → separator: **Third-Person - Combat & Targeting**

- **TDM** as the targeting-behavior owner. Keep lock-on restrained — optional combat-readability tool, not permanent default.
- **TrueHUD** (Nexus) — Optional feedback companion. Add only if testing shows material improvement.

Notes

- Weak target selection/switching makes even good camera and movement feel unreliable.
- TrueHUD can create illusion of a solved targeting system when the underlying behavior is still awkward.

Dodge, Sprint, And Movement Responsiveness → separator: **Third-Person - Camera & Movement**

Baseline

- **TK Dodge RE - Script Free** (Nexus) — First dodge candidate. Tactical repositioning, not combat pacing center.

Alternatives

- **TK Dodge SE** (Nexus) — Legacy fallback reference.
- **Dodge for all** (Nexus) — Newer (May 2026). Too early for baseline — low community signal.

Hit Reactions, Stagger, And Impact Feedback → separator: **Third-Person - Combat & Targeting**

- **Valhalla Combat** (Nexus) — Main gameplay-side comparison for hit feedback and stagger.
- **Precision** (from → Animations) — Adjacent support for contact feel.

Notes

- Too much stagger flattens combat; too little leaves animations unsatisfying.
- Camera, animation timing, collision, and gameplay rules all affect impact feel — ownership blurs quickly.

Third-Person Combat Systems → separator: **Third-Person - Combat & Targeting**

Balanced modern route: Valhalla Combat as the gameplay-rules framework. MCO ADXP as the ambitious alternative to compare against.

- **Valhalla Combat** — Gameplay-rule framework.
- **MCO ADXP - Modern Movement Combat Overhaul** (Nexus) — Ambitious alternative. Re-evaluate deliberately.
- **SCAR** (from → Animations) — NPC-side attack variety.

MCO Route Support (only if MCO is chosen)

- **Knockback SKSE** (Nexus)

Optional Additions

- **RaySense - Cover Animation** (Nexus)
- **Fire Ignites Arrows** (Nexus)
- **Poisoned Arrows and Bolts** (Nexus)
- **Variadic Collision Dynamics** (Nexus) — Runtime collision-capsule adjustments.
 - **Variadic Collision Dynamics - Resources** (Nexus) — Ready-to-use JSON presets.

Crosshair And Aiming Behavior → separator: **Third-Person - Combat & Targeting**

Disciplined aiming route: camera framing is the baseline aiming context.

- **Better Third Person Selection - BTPS** (Nexus) — Object-selection reliability.
- **TrueHUD** — Optional aiming readability aid.
- **Ricochet - Arrow Physics Framework** (Nexus) — Lock only if archery is a meaningful combat style.

Horse Camera And Mounted Controls → separator: **Third-Person - Mounted**

Baseline

- **Press H to Horse** (Nexus) — Actively maintained (May 2026). Few vanilla record edits.
- **Horses Simply Turn Better** (Nexus) — Free add-on. Sharpens turning radius for TDM.

Alternatives

- **Convenient Horses** (Nexus) — Last updated Jan 2022 (stale).
- **Simplest Horses** (Nexus) — Lightweight SPID+MCM drop-in.

Candidate TODO Additions

Combat → separator: **Third-Person - Combat & Targeting**

- **Eviscerate** — combat gore/dismemberment
- **Cinema - Dynamic Combat Letterbox**
- **Parry for All**
- **Deadly spell impact**

Mounted → separator: **Third-Person - Mounted**

- **HorsePower** - Modernized horse riding

Expanded Systems

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression, Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks, Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs, Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy, Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation

Overview

This section owns the gameplay systems that expand Skyrim beyond its 2011 baseline: character creation, progression, magic, perks, survival, crafting, economy, followers, and social systems. Each pillar of the Expanded Systems section lives in its own sub-file.

The system is designed to be evaluated in order — progression choices (races, standing stones, perks) come before magic, survival, crafting, and social systems that build on them.

Sub-Files

Area	File	Separator	Topics
Character & Progression	Character & Progression	Expanded Systems - Character & Progression	Alternate starts, races, standing stones, traits, religion, vampire/werewolf/shouts
Magic & Perks	Magic & Perks	Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks	Perk overhauls, magic expansion, stealth/detection
Survival & Needs	Survival & Needs	Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs	Survival frameworks, hygiene, death alternative
Crafting & Economy	Crafting & Economy	Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy	Alchemy, cooking, smithing, enchanting, economy, artifacts, weapons, armor, clothing
Followers & Reputation	Followers & Reputation	Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation	Crime/reputation, follower frameworks, romance/marriage

Key Principles

- Simonrim progression family (**Adamant**, **Mysticism**, **Thaumaturgy**, etc.) is the default baseline; EnaiRim (**Ordinator**, **Apocalypse**, etc.) is the high-expression branch → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression, Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks
- Survival, difficulty, and balance interactions across the full load order are owned by **modlist-survival-combat.md** → **Survival & Combat**
- All system choices must be evaluated for third-person gamepad usability and compatibility with the **Legacy of the Dragonborn** museum pillar → **Legacy of the Dragonborn**

Character & Progression

MO2 Separator: Expanded Systems → Expanded Systems - Character & Progression

All mods in this section belong to the **Expanded Systems - Character & Progression** MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the **Expanded Systems** section.

Character Creation And Starting Choices

How **Elder Wilds** begins: a grounded alternate start, a utility-first start, or a configurable route. The decision should improve replayability and roleplay expression without pre-answering later race, progression, religion, survival, or follower choices.

Baseline

- **Alternate Perspective - Alternate Start** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline candidate.
- **Dealing with Backstories** ([Nexus](#)) — Origins companion generating background-driven starting skills, bonuses, drawbacks, and gear.
- **Take Notes - Journal of the Dragonborn SSE** ([Nexus](#)) — Persistent in-game journal without rebalancing the character. Low-risk roleplay companion.
- **Roleplaying In Skyrim - Origins** ([Nexus](#)) — Optional origin-driven flavor and bonuses. Requires SKSE and [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#); soft-requires [Actor Value Generator](#) and [SkyUI](#).

Alternatives

- **Alternate Start - Live Another Life** ([Nexus](#)) — Conservative fallback.
- **Skyrim Unbound Reborn** ([Nexus](#)) — Configurable middle ground with more setup freedom.
- **Realm of Lorkhan - Freeform Alternate Start** ([Nexus](#)) — Freeform branch. Not the default baseline.

Notes

- Start frameworks carry world-state assumptions that ripple into later quest, city, survival, or follower decisions.
- [Dealing with Backstories](#) must be judged against the chosen race, standing-stone, perk, and survival stack.
- [Take Notes](#) only earns a slot if the list expects real roleplay or long-form journaling.
- A more immersive start loses value if it adds onboarding friction without materially improving the early-game tone.
- This subsection gets muddy if race, perk, religion, or survival decisions leak into it too early.

Race, Standing Stone, And Progression Overhauls

How strongly race traits and standing stones shape long-term character identity. Choose one clear progression philosophy before perks, magic, alchemy, and religion build on top of it.

Baseline

- **Aetherius - A Race Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) + **Evenstar - Minimalistic Standing Stones of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Balanced modern route.

Roleplaying in Skyrim Companion Series

All RiS mods require SKSE. Check individual mod pages for specific dependencies.

- **RiS - Classic Attributes** ([Nexus](#)) — 10 classic RPG attributes. Requires [Actor Value Generator](#).
- **RiS - Races** ([Nexus](#)) — Biological race overhaul. Requires [KID](#) and [SPID](#).
- **RiS - Lineages** ([Nexus](#)) — 4 subraces per vanilla race with unique abilities. Requires [KID](#), [SPID](#), and [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#).
- **RiS - Standing Stones** ([Nexus](#)) — 13 stones overhaul. Requires [aTweaks and Utilities](#), [KID](#), [Perk Entry Point Extender](#), and [SkyUI](#).
- **RiS - Birthsigns** ([Nexus](#)) — Monthly waxing/waning birthsign effects. Requires [KID](#) and [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#).
- **RiS - Useful MiscStats** ([Nexus](#)) — Misc stat progression layer. Requires [Actor Value Generator](#).
- **RiS - Skill Based Stat Growth** ([Nexus](#)) — Health/Magicka/Stamina grow as skills develop. Requires [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#).

Alternatives

- **Morningstar - Minimalistic Races of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) + **Evenstar** — Restrained fallback.
- **Imperious - Races of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) + **Andromeda - Unique Standing Stones** ([Nexus](#)) — High-expression comparison.

Notes

- Race and stone overhauls can quietly pre-decide too much of the character-building experience.
- A very expressive route can push optimization-heavy play even if the project wants immersive tone.
- A very light route can undershoot if later systems assume stronger identity hooks.
- Judge race and stone picks as a pair so the progression baseline stays coherent.

Character Traits And Identity Hooks

Opt-in character-defining quirks shaping a run from the start without replacing the broader progression stack. Goal: stronger roleplay identity and replayability, not a giant second character-build framework.

Baseline

- **Biggie Traits** ([Nexus](#)) — Immediate run-defining tradeoffs in compact form. Closer to Fallout-style traits than a total rules rewrite. No hard dependencies.
- **Pumping Iron - Dynamic Muscle Growth** ([Nexus](#)) — Cosmetic muscle growth based on combat skill increases and sleep. No gameplay impact.

Alternatives

- **Minimalist route** — Leave identity to race, standing stones, perks, and self-imposed roleplay.

Notes

- Trait systems can duplicate what race, perk, religion, or survival choices are already doing.
- If the best traits are too obviously optimal, the whole idea collapses into routine min-maxing.
- Traits should sharpen character identity and replayability, not replace the race-and-perk decisions above.

Religion Or Roleplay Systems

How much explicit spiritual identity and day-to-day roleplay texture [Elder Wilds](#) wants.

Baseline

- **Pilgrim - A Religion Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Fits the Simonrim-leaning progression family without making religion dominant.

Alternatives

- **Trua - Minimalistic Faiths of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Restrained fallback.
- **Wintersun - Faiths of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — High-expression route for stronger roleplay and progression pillar.

Notes

- A very light religion route can undershoot and leave roleplay identity too close to vanilla.
- A heavy deity-centered framework can make religion dominate character identity.
- Survival, economy, and follower expectations can drift into this section if faith routines aren't scoped carefully.
- Judge by ordinary play rhythm: prayer habits, shrine relevance, exploration texture.

Race-Specific Overhauls

Dedicated overhauls for vampire, werewolf, and shout gameplay — three character-identity systems vanilla leaves shallow. These complete the EnaiRim suite begun with [Andromeda](#) (standing stones). All three are by EnaiSiaion, designed to work together, and require no cross-patching.

Baseline

- **Sacrosanct - Vampires of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Vampirism progression, feeding, powers, 4 feeding tiers, blood-power effects keyed to vampiric age. 133K endorsements.
- **Growl - Werebeasts of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Beast-form progression, perks, feeding, 5 werebear varieties, dedicated perk tree.
- **Thunderchild - Epic Shouts and Immersion** ([Nexus](#)) — 19 new shouts (57 words), meditation mechanics, shout-aware equipment, boss encounters. Completes the EnaiRim character-systems suite.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla vampire/werewolf/shout systems. Hard to justify for a list built on "modern mechanics."

Notes

- All three are EnaiSiaion, designed to work with [Ordinator](#), [Andromeda](#), [Apocalypse](#), and the broader EnaiRim ecosystem by design.
- [Sacrosanct](#) and [Growl](#) interact with [Heart of the Beast](#) (werewolf transformation audio) in section 10. Load transformation-sfx after transformation-system mods.
- [Thunderchild](#)'s new shouts interact with shout-audio mods ([Airgetlam - Shouts SFX](#)) from section 10. Verify sfx replacements apply to Thunderchild's shouts, not just vanilla.
- Vampire feeding interacts with the crime-and-reputation baseline ([Skyrim Reputation](#) from → [Followers & Reputation](#)). Test feeding in cities.
- [Thunderchild](#)'s boss encounters may overlap with world-content mods from → [World Content](#).

Experience and Leveling

How the player gains levels and skill points. Instead of vanilla sleep-to-level, use Experience (discovery-based leveling) paired with Static Skill Leveling Rewritten (cooldown-gated skill advancement) for progression earned through exploration and deliberate practice.

Baseline

- **Experience** ([Nexus](#)) — Core leveling framework. Levels from exploration, quest completion, combat, discovery — not skill grinding.
 - **Experience - Synthesis Patcher** ([Nexus](#)) — Required patcher generating XP values for mod-added quests, locations, and enemies. Run during the patcher chain in → [Performance](#).
- **Experience - MCM** ([Nexus](#)) — MCM configuration for tuning XP rates, per-activity values, and per-source toggles.
- **Static Skill Leveling Rewritten** ([Nexus](#)) — Cooldown-based skill advancement. Encourages organic skill use over grind-spamming.
 - **Main file:** [Static Skill Leveling - ESL](#), ESL-flagged.
 - **Simpler Preset** ([Nexus](#)) — Recommended preset with tuned cooldown values.
- **No Startup Quest XP - Patch for Sunhelm and more** ([Nexus](#)) — Prevents XP from startup quests when using Experience + alternate start.

- **Skyshards (Nexus)** — 60+ glowing shards granting experience on collection. Tangible exploration reward for straying off the main path.
 - **Main file: Skyshards** (ESL-flagged version recommended).
 - **Skyshards - CS Light Addon (Nexus)** — Subtle emission glow for Community Shaders. → separator: **Graphics - Community Shaders**
 - **Skyshards - Keep it Moving (Nexus)** — Prevents collection notification from stopping movement. QoL for gamepad play.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla sleep-to-level. Avoids the patcher requirement but discards exploration-focused progression.
- **Static Skill Leveling - Custom Preset** — Use base mod without Simple Preset if manual tuning is preferred.

Notes

- Experience's Synthesis Patcher must be re-run whenever the load order changes.
- Static Skill Leveling's cooldown may feel restrictive; the Simple Preset mitigates this. Tune via .ini if needed.
- Skyshards placement may clip with city overhauls, new-lands mods, or landscape edits.
- All four mods are ESL-flagged or lightweight, adding minimal plugin pressure.

Magic & Perks

MO2 Separator: **Expanded Systems** → **Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks**

All mods in this section belong to the **Expanded Systems - Magic & Perks** MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the **Expanded Systems** section.

Perk Overhaul Compatibility

How much rules density and specialization pressure the list actually wants once race and standing-stone choices are in place.

Baseline

- **Adamant - A Perk Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Balanced modern route.

Alternatives

- **Vokrii - Minimalistic Perks of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Restrained comparison if **Adamant** feels too system-forward.
- **Ordinator - Perks of Skyrim (Nexus)** — High-complexity branch if perks should become a dominant source of build identity.

Notes

- A dense perk framework can dominate the character-building experience and make later systems feel secondary.
 - A restrained framework can make the list feel under-committed if other systems also land on the conservative side.
 - Compare perk candidates against the already-preferred race-and-stone direction so the full progression stack stays coherent.
-

Magic System Expansion

How broad, readable, and build-defining magic should feel once race, standing-stone, and perk baseline are in place.

Baseline

- **Mysticism - A Magic Overhaul (Nexus)** — Main baseline. Balanced modern route.
- **Triumvirate - Mage Archetypes (Nexus)** — Locked companion spell pack. Adds identity-driven archetype spells (Cleric, Druid, Shadow Mage, Shaman, Warlock) by EnaiSiaion. Each archetype is self-contained.
- **Strange Runes (Nexus)** — Locked magic-visual companion. Floating Nordic runes during spell charging. Zero gameplay impact, reads clearly in third-person. No record conflicts.

Alternatives

- **Odin - Skyrim Magic Overhaul (Nexus)** — Moderate expansion. Compare if **Mysticism** feels too restrained.
- **Apocalypse - Magic of Skyrim (Nexus)** — Maximum spell variety and magical experimentation.
- **Lost Grimoire SSE (Nexus)** — 115+ lore-friendly spells with matching scrolls and staves. Compatible with any primary overhaul.
- **Elemental Mastery Magic (Nexus)** — Elemental specialization and tiered mastery bonuses for Destruction/Alteration.
- **Immersive Illusion Spells (Nexus)** — New illusion types beyond fear/calm/frenzy.
- **360 Ward (Nexus)** — Wards block from any direction. Significant third-person gameplay improvement.
- **Sanguine Symphony (Nexus)** — Blood-magic spells costing Health instead of Magicka. Compatible with all primary overhauls.

Candidates

- **Revealing Rune (Nexus)** — Makes rune traps visible without a spell or perk. Gameplay quality-of-life. Evaluate after the primary magic overhaul is locked.

Notes

- A very large spell ecosystem can dominate progression and make race, perk, and religion feel secondary.
- Layering multiple spell packages casually turns this into a compatibility problem.
- **Mysticism** and **Odin** should be treated as competing primary overhauls, not a default combined baseline.
- Choose one primary magic overhaul first, then decide whether extra spell volume is actually needed.

Stealth And Detection

How Skyrim's detection system should be recalibrated for modern stealth mechanics without replacing the existing perk, magic, and combat layers.

Baseline

- **Realistic AI Detection (RAID)** ([Nexus](#)) — Detection-recalibration baseline. Script-free (23.8K endorsements). Recalibrates line of sight, lighting, distance, sneaking skill, and race detection without rewriting the AI itself.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Rely on the perk overhaul and targeted bugfix mods from → [Foundations](#) for detection.
- **Deferred high-commitment branch** — Add a full stealth toolkit only if playtesting proves detection still feels too forgiving or punishing.

Notes

- Detection recalibration can make encounter zones feel too easy or hard if it interacts with difficulty mods from → [Survival & Combat](#).
- A detection overhaul can make stealth-only play too dominant if it stacks with a perk overhaul that already buffs sneak.
- Detection changes can affect follower behavior; verify follower behavior under RAID with the chosen follower framework.
- **RAID** last updated April 2022 — script-free means less breakage risk, but verify detection feels right against the chosen perk overhaul.

Survival & Needs

MO2 Separator: [Expanded Systems](#) → [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#)

All mods in this section belong to the [Expanded Systems - Survival & Needs](#) MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](#) section.

Survival Systems

How much day-to-day bodily upkeep the list wants: enough hunger, fatigue, cold, weather, disease, and wilderness friction for roleplay and travel texture, or a heavier survival framework as a central system. This section owns the baseline survival direction; → [Survival & Combat](#) owns later balance and difficulty interactions.

Baseline

- **Starfrost - A Survival Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Fits the Simonrim-aligned progression family.

Alternatives

- **SunHelm Survival and needs** ([Nexus](#)) — Practical comparison if [Starfrost](#) proves too tightly tuned.
- **Last Seed - Survival Needs and Diseases** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier classic route if survival should become a dominant identity.
- **Frostfall - Hypothermia Camping Survival** ([Nexus](#)) + **Campfire - Complete Camping System** ([Nexus](#)) — Harsh wilderness route.

Campfire Companion (Optional Layer)

- **Skills of the Wild - New Campfire Survival Skill Trees** ([Nexus](#)) — Four new skill trees (Hunting, Foraging, Tracking, Camping) with progression tied to survival activities. v2.0 removed vanilla record edits for universal compatibility. Requires **Campfire**.
 - **Main file:** [Skills of the Wild](#). v2.0+ features full compatibility with any survival baseline.

Notes

- A heavy survival system can dominate pacing and crowd out other expanded systems.
- A very light setup can undershoot the immersive-travel pillar if later downtime decisions expect more texture.
- Cold, disease, food, sleep, and camping can blur together between survival, cooking, roleplay, and religion ownership.
- Judge survival primarily on travel texture, downtime rhythm, and world feel rather than maximum hardship.

Roleplay Upkeep And Hygiene

Lighter day-to-day body-maintenance layer between full survival needs and pure visual flavor. Adds believable downtime rituals without turning hygiene into a second dominant survival framework.

Baseline

- **Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed** (Nexus) — Leading hygiene-and-downtime route. Actively maintained, heavily customizable, modernized around SKSE + Papyrus-extender. Treat as roleplay-support, not main survival baseline.

Alternatives

- **Minimalist route** — Leave hygiene implied through inns, rivers, and roleplay.

Notes

- Hygiene can become fussy busywork if configured too aggressively.
- **Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed** touches equipment handling, overlays, follower participation, and optional integrations — needs stricter discipline than a simple immersion add-on.
- Only hard runtime requirements should be treated as mandatory.
- For Steam runtime 1.6.1170, the **Backported Extended ESL Support** requirement does not apply and should not be installed.

Death Alternative System

What happens when the player falls in combat. Goal: add consequence and narrative texture to defeat without making every lost fight permanent.

Baseline

- **Shadow of Skyrim - Nemesis and Alternative Death System** (Nexus) — Locked baseline. Upon defeat, respawn at the nearest safe location with debuffs; the defeating enemy gains a name, buffs, and persistent world presence. Defeating that nemesis later restores lost progress. Creates personal antagonists from organic gameplay.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla death-and-reload loop.

Notes

- Death-alternative systems interact with every combat mod. Verify compatibility with **Valhalla Combat**, **Precision**, **TK Dodge**, and combat-animation mods from → **Animations**.
- The nemesis system adds persistent NPCs and effects; verify save file size remains reasonable over long playthroughs.
- Death-alternative mods can create edge cases with scripted-death sequences in quests. Check compatibility with **Alternate Perspective**, **Wyrms Tooth**, **The Forgotten City**, and major quest mods from → **World Content**.
- Confirm compatibility with Steam 1.6.1170 and the SKSE plugin stack from → **Foundations**.

Crafting & Economy

MO2 Separator: **Expanded Systems** → **Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy**

All mods in this section belong to the **Expanded Systems - Crafting & Economy** MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the **Expanded Systems** section.

Alchemy Overhaul

Whether alchemy is a disciplined support system for potions/poisons/ingredients or a larger rework reshaping cooking and survival-adjacent loops.

Baseline

- **Apothecary - An Alchemy Overhaul** (Nexus) — Main baseline. Balanced modern route.

Alternatives

- **Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul** (Nexus) — Large integrated comparison if alchemy and cooking should become a major combined pillar.
- **Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments** (Nexus) — Lighter fallback.

Notes

- A very large alchemy package can quietly absorb cooking and food design.
- A restrained overhaul can undershoot if too many adjacent systems also land on conservative choices.
- Treat large food-and-cooking coverage as a deliberate expansion choice, not something hitchhiking into the alchemy baseline.

Cooking Systems

Whether food and cooking are mostly ambient support for travel and downtime or a deliberate progression-and-preparation layer.

Baseline

- **Gourmet - A Cooking Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Balanced modern route.

Alternatives

- **Complete Alchemy and Cooking Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Integrated comparison if alchemy and cooking should be tightly fused.
- **Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments** ([Nexus](#)) — Lighter fallback.
- **Mealtime - A Food and Recipe Mod** ([Nexus](#)) — Recipe-density companion if [Gourmet](#)'s scope feels too narrow.

Visual Companions

- **Hyper Realistic Cooked Beef** ([Nexus](#)) and **Hyper Realistic Bread** ([Nexus](#)) — Mesh/texture-only replacers. Zero plugin overhead.
- **Skyrim 3D Cooking** ([Nexus](#)) — Higher-detail cooking pot, oven, and food-prep meshes. Mesh-only, zero plugin overhead.
- **Realistic HD Food Remastered** ([Nexus](#)) — Photorealistic food textures (bread, meat, fruits, vegetables, prepared dishes).

Notes

- Cooking can become too dependent on the survival framework and stop making sense as its own system.
- A very large cooking package can quietly absorb alchemy and economy ownership.
- Judge cooking on inns, camps, home bases, travel prep, and downtime rhythm rather than recipe volume alone.

Smithing And Crafting Expansion

What crafting is supposed to do: lightly improve vanilla smithing, become a broader rules-and-materials framework, or shift responsibility toward NPC services and roleplay texture.

Baseline

- **Ars Metallica - Smithing Enhancement** ([Nexus](#)) — Smithing XP, tanning, mining, basic crafting-loop improvements without heavy rules restructuring.
- **Honed Metal - NPC Crafting and Enchanting Services** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked NPC-service companion. Pay smiths/enchanters to craft, temper, enchant, and recharge items. Makes town services and gold economy matter.
- **Thaumaturgy - An Enchanting Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Simonrim-aligned enchanting overhaul. Designed to pair with [Mysticism](#) and [Adamant](#). Prerequisite for artifact-overhaul content.

Alternatives

- **Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered** ([Nexus](#)) — High-complexity comparison if material logic and crafting rules should become a major progression pillar.
- **Summermyst - Enchantments of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — ~140 new enchantment effects to loot. Sits alongside [Thaumaturgy](#). Needs compatibility verification before locking.

Notes

- A very large crafting framework can absorb economy and loot-balance ownership.
- Mixing player-centric crafting with strong NPC-service assumptions can produce an incoherent progression loop.
- [Ars Metallica](#) and [Honed Metal](#) serve different purposes and should be locked together as complementary.

Economy And Loot Balance

What economy and loot should feel like: lightly rebalanced merchant-and-pricing, deliberate loot distribution, or harsher scarcity-driven progression.

Baseline

- **Trade and Barter** ([Nexus](#)) — Main merchant-pricing route.
- **C.O.I.N. - Coins of Interesting Nature** ([Nexus](#)) — Regional coin variety without touching prices or loot distribution.
- **C.O.I.N. - Treasury Exchange** ([Nexus](#)) — Currency exchange companion letting merchants convert coin types.

RiS Economy Series (optional)

- **RiS - Encounter Zones** ([Nexus](#)) — Reworks encounter zones for realism and variety with a randomizer. ESL flagged. No hard requirements.
- **RiS - Evolving Economy** ([Nexus](#)) — Dynamic pricing based on resources, season, Civil War, reputation, distance. Requires [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#) and [powerofthree's Papyrus Extender](#).
- **RiS - Loot Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Rarity-driven, contextually-aware loot with equipment breakage and leveled artifacts. Requires [Papyrus Ini Manipulator](#) and [SkyUI](#).

Flavor & Content

- **Narrative Loot** ([Nexus](#)) — 1,629 lore-friendly miscellaneous items for world-building texture. No economy balance changes. Stacks cleanly with any economy baseline.
- **SUDs - Skyrim's Unique Drinks** ([Nexus](#)) — 50+ unique drink items with custom meshes, textures, and effects. Distributed through leveled lists and world placement.

Alternatives

- **Open World Loot** (Nexus) — Curated loot progression and encounter rewards.
- **MorrowLoot Ultimate** (Nexus) — Heavy scarcity. Only if rare-item access and leveled loot should become a defining identity pillar.

Notes

- A heavy loot-distribution framework can absorb crafting and progression ownership.
- Harsh scarcity can make exploration, crafting, and reward pacing feel punitive rather than immersive.
- **Barter Limit Fix** belongs in → **Foundations** (Targeted Bugfix Mods), not as the economy-framework answer.

Artifact And Unique Item Overhauls

Unique-item content packs that add depth to Daedric artifacts, dragon priest masks, unique weapons, and quest items. Treats artifact overhauls as a separate layer from crafting — they change what named items are, not how the player makes generic items.

Baseline

- **Reliquary of Myth - Artifacts of Skyrim** (Nexus) — Artifact-stat and effect baseline. Rebalances legendary artifacts with unique enchantments and lore-friendly effects. 12K endorsements.
- **ArteFakes - Unique Artifacts Replacer** (Nexus) — Model-replacement companion. Higher-detail 3D models for unique items. Stacks cleanly with **Reliquary of Myth** (stats vs meshes).
- **Konahrik's Accoutrements** (Nexus) — Dragon-priest-specific companion. Upgrades named encounters with new gear, masks, harder fights. The only one that Legacy of the Dragonborn museum integration cares about directly.
- **Unique Items Tweaks - Improved Miscellaneous Artifacts** (Nexus) — Gap-filler for artifacts **Reliquary of Myth** doesn't cover.
- **Artificer - An Artifact Overhaul** (Nexus) — Simonrim-aligned alternative to **Reliquary of Myth**. Requires **Thaumaturgy** and **Mysticism** (both locked). **Choose one artifact overhaul baseline — not both.** Prefer if full Simonrim ecosystem coherence matters more.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla artifact stats. Functional but front-loaded toward late-game Daedric items.

Notes

- **Reliquary of Myth** + **ArteFakes** + **Unique Items Tweaks** touches every unique-item record. Verify the Synthesis patcher chain in → **Performance** doesn't re-balance the same records.
- **Konahrik's Accoutrements** adds new Dragon Priest encounters — check the **LoTD Patches (Official)** hub in → **Legacy of the Dragonborn** for an integration patch.
- Artifact overhauls that rebalance too aggressively can break encounter expectations.
- **Unique Items Tweaks** overlaps lightly with **Reliquary of Myth** on a small number of records — verify with a Bashed Patch.

Weapon Pack Additions

Weapon content packs adding new named and leveled-list weapons fitting vanilla's medieval-Nordic aesthetic. More variety without diluting the loot ladder.

Baseline

- **Heavy Armory - New Weapons** (Nexus) — 150+ lore-friendly weapons across 11 new types (halberds, spears, glaives, shortswords, quarterstaves, mauls, hatchets, clubs, long maces, shortspears, tridents). OAR-compatible animations for polearms, leveled-list integration.
- **LeanWolf's Better-Shaped Weapons SE** (Nexus) — Mesh-quality companion upgrading vanilla weapon silhouettes. Stacks cleanly with **Heavy Armory** (different records).
- **Legendary Skyrim Crossbows and Bows SSE** (Nexus) — Specialty crossbow-and-bow route with named and unique variants. Lock only if ranged combat is a viable build path.

Alternatives

- **Immersive Weapons** (Nexus) — Legacy comparison (230+ weapons). Unmaintained since April 2018. Synthesis patcher has explicit **Bash Tags** for it.
- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla weapons only.

Notes

- **Heavy Armory** uses standard leveled-list integration; doesn't require Synthesis patcher intervention like **Immersive Weapons**. A **Heavy Armory - Adamant Addon** (mod 144316) provides Simonrim-aligned perk integration.
- **LeanWolf's Better-Shaped Weapons** can conflict with **Unique Items Tweaks** and **Reliquary of Myth** on unique-weapon records.
- **Legendary Skyrim Crossbows and Bows** makes crossbows a meaningful archetype — → **Survival & Combat** difficulty decisions need to account for ranged output.
- All three weapon mods add new models — **Pandora** and **BodySlide** rebuilds in → **Performance** fire when any of them is updated.

Armor Pack Additions

Armor content packs adding new named and leveled-list armors fitting the medieval-Nordic aesthetic. More variety without diluting the loot ladder.

Baseline

- **Immersive Armors (Nexus)** — 200+ new armors with leveled-list integration. 206K endorsements. Synthesis patcher has explicit [Bash Tags](#).
- **NordwarUA Total Armor and Weapon Compilation (Nexus)** — Visual model overhaul compiling six NordwarUA mods. Standardizes cubemaps, no stat changes.
- **Common Clothes and Armors (Nexus)** — Clothing-and-light-armor variants for bandits, sellswords, travelers. Clothing-side companion to [NordwarUA](#).
- **Bandolier - Bags and Pouches Classic (Nexus)** — Carry-capacity utility. Bags, pouches, bandoliers with MCM configuration.

Immersive Armors Visual Pipeline

Stack order: [Immersive Armors](#) → [Immersive Armors Retexture and Mesh Fixes SE](#) → (optional) [IA - Realistic Armors replace by Xtudo](#) → (choose one female path) [IA CBBE 3BA BodySlide](#) OR the CBBE patch bundled with [IA HIMBO Conversion V2](#) → (if male body) [IA HIMBO Conversion V2](#).

- **Immersive Armors Retexture and Mesh Fixes SE (Nexus)** — **Required** visual companion. Fixes broken meshes, outdated textures, UV maps. Foundation all other IA mesh mods build on.
- **Immersive Armours - SSE CBBE 3BA BodySlide (Nexus)** — BodySlide files for all female IA outfits. Choose one female conversion path — **do not stack** with Retexture/Mesh Fixes' bundled CBBE meshes.
- **Immersive Armor HIMBO Conversion V2 (Nexus)** — BodySlide conversion for all IA armors for HIMBO. Designed to stack on top of Retexture/Mesh Fixes. Includes CBBE compatibility patch.
- **Immersive Armors - Realistic Armors replace SE by Xtudo (Nexus)** — Optional art-direction patch swapping 10 IA sets for NordWarUA's Realistic Armors. Requires [Realistic Armor](#) (36151) as hard dependency.

Run BodySlide after all IA mods are installed, then rebuild all IA batches.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla armor sets only.

Notes

- [Immersive Armors](#) unmaintained since November 2016 — verify game version compatibility before locking.
- [NordwarUA Total Armor](#) standardizes cubemaps across all six sub-mods — any mod depending on original cubemaps needs re-testing.
- [Common Clothes and Armors](#) adds clothing to NPC leveled lists. Verify NPCs look right if [Armor and Clothing Extension](#) is also active.
- [Bandolier](#) changes inventory — carry-weight design must account for additional slots.
- The Retexture/Mesh Fixes mod and CBBE 3BA BodySlide are **not stackable** for female meshes. HIMBO Conversion V2 avoids this conflict (designed to stack on top of Retexture/Mesh Fixes).
- All IA companion mods trigger [Pandora](#) and [BodySlide](#) rebuilds in → [Performance](#).

Clothing And Wardrobe Extensions

Clothing content packs adding new clothing, cloaks, and wearable non-armor items. More wardrobe variety without making every NPC a fashion show.

Baseline

- **Armor and Clothing Extension (Nexus)** — Clothing-diversity baseline with lore-friendly options and NPC-appropriate attire (35K+ endorsements). Requires [RUSTIC CLOTHING - SE](#) (→ [Graphics](#)) and [SkyUI](#) (→ [Foundations](#)).
- **Common Clothes and Armors (Nexus)** — Common-cloth variety companion pairing with ACE for bandit/sellsword archetypes.
- **Sforzinda Imitations (Nexus)** — Handmade curated boutique clothing. Not automatic baseline — treat as an explicit add-on. Cut if it pulls the list toward boutique-fantasy wardrobe.
- **Cloaks of Skyrim (Nexus)** — 100+ new cloaks for player and NPCs via SPID distribution. Most visually impactful wearable slot in third-person.
- **Colovian Noble Clothes (Nexus)** — Imperial-themed high-status clothing pass. Pairs with Beyond Skyrim content.
- **Knapsack Backpacks SE (Nexus)** — Carry-and-wearable utility with MCM configuration. Cosmetic companion to [Bandolier](#) (armor subsection).

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla clothing only.

Notes

- [Armor and Clothing Extension](#) requires [RUSTIC CLOTHING](#) and [SkyUI](#) — verify load order keeps [RUSTIC CLOTHING](#) above ACE.
- [Cloaks of Skyrim](#) adds 100+ cloak items. If → [Third-Person Gameplay](#) adds a custom cloak-slot overhaul, verify stacking.
- [Knapsack Backpacks SE](#) (cosmetic) and [Bandolier](#) (inventory) can stack, but verify inventory UI doesn't show duplicate bag icons.
- Verify [Colovian Noble Clothes](#) for known issues before locking.

Followers & Reputation

MO2 Separator: [Expanded Systems](#) → [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#)

All mods in this section belong to the [Expanded Systems - Followers & Reputation](#) MO2 separator unless noted.

Part of the [Expanded Systems](#) section.

Crime, Reputation, And Social Systems

How much the world should notice what the player does socially — reputation, crime tools, city suspicion, and guard behavior.

Baseline

- **Skyrim Reputation** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline for reputation.
- **The Choice is Yours** ([Nexus](#)) — Stricter control over quest auto-start pressure in a content-heavy run.
- **To Your Face SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Low-drama social polish for vanilla greeting behavior in cities and taverns.
- **Steal off Scoundrels** ([Nexus](#)) — SKSE plugin preventing pickpocketing from being flagged as stealing when the target is a criminal. No ESP, no conflicts.

Alternatives

- **Suspicious City Guards** ([Nexus](#)) — Grounded urban tension around suspicious behavior.
- **Book Of Shadows** ([Nexus](#)) — High-expression branch for crime and stealth as a major playstyle pillar.

Notes

- A very light social-response layer can leave crime and reputation too close to vanilla.
- A stealth-heavy crime toolkit can make one playstyle dominate a subsection meant for broader roleplay.
- City suspicion systems can become annoying without enough payoff.
- Targeted fixes like [Simple Offence Suppression](#) belong in → [Foundations](#) (Targeted Bugfix Mods), not as the social-system answer.
- Keep stealth-expression tooling separate from broader world-reaction goals.

Followers And Companion Systems

How companion management should function at the systems level.

Baseline

- **Nether's Follower Framework** ([Nexus](#)) — Main baseline. Modern flexible route.

Alternatives

- **EFF - Extensible Follower Framework** ([Nexus](#)) — Simpler established management route.
- **Amazing Follower Tweaks SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavy-management branch for more dominant follower control.

Notes

- A very light or dated framework can leave companions awkward to manage once the modlist grows.
- A heavy follower-control framework can make party management dominate ordinary play.
- Generic frameworks can conflict with custom companions better left outside them.
- This subsection owns party-management philosophy, not named companion selection (→ [NPCs](#)).

Romance, Marriage, And Companionship

The SFW romance and marriage layer: expanded marriage mechanics, modern dialogue with spouses and romance interests, and opt-in quest-driven romance arcs. Baseline is fade-to-black, not explicit content. Custom named followers belong in → [NPCs](#).

Baseline

- **Relationship Dialogue Overhaul - RDO SE** ([Nexus](#)) — 5,000+ fully-voiced new lines for vanilla NPCs, followers, and spouses using original voices. Community-canonical (137K endorsements), fully SFW.
- **Amorous Adventures** (clean variant) ([Nexus](#)) — Opt-in romance quests with fade-to-black. Fully voiced arcs for Lydia, Serana, Elisif, and other marriage-eligible NPCs. **Lock only the clean build.**
- **Marriage Mod - To Have And To Hold** ([Nexus](#)) — Up to 11 simultaneous spouses, divorce/remarriage, enhanced wedding ceremony, dynamic events.
- **Serana Dialogue Add-On** ([Nexus](#)) — Best-in-class single-companion expansion. 7,000+ fully-voiced lines, new story arcs, romance progression, quest commentary. 51K endorsements.

Alternatives

- **Discipline-first route** — Vanilla marriage mechanics. Only if [Elder Wilds](#) explicitly decides romance is out of scope.

Notes

- The wrong Amorous Adventures variant breaks the SFW rule. Download must be the clean build.
- Do not stack [To Have And To Hold](#) with another multi-spouse mod.

- Romance dialogue can conflict with custom-voiced follower mods from → [NPCs](#) that replace the same NPC's voice.
- Romance quest mods add non-trivial content — review against → [World Content](#) to avoid doubling up on a single NPC's quest line.
- Marriage events triggered by [To Have And To Hold](#) can fire during unintended moments; check MCM for event timing/cooldown settings.

Immersive Scale and World Feel

MO2 Separator: [World Feel](#) → [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#), [World Feel - Soundscapes](#), [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#), [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

All mods in this section belong to one of the four world-feel separators as noted per subsection.

Timescale And Calendar Adjustments → separator: [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

How quickly days pass, whether routine actions consume believable chunks of time, and season/calendar support.

Baseline

- **Time Flies SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Grounded play loops without turning into abstract clock tuning.
- **Seasonal Calendar** ([Nexus](#)) — Narrow companion if weather-and-season direction makes calendar readability worthwhile.
- **Seasons of Skyrim SKSE** ([Nexus](#)) + **Turn of the Seasons** ([Nexus](#)) — High-commitment seasonal branch. Cost: 4× DynDOLOD passes, 4× grass caches, meaningful patch footprint. Only adopt if the project owns that LOD-generation workflow.

Alternatives

- **Dynamic Timescale - Remade** ([Nexus](#)) — Environment-aware time shifts.
-

Travel Pacing And Carriage Fast Travel Rules → separator: [World Feel - Timescale & Travel](#)

How much friction, structure, and world texture sits between major locations.

Baseline

- **Carriage and Ferry Travel Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Improves vanilla public-travel layer. Verify 1.6.1170 compatibility (predates AE).
- **Carriage Drivers Are Alive** ([Nexus](#)) — Names, schedules, dialogue for carriage drivers.
- **Carriages and Stables Dialogue Bundle** ([Nexus](#)) — Bribes, rumors, destination chat. Stacks cleanly with above.

Alternatives

- **Carriage Stops of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Broader route coverage.
 - **Fast Travel Cost** ([Nexus](#)) — Economic pressure on map fast travel.
 - **Campfire** ([Nexus](#)) — Camping-and-rest companion. Already in the survival conversation.
 - **Journeyman - A Fast Travel Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Restricts fast travel unless a Travel Pack is crafted/purchased. SKSE plugin + ESP. Fits "living the world" without forcing no-fast-travel.
-

Encounter Spacing And Wilderness Feel → separator: [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

How busy, calm, or deliberately spaced wilderness travel feels between destinations.

Baseline

- **Extended Encounters** ([Nexus](#)) — Broad wilderness and road activity, lightweight.

Alternatives

- **Radiance Encounters** ([Nexus](#)) — World reactivity and consequences.
 - **Immersive Patrols SE AE** ([Nexus](#)) — Faction-patrol route.
-

Soundscape And Ambient Audio → separator: [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

What roads, settlements, wilderness, and interiors sound like during ordinary exploration.

Baseline

- **Sounds of Skyrim Complete SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Roads, wilderness, dungeons, settlements in one exploration-facing project.

Alternatives

- **Acoustic Space Improvement Fixes** ([Nexus](#)) — Interior ambience and reverb treatment.
 - **Discipline-first** — Keep current sound stack if playtesting shows world already sounds readable.
-

City Size, Outskirts, And Population Feel → separator: [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

How large, inhabited, and spatially convincing cities feel during ordinary play.

Baseline

- **Spaghetti's Cities - AIO** ([Nexus](#)) — Denser, more inhabited without giant patch-management.

Alternatives

- **Dawn of Skyrim (Director's Cut)** ([Nexus](#)) — Stronger city-core expansion. Last updated June 2020.
- **JK's Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier all-in-one. Only if city transformation should become a loud identity pillar.

Roadside Clutter, Ruins, And Landmark Density → separator: [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Small-to-mid-scale worldspace texture between major destinations.

Baseline

- **Ancient Land** ([Nexus](#)) — Static worldspace flavor and distant landmark presence.
- **Point The Way** ([Nexus](#)) — Road guidance and signposting.
- **Ryn's Standing Stones** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked landmark baseline. Each stone becomes a unique environmental setpiece. World geometry only, no gameplay effects.

Alternatives

- **Interesting Roads** ([Nexus](#)) — Lighter roadside variety. Asset-only, low compatibility risk.
- **Giant Crab Shells - Mihail's Shards of Immersion** ([Nexus](#)) — Coastal scenery. ESL-flagged.

Wildlife And Creature Ecology → separator: [World Feel - Nights & Wildlife](#)

How varied and biologically alive wilderness travel feels.

Baseline

- **Animallica SE - Skyrim Wildlife Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — More biologically varied during travel.
- **Butterflies Land True** ([Nexus](#)) — Insects land on surfaces. No scripts, ESL-flagged, ~1 KB.

Alternatives

- **One With Nature** ([Nexus](#)) — Creature relationship tuning. Script-heavy — verify AE compatibility.
- **Savage Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier danger-and-behavior.
- **Frogs - Mihail** ([Nexus](#)) — 4 frog variants. ESL-flagged.

Road Network And Surface Overhaul → separator: [World Feel - Cities & Landmarks](#)

Roads as built infrastructure at mesh/geometry level (separate from surface texture ownership in → [Graphics](#)).

Baseline

- **Blended Roads - Light Plugin (ESL)** ([Nexus](#)) — Locked baseline. Seamless road-to-terrain blending. No worldspace edits, no patch requirements.
- **Interesting Roads** ([Nexus](#)) — Roadside character (barrels, carts, signs). Asset-only.
- **Point The Way** ([Nexus](#)) — Navigational signposting at junctions.

Notes

- **Northern Roads** was evaluated and rejected due to patch burden at this modlist's complexity level.

Environmental Atmosphere: Wind And Dynamic Effects → separator: [World Feel - Soundscapes](#)

Weather-aware wind physics, dynamic cloth, and airborne particles for physical world-layer motion.

Baseline

- **Dynamic Wind Framework - SKSE Plugin** ([Nexus](#)) — Infrastructure baseline.
- **Dynamic Wind - Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Required data companion with weather/location profiles.
- **Particle Wind - SKSE Plugin** ([Nexus](#)) — Dust, leaves, snow, ash respond to wind direction.
- **Realistic Boat Bobbing SE** ([Nexus](#)) + **BOS Edition** ([Nexus](#))
- **R.A.S.S. - Rain Ash And Snow Shaders** ([Nexus](#)) — Visible rain droplets, snow accumulation, ash/frost shaders on player/NPCs. 33K+ endorsements.
- **Animated Icebergs** ([Nexus](#))

- **Animated Ice Floes** (Nexus)

Notes

- **R.A.S.S. + CS coexistence:** CS Wetness Effects handles terrain/objects; R.A.S.S. handles actor surfaces. Should coexist without conflicts — verify in testing.

Night Darkness And Visibility Balance → separator: **World Feel - Nights & Wildlife**

Baseline

- Darkness baseline from the weather mod and CS pair selected in → **Graphics** first.
- **Simply Darker Nights** (Nexus) — Simple image-space overlay. Verify it's not redundant before adding.
- **Lanterns of Skyrim II** (Nexus) — Road and settlement exterior lantern placement. Lighting-framework-agnostic. FOMOD patch hub covers ~30-50 patches vs Lux Via's ~80-120.
- **CS Lantern Lights - Lanterns of Skyrim II** (Nexus) — CS particle lights for LoS II. Install after LoS II.
- **Simple Wearable Lanterns - Remastered** (Nexus) — Preferred carried-visibility branch. Modern, lightweight, no SKSE.

Alternatives

- **Torches Candlelight and Lanterns** (Nexus) — Physics-equipped lanterns, NPC distribution. Requires BOS, MCM Helper.
- **Realistic Usable Lanterns** (Nexus) — Finite candles as consumable resource.
- **Handheld Lanterns - HDT-SMP** (Nexus) — Physics-equipped with sway. Requires FSMP.

Activation Text → separator: **World Feel - Timescale & Travel**

Baseline

- **Roleplaying In Skyrim - Immersive Activators** (Nexus) — Descriptive activation text (e.g., "Read Book" instead of "Activate"), hides NPC names until interaction (toggleable). 8KB, no scripts, no SKSE.

Candidate TODO Additions

Timescale & Travel → **World Feel - Timescale & Travel**

- **Extended Stay - Longer inn**
- **Sleep Tight SE** (Nexus) — NPC sleep schedules and sleepwear
- **Sleep Tight - NPCs wear underwear** (Nexus)

Nights & Wildlife → **World Feel - Nights & Wildlife**

- **Wearable Lanterns**

Cities & Landmarks → **World Feel - Cities & Landmarks**

- **Nordic Runestones**
- **Place of Power**
- **Whiterun Horse Statues**
- **Solitude Statuary**
- **s6o6t LORE - Mundus Stones**
- **Northern Roads - Clutters Only** (Nexus)

World Content

MO2 Separator: **World Content** → **World Content - Overhauls**, **World Content - Quests**, **World Content - Homes & Bases**, **World Content - Underwater**

All mods in this section belong to one of the four world-content separators as noted per subsection.

Landscape Overhauls → separator: **World Content - Overhauls**

Large worldspace-content changes making regions feel meaningfully different to cross.

Baseline

Keep restrained until section 08 is clearer. First experiment:

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Marshlands	Gives Hjaalmarch strong identity without redefining a central travel space.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Whiterun Forest Borealis	Heavier compatibility pressure.	Nexus
Aspens Ablaze	Rift identity layer. Keep only if → Terrain & Flora can absorb it.	Nexus

Cities, Towns, And Villages → separator: [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Authored settlement content — real places, not just denser vibes.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Great Cities - Minor Cities and Towns SSE	First-pass baseline giving multiple underbuilt settlements stronger structure.	Nexus
Cities of the North - Dawnstar	Default modular lock for four smaller hold capitals. Designed to stack.	Nexus
Cities of the North - Morthal		Nexus
Cities of the North - Falkreath		Nexus
Cities of the North - Winterhold		Nexus
Settlements Expanded	Makes seven underbuilt settlements feel inhabited (no city geometry changes). Must load late.	Nexus
The Great City of Solitude SSE	Port expansion with new homes, shops, warehouses, NPCs.	Nexus
JK's Whiterun Outskirts	Whiterun-area expansion. Independent of JK's Skyrim AIO; stack without patching.	Nexus
JK's Raven Rock	Solstheim settlement. ESL-flagged.	Nexus
JK's Tel Mithryn	Telvanni tower. ESL-flagged.	Nexus
FYX - Eastern Empire Company Building		Nexus
FYX - Riften - Window Consistency		Nexus

Locked Faction-HQ Additions

Mod	Description	Nexus
JK's Fort Dawnguard	ESL-flagged.	Nexus
JK's Castle Volkihar	ESL-flagged.	Nexus
JK's Dark Brotherhood Sanctuaries	ESL-flagged.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Great Cities	Major-hold-capital follow-on. Treat as deliberate second-step.	Nexus
Capital Whiterun Expansion	If JK's patch missing, mutually exclusive with JK's Whiterun edits.	Nexus
The Great Town of Ivarstead SSE		Nexus
The Great Village of Kynesgrove		Nexus
The Great Village of Mixwater Mill SSE		Nexus
The Great Town of Shor's Stone SSE		Nexus

College of Winterhold → separators: [World Content - Overhauls](#) / [World Content - Quests](#)

Coordinated three-mod sub-stack designed to work together without inter-mod patches.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus	Separator
Obscure's College of Winterhold	Architecture baseline. FOMOD with ~50 built-in patches including LotD.	Nexus	World Content - Overhauls
Immersive College NPCs	ESL-flagged, vanilla assets, no cell edits. Integration patch in Obscure's FOMOD.	Nexus	World Content - Overhauls

Mod	Description	Nexus	Separator
College of Winterhold - Quest Expansion	Skill-gated entry, 7 starter lessons before Saarthal. ESL-flagged, by jayserpa.	Nexus	World Content - Quests

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Magical College of Winterhold	Cleaner fantasy aesthetic but weaker grim-dark fit.	Nexus
Immersive College of Winterhold	Architecture+NPCs+crafting. Unmaintained since Dec 2020.	Nexus
College of Winterhold - Quest Expansion (alone)	Questline-only option — lowest patch overhead.	Nexus

Compatibility Notes

- Obscure's ↔ COTN Winterhold: Compatible without patch. Load COTN before OCW.
- Obscure's ↔ CS-native lighting: No official patch. Verify CellSettings.esp forwarding for CS Light + True Light bulbs. Install **OCW Meshes Optimized and Merged for CS patch** ([Nexus](#)).
- Obscure's ↔ LOTD: Patch in OCW's own FOMOD. ESP-FE format.
- ICN ↔ NPC appearance: Load ICN after broad NPC overhauls to avoid blackface.
- Quest Expansion ↔ FDE Brelyna Maryon: Both touch her dialogue tree — test for overlap.

Inns, Farms, And Small Settlements → separator: [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Travel-stop identity, small community presence, memorable rural pauses.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Great Village of Old Hroldan SSE		Nexus
Candlehearth - An Inn Overhaul	Locked inn-overhaul baseline. Every inn in Skyrim.	Nexus
Ask Innkeepers To Show Room SE	Preview room before renting. 5,351 endorsements.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Nexus
Granite Hill	Nexus
Lund's Hamlet - An Overhaul	Nexus
The Great Town of Karthwasten SSE	Nexus
Oakwood	Nexus

Dungeons And Ruins → separator: [World Content - Overhauls](#)

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Forgotten Dungeons (SSE)		Nexus
Dungeons - Revisited	Improves existing ruins rather than adding new destinations.	Nexus
Iconic's Crown of Barenziah	High-quality crown/gems/display stand.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Hammet's Dungeon Pack 1 SE	Curated hand-authored dungeons.	Nexus
Children of the North Wind	Bespoke Nordic architecture at 9 locations.	Nexus
Skyrim Underground SSE	Larger subterranean layer.	Nexus

Navmesh Support

Mod	Description	Nexus
Navigator - Navmesh Fixes - Patch Collection	FOMOD covering Dungeons Revisited, LotD, Helgen Reborn, JK's interiors, etc. Install after content mods and Navigator are in place.	Nexus

Points Of Interest And Roadside Content → separator: **World Content - Overhauls**

Smaller discoverable places between headline destinations.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Hidden Hideouts of Skyrim SE		Nexus
Daedric Shrines - All in One		Nexus
Daedric Shrines - Patch Collection		Nexus
Environs - Abandoned Abodes	ESL-flagged, zero script overhead.	Nexus
Evolving Locations - Riverside Shack		Nexus
Evolving Locations - Lucky Shack		Nexus
Evolving Locations - Cliffside Retreat		Nexus
Reinforced Civil War Camps		Nexus
Hagraven Houses Animated	BOS mesh replacer.	Nexus
Ivarstead Source	Landscape fix. ESL-flagged.	Nexus
Animated Ships		Nexus
Finer Sails		Nexus
Dynamic Boats at Docks - Official Patch Hub		Nexus
Snowy Ships for Snowy Regions	BOS-based.	Nexus
Unmarked Locations Pack - All In One	+ addon packs for Bruma, Wyrnstooth, Gray Cowl if those worldspaces are adopted.	Nexus
Ascend - Hidden Peaks of Skyrim	Climbing challenge locations across Skyrim. Complements parkour movement.	Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Hold Border Guards - Definitive Edition		Nexus
Nordic Ruins of Skyrim SSE		Nexus
Hidden Hideouts City Edition SE		Nexus
7000 Steps of Sanctum		Nexus
Gildergreen Regrown		Nexus
The Gildergreen Grows	Incompatible with Regrown.	Nexus
HAG Occult Orphan Rock		Nexus
Lore Friendly Roadside Ruins		Nexus

Underwater → separator: **World Content - Underwater**

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Depths of Skyrim - An Underwater Overhaul SSE	New grass, coral, kelp, 1000+ fish, unmarked treasures.	Nexus
Depths of Skyrim - Mesh fixes		Nexus
More Underwater Treasures - AIO	56 treasures (Skyrim) + 35 (Solstheim). Marked compatible with Depths of Skyrim.	Nexus

Notes

- Use `SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm` for LOD generation (→ [Performance](#)).
- Requires `iMaxGrassTypesPerTexture=7` in `Skyrim.ini`.

- Depths is script-free but adds 1000+ fish references — verify no unexpected Papyrus load.

Side Activities: Fishing, Hunting, And Downtime → separator: [World Content - Quests](#)

Non-combat downtime making Skyrim feel lived-in when the player isn't dungeon-delving.

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simple Fishing Overhaul	200+ lines improved dialogue, NPC reactions, MCM. ESL-flagged, by jayserpa.	Nexus
Hunterborn SE	Dressing, skinning, harvesting, butchering. 20K endorsements. Use Hunterborn Extender via Synthesis.	Nexus
Headhunter - Bounties Redone	Locked. Transforms vanilla bounties. By jayserpa, 28K+ endorsements.	Nexus
Skyrim's Got Talent	Locked. Instrument practice, skill progression, inn performances. By jayserpa.	Nexus
SGT - Player Reactions Addon		Nexus
SGT - Show in UI		Nexus
SGT - Visual Improvements		Nexus
Immersive Fishing	New spots, rods, fish types, radiant quests.	Nexus
Fishermen Fish	No ESP, mesh replacer only.	Nexus
Garbage Loot - Barrels and Sacks	ESL-flagged.	Nexus
Brawling - No Hitting Bystanders		Nexus

Alternatives

Mod	Description	Nexus
Simple Hunting Overhaul	Simpler alternative by jayserpa. If chosen, replaces Hunterborn. Requires Dynamic Activation Key .	Nexus
Dynamic Activation Key	Required by SHO.	Nexus
Immersive Hunting Animations	SHO companion.	Nexus
Immersive Carcass Carrying	SHO companion.	Nexus
Hunters Loot	SHO companion.	Nexus
Streamlined Fishing		Nexus
Become a Bard / Bards Reborn	Not compatible with SGT without patch.	Nexus
Fishing Extension Framework	Required for new-lands fishing.	Nexus

Weapons, Armor, And Equipment Additions → separator: [World Content - Quests](#)

Baseline

Mod	Description	Nexus
Immersive Weapons	~230 new weapons. 114K endorsements.	Nexus
Immersive Armors	~55 armor sets, 396 shields. 206K endorsements.	Nexus
Immersive Armors Retexture and Mesh Fixes SE	Brings visuals in line with 4K PBR stack.	Nexus
Dawnguard Arsenal SSE - SkyPatched	SkyPatched variant.	Nexus — SkyPatched: Nexus

Quest Additions → separator: [World Content - Quests](#)

Everyday & Radiant

Mod	Description	Nexus
Sidequests of Skyrim		Nexus
Missives	Dual everyday-quest baseline with Sidequests.	Nexus
Missives - Voice and Quest Expansion	20 new types, voiced.	Nexus
Missives - Notes Retexture		Nexus

Mod	Description	Nexus
Missives - Notes Retexture Darkened		Nexus
Diverse Witcher Missives Boards	BOS-based.	Nexus
Missives - Unique Missive Boards		Nexus
Missives Quest Conversion		Nexus
Missives - Worldspace Additions	Required for new-lands.	Nexus

Faction Expansions

Mod	Description	Nexus
A Chance Arrangement Plus Plus	Thieves Guild quest overhaul.	Nexus
Opulent Thieves Guild	Visual-progression companion.	Nexus
Improved Companions - Questline Tweaks	Removes forced radiant-quest spam between Companions missions.	Nexus
Penitus Oculatus	Locked. "Destroy the Dark Brotherhood!" replacement faction with radiant quests. 11.5K endorsements.	Nexus

Optional alternative: Destroy The Dark Brotherhood - Quest Expansion ([Nexus](#)) — jayserpa's quest-expansion approach to destroying the DB. *Incompatible with Penitus Oculatus* — choose one.

Quest Expansions (Vanilla+)

Mod	Description	Nexus
House of Horrors Quest Expansion		Nexus
Paarthurnax Quest Expansion		Nexus
The Only Cure Quest Expansion		Nexus
The Whispering Door Quest Expansion		Nexus
Quest Expansions Patches Hub		Nexus
Saints and Seducers Extended Cut	Transforms thin vanilla Creation into proper Shivering Isles return.	Nexus
Infiltration - Quest Expansion	Thieves Guild / Skyrim quest expansion.	Nexus
The Taste of Death - Quest Addon	Namira quest expansion.	Nexus
More to do in the Soul Cairn	Soul Cairn quest and content addon.	Nexus
Boethiah's Calling - Alternate Questline	Boethiah daedric quest alternative.	Nexus
Mephala's Curse - Whispering Door Addon	Whispering Door quest addon. Separable from the Quest Expansion — evaluate for overlap.	Nexus

Standalone Adventures

Mod	Description	Nexus
The Forgotten City	Locked. Most decorated Skyrim quest mod. Self-contained murder-mystery, LoTD integration.	Nexus
Mysteries of the Dwemer	Dwemer-theme quest mod.	Nexus

Alternatives

New Lands

Mod	Nexus
Wyrmsstooth	Nexus
Beyond Skyrim - Bruma SE	Nexus
Beyond Reach	Nexus
VIGILANT SE	Nexus
Falskaar	Nexus
The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal - 10th Anniversary	Nexus
The Isle Of Valefrost SE	Nexus

Standalone Quest Mods

Mod	Description	Nexus
Moon and Star		Nexus
The Wheels of Lull		Nexus
Whispers of the Depths		Nexus
Before the End		Nexus
Val Serano - Pirate Custom Voiced Follower and Quest Adventure		
The Frozen Heart		Nexus
Midnight Sun		Nexus
Echoes of Oblivion	AI-Generated Content.	Nexus

Lightweight Additions

Mod	Description	Nexus
Leaps of Faith	Lightweight pilgrimage. ESL-flagged.	Nexus
Rescue Missions	Radiant rescue. ESL-flagged.	Nexus

NPCs

MO2 Separator: [NPCs](#) → [NPCs](#) - [Appearance](#), [NPCs](#) - [Population](#), [NPCs](#) - [Followers](#)

All mods in this section belong to one of the three NPC separators as noted per subsection.

Creature/enemy content moved to → [Creatures and Enemies](#).

NPC Appearance Overhauls → separator: [NPCs](#) - [Appearance](#)

Face, hair, and presentation direction for Skyrim's named NPCs. Does not re-decide the body/skin/baseline character-visual stack already owned by → [Characters & Creatures](#).

Baseline

- **Northbourne NPCs of Whiterun Hold** ([Nexus](#)) — Modern, regionally textured look. Grounded route.
- **The Men of Winter SSE** ([Nexus](#)) — Dedicated male coverage. Last updated August 2020 — verify 1.6.1170 compatibility.
- **AI Overhaul SSE** ([Nexus](#)) — NPC schedule and behavior layer. Pairs with any appearance route.
- **Children of the First - An Altmer NPC Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Race-specific modular overlay for Altmer.
- **Children of the Ash - A Dunmer NPC Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Race-specific modular overlay for Dunmer.

Alternatives

- **High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Vanilla-faithful fallback.
- **Pandorable's NPCs (AIO)** ([Nexus](#)) — Beauty-forward branch.
- **Dibella's Blessing** ([Nexus](#)) — 233 female characters.
- **Males Of Skyrim by zzjay** ([Nexus](#))
- **The Wolven Widow - SerketHetyt's Elisif Overhaul** ([Nexus](#))
- **Pride of Skyrim** — Later modular target.

Civilian And Traveler Population Additions → separator: [NPCs](#) - [Population](#)

Extra background people making towns, inns, and roads feel used — without re-deciding city feel and roadside atmosphere.

Baseline

- **Crowded Streets** ([Nexus](#)) — Compatibility-first crowd: zero cell edits, dynamic cleanup, configurable density.

Alternatives

- **Travellers of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#)) — Road-traveler route. LE-era port — verify 1.6.1170 compatibility.
- **Populated Skyrim Reborn SSE** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier legacy route.
- **MINPCs** ([Nexus](#)) — Adventurer-style incidental content.
- **Immersive Citizens - AI Overhaul SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Known conflict with AI Overhaul SSE.
- **Interesting NPCs SE (3DNPC)** ([Nexus](#)) — Authored content NPCs.

NPC Name Variety → separator: **NPCs - Population**

Making named NPCs feel more regionally distinct without changing appearance or dialogue.

- **NPCs Names Distributor** ([Nexus](#)) — Framework distributing name variations based on race, faction, location.
- **Tamrielic Names** ([Nexus](#)) — Human NPC names (Nord, Imperial, Redguard, Breton).
- **Reachmen Tribes Names** ([Nexus](#)) — Forsworn/Reach names.
- **Ashlander Nomads Names** ([Nexus](#)) — Dunmer/Solstheim names.
- **Dovah Names** ([Nexus](#)) — Dragon names.
- **Daedric Names** ([Nexus](#)) — Daedra names.
- **Player Name Randomizer** ([Nexus](#)) — Randomizes player display name on new game.

NPC Dialogue Expansions → separator: **NPCs - Appearance**

Targeted dialogue additions for existing NPCs — expanding what vanilla characters say via spliced vanilla voice assets.

Baseline

- **Dialogue Expansion - Windhelm** ([Nexus](#)) — 180+ lines for Windhelm citizens/guards/court. **Discontinued** but existing downloads function.
- **Dialogue Expansion - Imperial Soldiers** ([Nexus](#)) — Also discontinued.
- **Bandit Lines Expansion** ([Nexus](#)) — Spliced vanilla assets.
- **Extended Bandit Dialogue** ([Nexus](#)) — Additional bandit lines.
- **Falmer Servant Lines Expansion** ([Nexus](#)) — 483 lines via professional voice talent. ESL-flagged. Optional plugins: More Spawns, More Unique Servants.
- **Civil War Lines Expansion** ([Nexus](#))
- **Forsworn and Thalmor Lines Expansion** ([Nexus](#))
- **Shouts of Stallholders** ([Nexus](#)) — AI-Generated Content — evaluate voice quality.

Follower Dialogue Expansion (FDE) series by Anbeegod

AI-voiced, each ESL-flagged. Full set of 10 expansions:

- **FDE - Aela the Huntress** ([Nexus](#)) — 2700+ lines, romance arc, werewolf mechanics.
- **FDE - Brelyna Maryon** ([Nexus](#)) — 400+ lines.
- **FDE - Lydia** ([Nexus](#)) — 400+ lines.
- **FDE - Roggi Knot-Beard** ([Nexus](#))
- **FDE - Aranea Ienith** ([Nexus](#)) — 495 lines.
- **FDE - Borgakh the Steel Heart** ([Nexus](#)) — 478 lines.
- **FDE - Uthgerd the Unbroken** ([Nexus](#)) — 233 lines.
- **FDE - Ysolda** ([Nexus](#)) — 180 lines.
- **FDE - Jenassa** ([Nexus](#)) — 500+ lines.
- **FDE - Olfinia Gray-Mane** ([Nexus](#)) — 578 lines.

Official FDE collection: <https://next.nexusmods.com/skyrimspcialedition/collections/uu3kpb>

Alternatives

- **Extended NPC Dialogue Hub** ([Nexus](#)) — Central dialogue hub.
- **Small Talk** ([Nexus](#)) — NPC-to-NPC ambient dialogue. SKSE plugin, no ESP.

Custom Followers → separator: **NPCs - Followers**

Custom fully-voiced follower additions with authored dialogue, quest commentary, and personal content.

Baseline

- **Lucien - Immersive Fully Voiced Male Follower** ([Nexus](#)) — 5000+ lines, personal quest, LoTD-aware. 30K+ endorsements.
- **Remiel - Custom Voiced Dwemer Specialist** ([Nexus](#)) — ~5000 lines. Custom framework — do not use with NFF/AFT.
- **INIGO** ([Nexus](#)) — 7000+ lines, 100K+ endorsements.
 - **Inigo Official Patch SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Required for 1.6.1170.
 - **Lulu's INIGO 2.0** ([Nexus](#)) — High-poly visual replacer.
- **Khajiit Will Follow** ([Nexus](#)) — 4 Khajiit followers. ~8K endorsements. Compatible with NFF.
- **Song of the Green (Auri Follower)** ([Nexus](#)) — 1000+ lines, romance option, Inigo banter.
 - **Majestic Auri** ([Nexus](#)) — High-poly visual replacer. 224K+ downloads.
- **Sofia - The Funny Fully Voiced Follower** ([Nexus](#)) — Comic relief. May be cut for tonal mismatch.
- **Kaidan 2** ([Nexus](#)) — 1200+ lines, romance arc. Use the Immersive Features AIO from kaidanmod.com (supersedes deprecated Nexus Extended Edition).
 - **A Makeover for Kaidan** ([Nexus](#))
 - **Immersive Kaidan Start** ([Nexus](#))

Follower Framework Notes

- Remiel and Auri work best outside NFF (custom systems).
- Sofia works under NFF or standalone.
- Lucien tested with NFF but works standalone.
- Kaidan 2 has custom AI system — use built-in track/summon powers instead of NFF.

Notes

- Remiel WILL BREAK under NFF/AFT. Same for Auri 2.0+.
- Kaidan 2: use kaidanmod.com AIO path (Nexus Extended Edition is deprecated).
- Sofia's comedic tone may clash with grim-dark presentation.
- Verify cross-follower banter (Remiel+Auri have Inigo patches; Kaidan 2 has extended banter with Remiel).
- **Backported Extended ESL Support** listed for Majestic Auri does not apply to 1.6.1170 — do not install.

Candidate TODO Additions

NPC Dialogue → separator: **NPCs - Appearance**

- **Naked Comments Overhaul** (Nexus)
- **Collision Dialogue Overhaul** (Nexus)
- **Extended NPC Dialogue** series
- **Chattier Hunters and Fishermen** (Nexus)

NPC AI → separator: **NPCs - Population**

- **Immersive Citizens - AI** (Nexus) — Known conflict with AI Overhaul SSE

NPC Framework → separator: **NPCs - Followers**

- **Keep Up - Follower Locomotion Fix** (Nexus)

Creatures and Enemies

MO2 Separator: **NPCs - Enemies & Creatures**

All mods in this section belong to the **NPCs - Enemies & Creatures** MO2 separator.

NPC-specific content → **NPCs**.

Enemy Variety

How hostile enemy groups feel less repetitive across ordinary play.

Baseline

- **Lawless - A Bandit Overhaul** (Nexus) — Cleanest vanilla-plus bandit variety. Bandits are the most overexposed enemy family.

Alternatives

- **OBIS SE** (Nexus) — Heavier legacy bandit route.
- **Haugbui - A Draugr Overhaul** (Nexus) — Lighter undead route.
- **Skyrim Revamped - Complete Enemy Overhaul** (Nexus) — List-wide enemy rebalance.
- **Skyrim Immersive Creatures** — Out of scope; overlaps later creature subsections.

Creature Visual Overhauls

Creature-specific visual direction layered on top of the Bellyaches texture foundation from → **Characters & Creatures**.

Baseline

- **Fluffworks** (Nexus) — Broad furred-animal presentation layer.
- **Bears of the North** (Nexus) — Species standout for common large wildlife threat.
- **Iconic's Dragon Retexture** (Nexus) — Clean dragon presentation upgrade.
- **Dragons SE** (Nexus) — Full dragon model replacer. Not compatible with Iconic's — choose one.
- **Draugrs - New models and textures** (Nexus) — Most-seen undead enemy.
- **Spider SE** (Nexus)
- **Deer Reworked - Ultimate** (Nexus)
- **Cannibal Draugr on Solstheim** (Nexus) — Bloodmoon-flavored identity.
- **Hagraven - New models and Textures** (Nexus)
- **Butterfly Improved by zzjay** (Nexus)

Alternatives

- **Fusa Fusa Project** ([Nexus](#)) — Don't casually stack with Fluffworks.
- **Splendor - Dragon Variants** ([Nexus](#)) — Last updated Sept 2017.

New Creature Additions

Mihail Creature Additions (all ESL-flagged)

- **Farm Geese** ([Nexus](#))
- **Sewer Rats** ([Nexus](#))
- **Giant Bats and Rats** ([Nexus](#))
- **Imps** ([Nexus](#))
- **Giant Centipedes** ([Nexus](#))
- **Ogrim** ([Nexus](#))
- **Ruinachs** ([Nexus](#))

Non-Mihail Creature Additions

- **Edmond's Nature Series - BIRDS** ([Nexus](#)) — Comprehensive bird overhaul. ESL-flagged. Replaces Seagulls - Mihail (don't stack).
 - **Optimized textures by Xtudo** ([Nexus](#)) — Pick **2K** main file.
- **Morrowind Creatures SE** ([Nexus](#))
- **Ogres SE** ([Nexus](#))
- **Sea Turtles - Mihail** ([Nexus](#))

Additional Species Follow-Ups

- **Diverse True Wolves and Dogs** ([Nexus](#))
- **Real Rabbits HD** ([Nexus](#))
- **Rally's Shaggy Cows of Skyrim** ([Nexus](#))
- **Realistic Horse Breeds by Krittakitty** ([Nexus](#)) — Verify 1.6.1170 compatibility.

Creature Behavior Improvements

How creatures attack, react, and express identity once combat starts.

Baseline

- **Dragons Use Thu'um** ([Nexus](#)) — Smarter dragon shout usage and encounter AI.
- **The Restless Dead** ([Nexus](#)) — Undead-behavior baseline. Replaces abandoned Draugr Upgrades and Improvements.

Alternatives

- **Epic Dragon Combat REDONE** ([Nexus](#)) — Full dragon combat overhaul: 20+ new dragon types, unique abilities, custom VFX. Self-contained — includes own models/textures so replaces baseline dragon visual direction.
- **Dragon War** ([Nexus](#)) — Heavier dragon route for fight structure/tempo.
- **SkyTEST Lite ESL** ([Nexus](#)) / **Animal Tweaks** ([Nexus](#)) / **Pelagius's Wildlife AI** ([Nexus](#)) — Animal-side mods drifting into ecology territory.

Wildlife Density And Rarity Balance

Baseline

- **True Hunter - fewer animals per square meter** ([Nexus](#)) — Spawn-chance reduction for more deliberate wildlife.

Alternatives

- **No Predators on roads** ([Nexus](#)) — Abandoned (Aug 2017). Coexists with True Hunter.

Candidate TODO Additions

- **Next Gen Dragon VFX** ([Nexus](#))
- **Diverse 4thUnknown Dragons** ([Nexus](#)) — v1.17. Requires **Dragons SE** + **SkyPatcher**.
- **Dragons actually fall down** ([Nexus](#))
- **Epic Dwarven Centurion Combat** ([Nexus](#))
- **Skyrim Bandit Expansion**
- **Sleep of the Dead - A Draugr Leather and Shroud Replacer** ([Nexus](#))
- **Frozen Electrocuted Combustion** ([Nexus](#))
- **Better Butterflies** ([Nexus](#))

Audio and Feedback

MO2 Separator: [Audio](#) → [Audio - Music](#), [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

All mods in this section belong to one of the two audio separators as noted per subsection.

Music Overhaul Strategy → separator: [Audio - Music](#)

The soundtrack direction: how much to expand Skyrim's music while staying close to the Jeremy Soule baseline.

Baseline

- **Chapter II - Jeremy Soule Inspired Music** ([Nexus](#)) — Darker, more emotional melancholy without breaking from Soule's shape.
- **The Northerner Diaries - Immersive Edition** ([Nexus](#)) — Authentic Jeremy Soule compositions: 19 exploration tracks.
- **The Southerner Diaries** ([Nexus](#)) — 22 Soule-inspired exploration and town tracks.
- **Melodies of Civilization** ([Nexus](#)) — 20+ town, tavern, and settlement tracks.
- **Nyghtfall - Dark Fantasy Music** ([Nexus](#)) — ~7 hours, 98 dark-fantasy tracks. Evaluate after baseline is in place.
- **Nordenhamr - Viking Music** ([Nexus](#)) — Viking identity reinforcement.
- **BA Bard Songs** ([Nexus](#)) — Bard song replacer. Compatible with Skyrim's Got Talent.

Alternatives

- **Yggdrasil Music and SoundFX Overhaul** ([Nexus](#)) — Harsher, more ritualistic direction. Last updated April 2021.
- **Silent Combat Music** ([Nexus](#)) — Support option if combat music becomes intrusive.
- **Minimalist route** — Keep vanilla soundtrack.

Installation Notes

- If combining multiple music mods, use the Synthesis music-merge plugin for deliberate playlist merging.
- Keep generated music-merge output in its own dedicated MO2 mod. Rebuild when the music stack changes.
- See → [Performance](#) for Synthesis pipeline configuration.

Notes

- A very large combined soundtrack can feel incoherent if tracks don't share tonal identity.
 - Multiple music mods must be merged via Synthesis to avoid overlapping [MUSTT](#) records.
 - Any pre-2020 music mod may lack native AE support — verify before locking.
-

Weapon, Magic, And Impact SFX → separator: [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

The sound-effects layer for combat, magic, items, UI, and impact. The bar: modern, weighty, clear audio readable in third-person without visual confirmation.

Baseline

- **Immersive Sounds - Compendium** ([Nexus](#)) — Weapon-and-armor SFX baseline. Broadest patch ecosystem.
- **Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE** ([Nexus](#)) — Master reverb-and-attenuation layer. 27K endorsements, actively maintained (v4.1.4, April 2026).
- **Airgetlam - Shouts SFX** ([Nexus](#)) — Shout-audio companion. Replaces raw [.wav](#) files, no record conflicts.
- **Strange Runes** — Magic audio layer (cross-referenced from → [Magic & Perks](#)).

Load Order

[ISC](#) and [AOS](#) both edit large numbers of sound records. Load [AOS](#) after [ISC](#) so AOS's reverb/attenuation wins over ISC's raw effect swaps. [Airgetlam](#) loads after both.

Notes

- ISC is one of the oldest actively used Nexus mods (first uploaded 2013). Touches so many records that any update creates unexpected conflict pressure.
 - Airgetlam replaces raw audio files — should be loaded after any mod touching shout records.
-

Creature And NPC SFX → separator: [Audio - SFX & Ambience](#)

Baseline

- Minimalist route — rely on ISC + AOS for creature sounds. Add dedicated replacers only if testing reveals weak vocalisations.
- **Talkative Dragons** ([Nexus](#)) — Dragons speak during combat via reused vanilla voice lines. ESL-flagged, only overwrites one record ([CreatureDialogueDragon](#)). 15,478 endorsements.

Notes

- Creature sound [.wav](#) replacers are generally safe (no record conflicts). Sound descriptor editors must load after ISC and AOS.

- Talkative Dragons edits a dialogue record, not raw audio. Verify with dragon dialogue from Epic Dragon Combat REDONE.

Combat And Immersion Audio → separator: **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

Combat-specific and immersion-audio mods layering on top of the weapon/magic SFX baseline.

- **Precision (Nexus)** — Already locked in → **Third-Person**; audio impact is secondary.
- **Valhalla Combat (Nexus)** — Already locked; parry/stagger/timed-block audio feedback.
- **Heart of the Beast - Werewolf Sound and Camera Overhaul (Nexus)** — Werewolf audio baseline if **Growl** is adopted.
- **Heart of the Beast - Feral (Nexus)** — Alternative werewolf sounds. Choose one variant, not both.

Notes

- Only one Heart of the Beast variant active at a time. Both installed = file conflicts.
- If **Growl** adds new werewolf forms not covered by the sound replacer, forms fall back to Growl defaults.

Ambient And Environmental Audio → separator: **Audio - SFX & Ambience**

Environmental soundscapes, creature ambient sounds, and weather audio to reinforce world immersion outside of combat.

Baseline

- **Wildwood Echoes (Nexus)** — Forest and woodland soundscape expansion.
- **Blackreach Eerie Ambience (Nexus)** — Blackreach-specific ambient atmosphere.
- **Murder of Songbirds (Nexus)** — Ambient bird audio in wilderness areas.
- **Nordic Winds (Nexus)** — Weather-specific wind sound effects for colder regions.
- **Whispering Tomes of Apocrypha (Nexus)** — Apocrypha ambient soundscape.
- **Falmer 'Dialogue' Overhaul - Echolocation (Nexus)** — Falmer echolocation vocalisation replacer. Creature-audio companion layer.
- **Potema Revoiced (Nexus)** — Revoiced Potema dialogue. Overwrites vanilla voice files rather than dialogue records.

Notes

- All entries above are raw **.wav/.xwm** replacers or sound-descriptor mods — no record-level conflicts with ISC or AOS.
- Load sound-descriptor edits after ISC and AOS in left pane.
- Potema Revoiced replaces voice files only; verify compatibility with quest-expansion mods touching the Potema quest.

Survival, Difficulty, and Balance

MO2 Separator: **Survival & Combat** → **Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality**, **Survival & Combat - Enemy AI**, **Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries**

All mods in this section belong to one of the three survival/combat separators as noted per subsection.

Difficulty Framework → separator: **Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality**

Cross-load-order pressure: how quickly the world pushes back, how clearly dungeon progression reads, and whether difficulty comes from better structure instead of blunt stat inflation.

Baseline

- **Arena - An Encounter Zone Overhaul (Nexus)** — Cleanest middle ground: more progression pressure than vanilla, still readable and open-world friendly.

Alternatives

- **Minimal intervention** — Leave encounter zones close to vanilla.
- **Heavy world-structure** — Deleveled loot and stronger world gating (owned by → **Crafting & Economy**).

Notes

- Encounter-zone structure can overlap with loot/economy decisions if this section pretends it owns world progression.
- If **Arena** is combined with much harsher loot distribution, the result can overshoot from moody into over-gated.

Combat Lethality And Pacing → separator: **Survival & Combat - Difficulty & Lethality**

Tunes encounter harshness and time-to-kill on top of the combat framework from → **Third-Person**, not replacing it.

Baseline

- **Simply Balanced (Nexus)** — Preferred pacing tool. Final damage/progression tuning without re-owning stamina, injury, or combat behavior.

Alternatives

- **Blade and Blunt - A Combat Overhaul** (Nexus) — Deliberate branch — it reaches far beyond simple pacing.
- **Minimalist route** — Keep lethality in the section-04 combat stack.

Candidate

- **Relentless** (Nexus) — Difficulty and pacing mod. Research before adding; evaluate how it interacts with the Section-04 combat stack and Arena encounter zones.

Enemy AI Improvements → separator: **Survival & Combat - Enemy AI**

Baseline

- Restrained route — rely on **Arena**, the section-04 combat stack, and targeted creature/faction additions.
- **Less Sniperlike NPCs** (Nexus) — Reduces NPC projectile accuracy. Prefer applying via Wrye Bash (~70.0) to avoid an extra plugin.

Alternatives

- **Skyrim Revamped - Complete Enemy Overhaul** (Nexus) — High-commitment. Add only if ordinary testing shows enemy behavior still too flat.
- **NPCs Take Cover - Smarter Anti-Cheese AI** (Nexus) — NPCs take cover during combat instead of standing in the open. Lightweight, no new records.

Injury, Stamina, And Resource Pressure → separator: **Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries**

Attrition that lingers beyond a single swing: drained stamina, enforced downtime, the feeling that repeated bad fights accumulate a cost.

Baseline

- **Stress and Fear - A Dynamic Sanity System** (Nexus) — Emotional/pacing consequences encouraging rest, food, inns, and quieter recovery. Design is light enough to create stories without shouting over the rest of the list.
- **Light the Way - A Stress and Fear Add-On** (Nexus) — Light-flicker effect during high-stress moments.
- **Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed - Stress and Fear patch** (Nexus) — Cleanliness affects sanity. Required if both mods installed.

Alternatives

- **Blade and Blunt** — Overlapping alternative for harsher stamina-and-combat pressure.
- **Minimalist route** — Keep resource pressure inside existing combat/survival layers.

Enemy Resistances And Knowledge Checks → separator: **Survival & Combat - Enemy AI**

Baseline

- **Know Your Enemy 2** (Nexus) — Different creatures call for different tools; inspect system makes knowledge legible. Scope: tactical differentiation, not full enemy-ecosystem ownership.

Notes

- Resistance systems can feel punishing if the player doesn't have enough ways to adapt mid-run.
- For Steam 1.6.1170, the listed **Backported Extended ESL Support** requirement does not apply.
- If the inspect flow or resistance spread feels too noisy, the concept may be better than the lived experience.

Survival Systems Compatibility → separator: **Survival & Combat - Resources & Injuries**

How difficulty and pressure choices interact with the chosen survival framework.

Baseline

- Additive route — use pressure layers that reward existing survival behaviors (eating, resting, warming up, returning to town).
- **Stress and Fear** naturally plugs into meals, inns, sleep, and calmer downtime.
- If **StarFrost** remains the baseline, this section should amplify recovery need without forcing menu babysitting.
- **Cold Breath NG** (Nexus) (v1.8, May 2026) — Higher-fidelity fogged breath in cold environments. Mesh/particle replacer, no ESP.

Legacy of the Dragonborn

MO2 Separator: **Legacy of the Dragonborn**

All items in this section belong to the **Legacy of the Dragonborn** MO2 separator.

Core Mod Baseline

Treated as a foundational content pillar for the final list, not a late optional extra.

Baseline

- **Legacy of the Dragonborn** ([Nexus](#)) v6.10.1 (May 2026) — Non-negotiable centerpiece.
- **The Curator's Companion** ([Nexus](#)) v7.0.8 — In-game tracking for museum displays and collection progress.
- **Legacy of the Dragonborn Patches (Official)** ([Nexus](#)) v6.10.7 (June 2026) — Required integration infrastructure.
- **Paintings Replacer for Legacy of the Dragonborn SSE** ([Nexus](#) 13279, v1.1, Nov 2017) — Texture replacer, low risk.
- **Fate Cards Re-texture - Skyrim Concept Art** ([Nexus](#) 16080, v01, Mar 2018) — Texture replacer.
- **Placeable Display Cases** ([Nexus](#) 131107, v3.1, Jan 2025).
- **Achievement Injector** ([Nexus](#)) + **Legacy of the Dragonborn - Achievement Injector** ([Nexus](#)) — Museum achievement content.

Supported Content

Quest Mods With Strong LoTD Integration

- **VIGILANT** — Multiple display cases in Hall of Oddities.
- **Unslaad** — Official patch hub support.
- **Glenmoril** — Patch pipeline still maturing; check before locking.
- **Project AHO** — Full display room in Hall of Secrets.
- **Carved Brink** — Displays for Faceted Stones artifacts.
- **The Forgotten City** — Unique items and choice reward display.
- **Beyond Skyrim - Bruma** — Count-flation and display-base integration.
- **Beyond Reach** — Third-party patch.
- **The Wheels of Lull** — Hall of Secrets display slots.
- **Moon and Star** — Unique armor/weapon display.
- **Wyrmsooth** — Displays for unique items.
- **Falskaar** — Base museum count supports.
- **Sirenroot - A Verdant Tale** — Check patch status.
- **Midwood Isle** — Official patch support.
- **The Gray Cowl of Nocturnal** — Legendary mask display.
- **The Breton Paladin** — Official patch support.
- **Clockwork** — Unique item display slots.
- **Konahrik's Accoutrements** — Deep integration with dedicated display room.
- **Artifacts - The Ice Blade of the Monarch** — Standalone artifact with display.
- **Artifacts - The Tournament of the Ten Bloods** — New artifact quest with displays.
- **Obscure's College of Winterhold** — LoTD patch in OCW's own FOMOD. Covers private collection and unique College items.

Display Expansions And Room Mods

- **LoTD Display Patch Repos** — Third-party display patches not covered by official hub.
- **Museum Display Room Expansion** — Evaluate if base museum feels cramped.
- **Hall of Forgotten Guild** — Curator's Companion feature for additional collectible space.

Collectible Additions

- **Stones of Barenziah Quest Markers** — Dedicated display for completed crown.
- **Jewels of the Reach** — Additional gemstone collectible.
- **Dawnguard Treasure Map** — Feeds collection-driven exploration loop.

Artifact Enhancement

- **Zim's Immersive Artifacts** ([Nexus](#)) — 50+ vanilla artifact rebalances. If no official patch, load LoTD after ZIA so museum display conditions use LoTD records.

Patch Strategy

- Use **LoTD Patches (Official)** as default patch source.
- Add third-party patches only when official collection doesn't cover a finalized mod.
- Do not pre-install broad patch bundles for hypothetical mods.
- Re-check museum sorting behavior after each major content addition.

Mod Selection Questions

1. Does this mod have official or high-quality third-party LoTD patch support?
2. Does it add unique items that feel like they *should* be displayed?
3. Does it conflict with LoTD worldspace edits?
4. Does the play order fit the museum's unlock progression?

Submods And Quality-Of-Life

Sorting And Inventory

- **Legacy Safehouse Plus** — Expanded safehouse with additional crafting stations. Check v6.10+ compatibility.
- **LOTD - Explorer's Room** — Explorer-themed storage/display.
- **Quick Light** — Not LoTD-specific but essential for museum navigation.
- **Map Markers for LotD** — Fast-travel marker after quest conditions met.

Museum-Specific UI

- **LOTD Museum Exterior Fixes** — Navmesh and door-activation fixes.
- **LOTD Hall of Secrets Door Fix** — Door activator fix.
- **Object Manipulation Overhaul** — Display arrangement without console commands.

Additional QoL

- **LOTD - Museum Exterior Music** — Low priority; evaluate after → **Audio** is locked.
- **Dynamic Activation Key** — Reduces E-key scroll-conflict with crowded displays.

Relic System

- **Relic Hunter** — Evaluate compatibility with LoTD v6's own relic system.
- **LOTD - Explorer's League** — Guild-like progression. Check overlap with Curator's Companion.
- **Shovels - Dig Up Treasure** — Check for conflict with LoTD dig-site expeditions.

Notes

- Legacy of the Dragonborn can drag the whole load order toward completionist design.
- Museum-first progression changes perceived value of loot and unique-item mods.
- Quest mods with strong LoTD integration may co-determine the quest mod stack.
- Third-party display patches for pre-2023 quest mods may not be maintained against LoTD v6.

Modlist Curation Rules and Testing Plan

MO2 Separator: **Testing & Curation**

All items in this section belong to the **Testing & Curation** MO2 separator.

Curation Rules

Shared guardrails keeping individual picks consistent with the list's overall identity across every section.

Visual Style Consistency

Every texture, mesh, and lighting mod must be evaluated for visual coherence. Don't mix low-resolution vanilla-retexture packs with high-end PBR material overhauls in the same category. Prefer grounded, weathered, northern, wilderness-first color palettes over clean, heroic, or high-fantasy.

Lore Friendliness

New content must not contradict established Elder Scrolls lore (unless the contradiction is the deliberate point of a well-regarded quest mod). Cosmetics should respect setting: steel looks like steel, fur and leather dominate cold-region gear, architecture matches hold style. New content is welcome as long as it plausibly extends the existing world.

Third-Person-First Design With Full Gamepad Support

Every gameplay, animation, UI, camera, and interaction mod must be evaluated for third-person usability and gamepad compatibility first. The list must never force switching to first-person or keyboard/mouse for any interaction — lockpicking, reading, menus, crafting, dialogue, container looting, and favouriting. A mod that breaks the third-person gamepad experience is a poor fit regardless of individual quality.

Animation Quality Bar

Animations must meet the **Animations** baseline for blend smoothness, motion-capture fidelity, and weapon-type awareness. No clipping, snapping, floating, or poor foot-planting. The animation must look natural at standard gameplay speed in third-person, not only in slow-motion showcase clips.

Performance Target And Hardware Assumptions

Target: mid-range modern GPU (roughly RTX 3060 / RX 6700 equivalent) at 1440p with a 60 FPS target in most outdoor scenes. Dense forests and major cities may drop below 60 FPS; acceptable if above 45 FPS. Mods requiring DLSS/framegen reach playable framerates on target baseline must be flagged optional.

Preference For Lightweight Vs Feature-Rich Mods

When two mods solve the same goal, prefer the lighter option unless the feature-rich alternative brings a clearly measurable improvement. Lightweight: fewer deps, smaller plugin footprint, less script load, simpler patch requirements.

Rules For Avoiding Overlapping Overhauls

No two mods should overhaul the same gameplay system unless one is explicitly a compatibility layer. Examples: two perk overhauls, two magic systems, two encounter-zone overhauls, two survival frameworks, two independent combat animation packs for the same attack sets. Alternatives in section files must clearly state whether they are compatible add-ons or exclusive branches.

Testing Plan

Each stage targets a specific category of load-order risk, ordered so earlier stages catch common failures before later stages invest time in detailed playthrough evaluation.

Fresh Game Startup Checklist

1. Skyrim launches from MO2 without crash or infinite load.
2. Main menu displays correctly with all UI mods active.
3. New game reaches the alternate-start character-generation flow without freezing.
4. Character-generation menu (races, presets, body, sliders) works with all body/appearance mods.
5. Clean character save saves and loads without corruption or missing-master warnings.
6. MCM registers all expected configuration menus.
7. Console commands and basic navigation work without error spam.

If any step fails, do not proceed to later tests.

Character Creation Test

Verify: race/body preset/appearance sliders apply correctly; starting equipment/spells/inventory match alternate-start config; starting location loads without crashes, missing geometry, or broken lighting; perk/race/standing-stone overrides apply; first level-up triggers correctly; starting quest marker appears as expected.

Third-Person Combat Test

Five encounter types: one-handed+shield vs humanoid; two-handed power attacks vs large target; archery/ranged magic vs distant target; dual-wield or spell-sword vs fast enemy; mounted combat if horse overhaul is active. Verify: stable camera (lock-on, shoulder switching, free-look); dodge/block/parry/stagger trigger correctly; hit reactions/impact VFX/sound feedback play without delay; no animation breaks/snapping/T-posing; UI elements display correctly.

City Performance Test

Walk from gate to center in each major city (Whiterun, Solitude, Windhelm, Riften, Markarth). Record framerate range; note stutter/loading pauses/texture pop-in; check for missing objects, broken navmesh, stuck NPCs; verify city overhaul mods apply cleanly; confirm indoor cells load correct lighting. Fail if <45 FPS on target hardware or visual errors make area feel broken.

Forest Traversal Test

Travel through dense pine (Falkreath), aspen/deciduous (The Rift), and tundra transition (Whiterun plains near forest edge). Record framerate with grass/tree/LOD active; check grass pop-in, tree LOD shimmer, distant-object flicker; verify soundscape mods change between biomes; confirm encounters/wildlife/patrols spawn at expected intervals; test grass cache without dead zones. Passes if traversal stays playable (no sustained drops below 45 FPS) and biome transitions feel organic.

Dungeon Lighting Test

Enter Nordic ruin, cave/mine, Dwemer ruin. Verify: lighting overhaul produces readable contrast without crushing blacks; torch/magelight/candlelight illuminate correctly; interior acoustic changes match room size/material; no light bleed through walls, misaligned shadows, or fire flicker mismatch; enemy silhouettes visible enough for third-person targeting. Fail if any interior is unplayably dark or lighting errors break immersion in more than one room per dungeon.

UI And Controller Test

Test full UI with KB+M and controller: inventory/magic/map/journal/crafting menus open/navigate/close without errors; item cards display correct info; map renders correctly with quest markers in right positions; dialogue menus show full text; controller button mappings match expected layout; HUD elements display at correct size/position for target resolution. Fail if any menu is unusable on either input method or controller support requires manual INI editing.

Long-Session Stability Test

Play continuously for at least 2 hours: travel through 4+ worldspaces/holds including city-to-dungeon and fast-travel loads; complete 2 quest stages, 1 combat encounter, 1 menu-heavy activity; open/close MCM at least once; save/reload at least twice; check save file size and Papyrus log for accumulating errors. Passes if no crash, save remains loadable, no escalating error spam. Single crash = warning. Two crashes = failure requiring investigation.

Post-Install Smoke Test

Run after completing any numbered section.

#	Command	Location	Stress Profile
1	<code>coc Whiterun</code>	Whiterun	Major city — NPCs, shadows, architecture
2	<code>coc Solitude</code>	Solitude	Large city — water, long draw distances
3	<code>coc RiftenOrigin</code>	Riften	Canopy lighting, heavy NPC AI
4	<code>coc MarkarthOrigin</code>	Markarth	Dwemer stone, waterfalls, verticality
5	<code>coc Riverwood</code>	Riverwood	Forest exterior — grass, trees, landscape LOD
6	<code>coc BleakFallsBarrow01</code>	Bleak Falls Barrow	Interior dungeon — close-quarters lighting
7	<code>coc WhiterunBanneredMare</code>	Bannered Mare	Tavern interior — fire lighting, patron NPCs

Pass criteria: No crash on load. No missing textures. Target: ≥60 FPS during graphics-heavy stages (sections 02+); ≥40 FPS acceptable during section 01. If any location fails, the most recently installed mod or generation step is the first suspect.

Adult Content

MO2 Separator: `Adult Content`

All mods in this section belong to the `Adult Content` MO2 separator unless noted.

Framework Prerequisites

OStim Standalone — a modern, standalone adult animation framework that does not require OSA or SexLab. The OStim Romance and Amorous Adventures patch layer depend on this.

Baseline

- **OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — Modern adult animation framework. Does not require OSA.
- **OStim Community Resource** ([Nexus](#)) — Shared framework for OStim add-ons.
- **Night-blooming Violets for OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — Scene framework addon.
- **OARE - Open Animations Romance and Erotica** — Recommended animation pack baseline.
- **Additional Leito's Animations for Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — ~150 animations.
- **Anub's animations for Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — ~685 animations.
- **PPA - Procedural Penis Animations** ([Nexus](#)) — CBPC collision physics addon.
- **OSmp - Automatic SMP physics toggle for OStim** ([Nexus](#)) — ESL-flagged, supports CBBE 3BA and HIMBO.
- **Female Moan Voicesets For Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — 38 voicesets keyed to voice types.
- **Ostim SA-Sound Replacer-Blowjob** ([Nexus](#))
- **Male Orgasm Sounds For Ostim Standalone** ([Nexus](#))
- **OCum Ascended** ([Nexus](#)) — Cum and orgasm mechanics with visual layers.
- **Clean Navigation Icons for OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — 62 navigation icons.
- **Animation Pack Icons for OStim Standalone** ([Nexus](#)) — 18 icons.
- **OTooTiredToMove** ([Nexus](#)) — Temporary immobilisation after climax.

Notes

- OStim Standalone must not be loaded alongside legacy OSA or SexLab.
- OStim Romance and AA OStim patch must match the same OStim Standalone version.
- Keep auto-start settings conservative to avoid script load.

Romance Content

Opt-in quest-driven romance content running on top of the OStim framework.

Baseline

- **OStim Romance** ([Nexus](#)) — Primary romance-content baseline. Active maintenance.
- **Amorous Adventures OStim Standalone Patch** ([Nexus](#)) — Ports classic Amorous Adventures content to OStim Standalone.

Notes

- Lock the framework version first, then verify romance mod compatibility.
- Romance quests add dialogue/quest records that may conflict with → `World Content` or → `NPCs` overhauls.
- Verify load order with `RDO` and `Serana Dialogue Add-On` for overlapping NPCs.

NPCs And Dialogue → Adult Content

Baseline

- **Rigma - A male NPC overhaul** (Nexus) — Male NPC overhaul with focus on attractiveness. Includes SOS support and vanilla-facegen compatibility.
- **Rigma - KS Hairdos patch**
- **Haelga Reimagined** (Nexus) — Riften innkeeper dialogue expansion.
- **Soul-Crushing Romance - A Molag Bal Dialogue Mod** (Nexus) — Romance arc for House of Horrors quest.
- **Blood and Bismuth - A Farkas Dialogue Mod** (Nexus) — Farkas romance content.

Alternatives

- **The Billy The Goat Mod** (Nexus) — Novelty companion. Optional.
- **Shrooms of Solstheim** (Nexus) — Visual Solstheim flora upgrade. Adjacent to adult content.
- **BeeHH - Hentai Henchman** (Nexus) — Research item only. Conflicts with NFF.

Notes

- Rigma conflicts with other male NPC overhauls. If → **NPCs** locks **The Men of Winter**, Rigma must override on a per-NPC basis or be reconciled.
- Hygiene and bathing owned by **Bathing in Skyrim - Renewed** in → **Survival & Needs**. No separate bathing addon needed.

Main Character Voicing

MO2 Separator: Voicing

All mods in this section belong to the **Voicing** MO2 separator.

Framework Overview

Dragonborn Voice Over (DBVO) and Main Character Voice Over Generator (MCVO Generator) together give Skyrim's player character a voice. DBVO is the runtime framework; MCVO Generator scans the full load order and produces the data files for voice generation. Combined with AI voice synthesis (xVASynth or ElevenLabs), the player character speaks every dialogue line.

Baseline

- **Dragonborn Voice Over** (Nexus) — SKSE-based framework. Intercepts player dialogue and plays **.wav** files from installed voice pack. MCM allows switching packs per character. Required by MCVO Generator as a master.
- **Pre-made voice packs (drop-in):**
 - **Bella Voice DBVO** (Nexus) — Most popular female pack, broadest mod coverage.
 - **DBVO - Allison Voice Pack** (Nexus) — British female alternative.
 - Pre-made male packs are less common.
- **Recommended actress:** Jennifer Hale (Bella Voice DBVO uses spliced Hale VO catalog).
- **Recommended actor:** Travis Willingham (MCVO Generator + xVASynth pipeline).

Alternatives

- **MCVO Generator + xVASynth** (Nexus / Nexus) — Free custom-generation path. Quality is noticeably synthetic. Must re-run when load order changes.
- **ElevenLabs + DBVO Voice Pack Creator** — Premium path. Higher quality, more natural output. Requires paid account and Discord-only tool.

Notes

- DBVO requires ConsoleUtilSSE NG, JContainers SE, SkyUI, and SKSE64 (all in foundations stack).
 - DBVO must load after any mod editing **dialoguemenu.swf**. Place after the UI stack in the left pane.
 - Windows 255-char path limit can crash on startup — keep install path short.
 - Pre-made packs may not cover every mod. Uncovered lines fall back to subtitles.
 - MCVO Generator last updated March 2023; still works on 1.6.1170 but no active development.
 - xVASynth batch processing can take 2-3 hours for 50,000+ lines.
-

Dual Voice Pack Strategy

Two complete voice packs (one male, one female) for character flexibility. Install as separate MO2 mods, swap via MO2 profile or DBVO MCM.

- **Option A: Pre-Made Packs (Recommended)** — Female pack (Bella/Allison) + generate male via MCVO Generator + xVASynth (Geralt default).
 - **Option B: ElevenLabs Both** — Run tool twice with two voice IDs. Package as separate mods.
 - **Option C: MCVO + xVASynth Both** — Run once with male model, once with female model.
-

MCVO Generator + xVASynth Pipeline

Before Starting

- Install DBVO and dependencies. DBVO must be enabled and in the load order before running MCVO Generator.

- Build the full modlist in MO2 with final load order.
- Install xVASynth and desired voice models (default male: Geralt of Rivia pack from Witcher 3 Nexus 5676).
- Download MCVO Generator from Nexus, extract to convenient location.

Generating the Voice Pack

1. Run MCVO Generator (DBVO-All.exe). Produces DBVO-All.esp in Data\ and DBVO-All.csv. Add the .esp to MO2 as new mod.
2. Open xVASynth in Batch Mode, load DBVO-All.csv, select voice model, click **Generate**.
3. xVASynth outputs .wav files under Data\Sound\Voice\Dragonborn Voice Over\. Create MO2 mod from this folder structure.
4. Launch game through SKSE, open DBVO MCM, select voice pack, test dialogue lines.

Generating The Second Set (Male/Female)

Repeat steps 2-4 with different voice model. Create separate MO2 mod. Enable one at a time.

ElevenLabs Custom Voice Pack

Prerequisites

- ElevenLabs paid account (Creator \$22/mo. recommended for full load order).
- DBVO Voice Pack Creator tool (DBVO author's Discord, #tool-download channel).
- ElevenLabs API key.

Voice Selection

Browse ElevenLabs Voice Library or use Voice Design. Get voice ID via GET https://api.elevenlabs.io/v1/voices.

Generating

1. Run MCVO Generator to produce DBVO-All.csv.
2. Use DBVO Voice Pack Creator: point at CSV, enter API key and voice ID, run.
3. Package output as MO2 mod.

Character Quota Planning

Creator plan (100,000 chars/month) covers ~15,000-20,000 lines. Full 50,000+ line load order may need Pro plan (\$99/month, 500,000 chars) or multiple months. Use free tier (10,000 chars/month) for testing only.

Performance and Technical Workflow

MO2 Separator: Performance

Overview

This section owns the performance budgeting, optimization discipline, generated-patch pipeline, and long-term maintenance workflow that keeps Elder Wilds stable as the load order grows. The section is split into five sub-files that each own a distinct concern:

- **Performance Strategy:** budgeted performance analysis, VRAM-heavy mod review, CPU-heavy script review
- **Optimization & Configuration:** shader impact, grass/tree/draw-call optimization, INI tuning (BethINI Pie baseline), save safety
- **Tool Pipeline:** xEdit/Pandora/DynDOLOD/Synthesis workflow discipline, 4K LOD baseline (xLODGen/TexGen/DynDOLOD STEP config), optional diagnostics (Recursion Monitor, S.L.A.C.K.)
- **Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration:** exact Wrye Bash tweak settings, Bash Tag per plugin, full Synthesis patcher pipeline (11 stages), build order and rebuild triggers
- **Testing & Maintenance:** benchmark methodology and scenarios, tuning knobs, patcher revisit triggers, generator output order, change tracking, MCM recording, mod update workflow

Sub-File Index

File	Section
modlist-performance-strategy.md	Performance Strategy
modlist-performance-optimization.md	Optimization & Configuration
modlist-performance-tools.md	Tool Pipeline
modlist-performance-patches.md	Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration
modlist-performance-testing.md	Testing & Maintenance

Key Principles

- Treat performance as four separate problems: shader cost, VRAM pressure, CPU/script load, and exterior draw-call pressure. A fix that targets the wrong category makes things worse.
- Use the disciplined route for all generated work: keep every output in its own dedicated MO2 mod, rebuild only when the owning category changes, and run tools in a repeatable order.
- The Bashed Patch and Synthesis pipeline is the single source of truth for conflict resolution. A tag or patcher exists only when a specific mod in the list requires it.
- The list's long-term health depends on disciplined rebuild habits, saved MCM profiles, and a documented changelog — not on any single mod pick.

Related Sections

- [modlist-foundations.md](#) — engine baseline, SSE Display Tweaks config, core stability fixes
- [modlist-graphics-shaders.md](#) — Community Shaders visual framework (performance envelope owned by [modlist-performance-optimization.md](#))
- [modlist-curation.md](#) — curation rules and testing methodology

Performance Strategy

MO2 Separator: Performance

All items in this section belong to the [Performance](#) MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance](#) and [Technical Workflow](#) section.

Performance Budgeting

How [Elder Wilds](#) measures performance, identifies bottlenecks, and keeps generated workflow sane once the list gets heavy.

Baseline

- **Budgeted route** — Separate GPU, VRAM, CPU/script, and draw-call problems so fixes target the real cause.
- Treat performance as four different problems that can look similar: shader cost, VRAM pressure, CPU/script load, and exterior draw-call pressure.
- Keep one repeatable forest scene, one city scene, and one dungeon/interior scene for comparisons.
- Record baseline and post-change captures with [PresentMon](#) and review in [CapFrameX](#).
- Prefer a stable frame-time target over chasing the highest uncapped number.

Alternatives

- **Intuition-first route** — Change settings/mods by feel.
- **Average-FPS route** — Judge by headline FPS even if frame pacing and bottleneck type stay unclear.

Notes

- A single bad scene can be CPU-bound, GPU-bound, or content-bound in different directions.
 - Average FPS can improve while hitching and traversal smoothness get worse.
-

VRAM-Heavy Mod Review

Texture resolution, PBR/parallax adoption, heavy shader features, and world coverage drive VRAM pressure. Spend texture budget where visible in normal play.

Baseline

- **Selective route** — High resolution only for hero assets, creatures, architecture, or landscape layers dominating the screen.
- Start below maximum resolution when a visual pack offers multiple sizes; scale up only if testing proves the asset earns it.
- Treat PBR/parallax conversions as a VRAM and maintenance choice, not just a screenshot upgrade.
- If a scene stutters, verify actual memory pressure before blaming scripts or AI.

Alternatives

- **Max-detail route** — Broad 4K coverage, frequent material upgrades.
- **Restraint-first route** — Mostly 2K and below with few exceptions.

Notes

- High VRAM usage can look like generic stutter, but lowering unrelated gameplay mods won't fix it.
 - Some landscape/architecture/material upgrades cost more in aggregate than character textures ever will.
-

CPU-Heavy Script Review

CPU and Papyrus pressure comes from layered systems, NPC density, polling scripts, and constant background updates.

Baseline

- **Moderated route** — Keep strong feature mods, but avoid stacking several background-heavy systems solving similar jobs.
- Treat NPC expansion, survival layers, follower frameworks, reputation systems, defeat systems, and ambient event mods as cumulative load.
- Prefer one good system per gameplay problem instead of three lighter systems all ticking in the background.
- Keep diagnostic logging off during normal play unless a bug needs it.
- Judge script health through sleeping, waiting, cell changes, combat cleanup, and long travel.

Alternatives

- **Permissive route** — Allow multiple overlapping always-on systems.
- **Strict route** — Aggressively cut scripted features even when they materially help list identity.

Notes

- Script delay often misdiagnosed as low FPS or "Skyrim being Skyrim."
- Mid-save uninstalls can create save instability looking like performance decay.
- A list can feel fine in short tests and still degrade over longer sessions.

Optimization & Configuration

MO2 Separator: Performance

All items in this section belong to the [Performance](#) MO2 separator.

Part of the [Performance and Technical Workflow](#) section.

Shader Performance Impact

Baseline

- **Conservative to balanced route** — Accept a few heavier depth/lighting features once the rest of the visual stack is stable.
- Remove or downgrade luxury modules before tearing apart the rest of the graphics stack.
- [Skyrim Upscaler](#) is a fallback tool from → [Graphics](#), not the first answer to poor optimization.
- Use [SSE Display Tweaks](#) from → [Foundations](#) to enforce stable frame cap.
- Judge shader cost in motion, weather transitions, and dense foliage scenes.

Alternatives

- **Conservative route** — Keep CS close to the section-02 baseline.
 - **Luxury route** — Keep piling on expensive modules, then try to recover cost elsewhere.
-

Grass, Tree, And Draw-Call Optimization

Baseline

- **Content restraint first, then low-maintenance optimization.**
- **Lightened Skyrim** — Leading optimization branch. Almost invisible cleanup, low drama.
- **eFPS - Exterior FPS boost** — Optional only if exterior draw-call pressure still needs help after main world stack is stable. Plan for patch coverage.
- Re-evaluate exterior optimization after major city, roadside, tree, or world-content choices.

Notes

- [eFPS](#) has strong upside but real compatibility/patch overhead for lists with heavy exterior edits.
 - Heavy cities, outskirts, roads, trees, and landmark mods can erase optimization gains faster than tweak mods can recover them.
-

INI Tuning And Display Settings

Baseline

- **Tool-first route** — Use [BethINI Pie](#) as the baseline editor.
- Keep MO2 INI path behavior simple and documented.
- After baseline is set, keep only a short list of manual overrides justified by display/shadow/frame-cap targets.
- Let [SSE Display Tweaks](#) handle display behavior and frame pacing.

BethINI Pie Configuration Baseline

Run through MO2 targeting the active profile INIs.

1. **Basic:** Reset to Defaults → High preset → Apply Recommended Tweaks. Window Mode: Borderless. FOV: First Person 75, Third Person 85.
2. **General** → **Saved Games:** Untick Autosaves, Save on Travel, Save on Rest, Save on Wait (survival mods handle save restrictions; manual saves are safer).

3. **Gameplay:** Difficulty Adept. Untick Disable Kill Cam. Tick Remove Borders. Untick Tutorials.
4. **Interface:** Tick Dialogue Subtitles and General Subtitles. Leave Compass and Crosshair ticked. Untick Floating Quest Markers. Leave Controller Vibration ticked.
5. **Environment:** Grass Density 60. Untick Reflect Sky.
6. **View Distance:** Leave Tree LOD Distance at High default for now. Set to 0 via INI Editor before DynDOLOD generation later.
7. **Visuals:** Max Particle Render Count 7500. Untick Lens Flare (CS handles post-processing).
8. Click Save and Exit, then confirm values in **M02 → Tools → INI Editor**.

Save Safety Considerations

Baseline

- **Disposable-test route** — Keep clean labeled saves for pre-LOD, post-LOD, city-performance, forest-travel, and long-session stability.
- Start new game when adding major worldspace optimization layers (eFPS mod page recommends fresh-start caution).
- Don't treat old generated outputs, removed scripted mods, or stale occlusion data as safe just because the game still loads.
- Preserve one or two mature long-session saves only for validation.

Notes

- Save corruption can present as performance degradation long before it looks like hard failure.
- Reusing one heavily mutated test save makes optimization conclusions far less trustworthy.

Tool Pipeline

MO2 Separator: Performance

All items in this section belong to the **Performance** MO2 separator.

Part of the **Performance and Technical Workflow** section.

Tool Workflow

A heavy Skyrim list usually becomes unstable through stale output and sloppy rebuild habits before failing through any one mod choice.

Baseline — Disciplined Route

- Run **xEdit** conflict review after each major category change.
- Re-run **Pandora** when behavior, animation, or skeleton-relevant content changes.
- Re-run **Synthesis** whenever a chosen patcher-based system changes (including music-merge from → **Audio**).
- Rebuild **TexGen**, **xLODGen**, **DynDOLOD**, grass cache, and occlusion output when their inputs materially change.
- Keep every generated output in its own dedicated MO2 mod.

Alternatives

- **Ad hoc route** — Rebuild whenever something looks broken.
- **Late-everything route** — Postpone most generated work until the end.

4K LOD Tool Baseline

General Rules

- Keep tools (**xLODGen**, **TexGen**, **DynDOLOD**) outside game folder and outside MO2 mod folders.
- Keep output folders outside Program Files, Steam, Documents, Desktop, and MO2 instance.
- Install finished output back into MO2 as separate mods: **Terrain LOD Output**, **TexGen Output**, **DynDOLOD Output**.
- Generate in this order: **xLODGen** → **TexGen** → **DynDOLOD**.
- Use **x64** versions of tools.

xLODGen 4K STEP Baseline

- MO2 executable: **xLODGenx64.exe -lodgen -SSE -o:"<output path>"**.
- Use **xLODGen** only for terrain LOD.
- Use **SSE-Terrain-Tamriel-Extend.esm** as terrain-boundary resource (from STEP xLODGen forum; Mega mirrors available). Load as early as possible in load order.
- Select all worldspaces. Tick only **Terrain LOD**.
- 4K users: double diffuse and normal sizes for LOD4/LOD8/LOD16/LOD32.
- Initial LOD4: keep **Optimize Unseen** off. For map/LOD32: use higher **Quality** (0-10) and **Optimize Unseen** ~550.

- After generation, run **ACMOS Road Generator** with **Roads = Path Only**, overwrite LOD textures.

TexGen 4K STEP Baseline

- MO2 executable: **TexGen64.exe -SSE**.
- Run after **xLODGen**, before **DynDOLOD**.
- Preset matching rendered resolution: **2160p = 4K**.
- Grass options: tick **Grass** if no complex grass; tick **HD grass** if using complex grass / CS grass features.
- **TexGen_SSE.ini**: **GrassModelHeightMultiplier=1.15**, **TreeMSAlphaThreshold=144**, **ObjectMSAlphaThreshold=96**.
- **ForceComplexGrass**: **0** (default) or **1** (STEP complex-grass branch).
- Move output to **TexGen Output** mod, enable before running **DynDOLOD**.

DynDOLOD 4K STEP Baseline

- MO2 executable: **DynDOLODx64.exe -SSE**.
- **DynDOLOD_SSE.ini**: **Expert=1**, **Level32=1** **AllHDL0D32=1**.
- Grass brightness values: **0.500** for all R/G/B Top and Bottom channels.
- **DoubleSidedTextureMask=mountain,mtn**, **DoubleSidedMeshMask=mountain,mtn**.
- Complex grass branch: **ComplexGrassBillboard=5**, matching brightness values, **ComplexGrassBacklightMask=25**.
- GUI: select all worldspaces, tick **Candles** and **FXGlow**, click **High**.
- **Occlusion** only on first run. **Grass LOD** only if generating grass LOD.
- Target: **4K** preset with **Optimal** tree/catch-all rules + recommended **LOD32** rules.
- Move output to **DynDOLOD Output** mod, enable **DynDOLOD.esm** and **DynDOLOD.esp**, sort with LOOT.

4K Validation

- Benchmark before and after LOD from clean Whiterun save. Also check the Rift (**cow tamriel 40 -24**) for aspens.
- If performance is already below STEP's pre-LOD target, lower the broader graphics baseline before blaming LOD.
- If travel performance still too expensive after LOD, step DynDOLOD from High → Medium/Low, skip Grass LOD.
- Document emergency tweaks next to the MO2 executable or output mod.

Optional Diagnostics And Performance Tools

Neither requires ongoing configuration or conflict maintenance once installed.

Recursion Monitor

- **Nexus: Recursion Monitor** — Detects broken Papyrus scripts stuck in recursive loops. Requires SKSE, Address Library.
- **Updated fork: recursion-fix-updated** (May 2026) — Removes blocking debug popup; writes to SKSE log instead. Prefer for production list.

S.L.A.C.K. (Save And Load Accelerator For SKSE Cosaves)

- **Nexus: S.L.A.C.K.** — Cosaves save up to 150× faster, load up to 15× faster. Error-friendly mode catches exceptions from other SKSE plugins' cosave handlers.
- Requires: SKSE 1.6.1170, Address Library, SSE Engine Fixes (SKSE64 Preloader).
- Safe to install or uninstall at any time.
- Complements **Seamless Saving** (targets main save serialisation, not cosaves). Safe to run both.

Notes

- Neither mod touches worldspace records, leveled lists, or asset files.
- Recursion Monitor is read-only in normal operation. Updated fork removes the only known compatibility concern.
- S.L.A.C.K. hooks SKSE's internal save/load API; error-friendly mode catches exceptions instead of crashing.
- Both are safe to remove from an existing save.

Bashed Patch & Synthesis Configuration

MO2 Separator: Performance

All items in this section belong to the **Performance** MO2 separator.

Part of the **Performance and Technical Workflow** section.

Core Idea

- The generic category maps only become useful when tied to the actual mods **Elder Wilds** ships with. This section is that binding: exact **Wrye Bash** tweaks, **Bash Tags** per plugin, and **Synthesis** patcher pipeline in exact order.
 - Default is "do not touch" — add a **Synthesis** patcher or **Bash Tag** only when a specific mod in the list makes it necessary.
-

Wrye Bash (Bashed Patch) Configuration

Tweak Settings

Enable in **Wrye Bash** → **Bashed Patch** → **Tweakers** only the items below.

Tweak Actors:

- **Opposite Gender Anims: Female** and **Male** — needed for CBBE 3BA, HIMBO, KS Hairdos, EVG Conditional Idles, Goetia, Leviathan II packs.

Tweak Assorted:

- **All Armor Playable** — required by Immersive Armors (60+ sets with non-playable flag).
- **No Light Fade Value Fix** — CS Light, True Light, ELFX, Relighting Skyrim, Luminosity all interact with fade values.
- **No Light Flicker** — RAID Weathers, Cathedral, Obsidian, Azurite III CS weather variants.
- **Remove Load Screen Models** — SkyParkour v3, RaySense, Ricochet add 3D geometry that can leak into load screens.
- **Save Sorting Fix** — real issue with this much plugin weight.
- **Set Light Radii** — use 100% multiplier to leave lighting radii alone.
- **Set Sound Attenuation Levels: Nirnroots Only** — leave default.
- **Uniform Groundcover** — Skoglendi, Origins of Forest, Mari's flora need matching density variance.

Tweak Names:

- **Body Part Codes** — drive Sort: Armor/Clothes correctly with CBBE 3BA.
- **Sort: Armor/Clothes** — with Immersive Armors, Bruma, Spaghetti's Cities, unsorted inventory is unreadable.
- **Sort: Scrolls, Sort: Spells, Sort: Weapons/Ammunition** — Apocalypse, Mysticism, Odin, Adamant, Vokrii, Ordinator, Ars Metallica all add to these lists.
- **Lore Friendly Text: Dwarven -> Dwemer** — PBR textures use Dwemer terminology.

Tweak Races:

- **Races Have All Head Parts** — KS Hairdos adds hundreds; set types code to ~45.
- **Playable Head Parts**
- **Leave Force Behavior Graph Gender** off — Elder Wilds does not standardize that flag.

Tweak Settings:

- **AI: Bump Reaction Delay** — raise to Adult Content to mute spammy follower reactions.
- **AI: Conversation Chance** — leave default.
- **AI: Max Active Actors** — raise to 80.
- **AI: Max Dead Actors** — raise to 120.
- **Arrow: Max Arrows Attached to NPC** — raise to 20.
- **Combat: Max Actors** — raise to 60.
- **Combat: Stealth Damage Bonus** — leave default (RAID is canonical authority).
- **Msg: Cannot Equip Item Fix** — **must** be enabled (Campfire, Frostfall, SunHelm/Starfrost/Last Seed rely on it).
- **Msg: No Fast Travel** — leave default.
- **Player: Max Draggable Weight** — set to 1000.
- **Player: Underwater Breath Control** — leave default.
- **Soul Trap: Common/Grand/Greater/Lesser Soul Level** — set to vanilla values.
- **Visuals: Masser/Secunda Size/Speed** — set to 1.0.
- **Warning: Exterior/Interior Distance To Hostiles** — leave default.
- **World: Cell Respawn Time / Respawn Time (Cleared)** — leave default.
- **World: Timescale** — set to 20 and never change. **Save-baking warning:** this setting bakes into SSE saves.

Bash Tags

Set the following **Bash Tags** on the listed plugins (one file per plugin under **Data\Bash Patches**):

Leveled List / Economy:

- **Immersive Weapons.esp** — Relev
- **Immersive Armors.esp** — Relev
- **Immersive Armors Retexture.esp** — Graphics (retexture, not content add)
- **Hunterborn.esp** — Invent.Add, Delev, Relev
- **Simple Fishing Overhaul.esp** — Invent.Add, C.MiscFlags
- **Streamlined Fishing.esp** — Invent.Add
- **Open World Loot.esp** — Delev, Relev, C.Encounter
- **MorrowLoot Ultimate.esp** — Delev, Relev
- **Trade and Barter.esp** — Stats, Invent.Change
- **Ars Metallica.esp** — Stats, Invent.Change
- **Complete Crafting Overhaul Remastered.esp** — Stats, Invent.Change
- **Honed Metal.esp** — Invent.Change
- **Apothecary.esp** — Invent.Add, Stats, Keywords
- **CACO.esp** — Invent.Add, Stats, Keywords

- [Alchemy Potions and Food Adjustments.esp](#) — Stats, Keywords

Race / Perk / Magic:

- [Aetherius.esp](#) / [Morningstar.esp](#) / [Imperious.esp](#) — [R.AddSpells](#) (whichever wins)
- [Adamant.esp](#) / [Vokrii.esp](#) / [Ordinator.esp](#) — [NPC.Perks.Change](#), [NPC.Perks.Add](#)
- [Mysticism.esp](#) / [Odin.esp](#) / [Apocalypse.esp](#) — [SpellStats](#), [EffectStats](#)

Lighting / Weather / Water:

- [CS Light.esp](#) / [True Light.esp](#) — [C.Light](#), [C.ImageSpace](#)
- [ELFX.esp](#) / [ELFX - Shadows.esp](#) — [C.Light](#), [C.Fog](#)
- [Relighting Skyrim.esp](#) / [Luminosity.esp](#) — [C.Light](#)
- [RAID Weathers.esp](#) / [Raid Weathers CS.esp](#) — [C.Climate](#), [C.Music](#) (if pack changes music)
- [Cathedral Weathers.esp](#) / [Obsidian Weathers.esp](#) / [Obsidian - CS.esp](#) — [C.Climate](#)
- [Realistic Water Two.esp](#) — [C.Water](#)
- [A Water Made For CS in mind.esp](#) — [C.Water](#)
- [Simplicity of Sea.esp](#) — [C.Water](#)
- [Enhanced Rocks and Mountains.esp](#) / [Fix and Addon.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [ObjectBounds](#)

City / Worldspace:

- [Beyond Skyrim - Bruma SE.esp](#) — [C.Climate](#), [C.Music](#), [C.Light](#), [C.Water](#), [C.ImageSpace](#), [C.Location](#), [C.Regions](#)
- [Spaghetti's Cities - AIO.esp](#) — [C.Light](#), [C.MiscFlags](#)
- [The Great Cities - Minor Cities and Towns SSE.esp](#) / [Dawn of Skyrim \(Director's Cut\) SE.esp](#) / [JK's Skyrim.esp](#) — [C.Light](#), [C.MiscFlags](#)

NPC / Dialogue / Audio:

- [RUSTIC CLUTTER COLLECTION.esp](#) / [RUSTIC CLOTHING.esp](#) — [Names](#), [Stats](#)
- [High Poly Project.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [ObjectBounds](#)
- [KS Hairdos SSE.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [Names](#)
- [High Poly True to Vanilla NPC Overhaul.esp](#) — [Graphics](#), [Names](#), [Actors.Stats](#)
- [RDO.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackages](#), [Actors.Spells](#)
- [Amorous Adventures.esp](#) (clean) — [Actors.AIPackagesForceAdd](#), [Actors.SpellsForceAdd](#), [Invent.Add](#)
- [Marriage Mod - To Have And To Hold.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackagesForceAdd](#), [Actors.Factions](#)
- [Serana Dialogue Add-On.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackages](#), [Actors.Spells](#)
- [Pilgrim.esp](#) / [Trua.esp](#) / [Wintersun.esp](#) — [Actors.Spells](#) (whichever wins)
- [Book of Shadows.esp](#) — [Actors.Spells](#)
- [Skyrim Reputation.esp](#) — [Actors.Factions](#), [Relations.Add](#)
- [Suspicious City Guards.esp](#) — [Actors.AIPackages](#)
- [Audio Overhaul for Skyrim SE.esp](#) — [Sound](#)
- [Immersive Sounds - Compendium.esp](#) — [Sound](#)
- [Sounds of Skyrim Complete SE.esp](#) — [Sound](#), [C.Acoustic](#)

Survival / Follower:

- [Campfire.esp](#) — [C.MiscFlags](#), [Invent.Add](#)
- [Frostfall.esp](#) — [C.Climate](#), [C.ImageSpace](#)
- [Starfrost.esp](#) / [SunHelm.esp](#) / [Last Seed.esp](#) — [Stats](#), [Keywords](#), [Invent.Add](#) (whichever wins)
- [Nether's Follower Framework.esp](#) / [EFF.esp](#) / [Amazing Follower Tweaks SE.esp](#) — [Actors.Factions](#), [Invent.Add](#)

No Tags: [TrueHUD.esp](#), [Sovngarde - Mist's Font Replacer.esp](#)

Synthesis Configuration

The [Synthesis](#) patcher pipeline runs as a single batch via [Run Mutagen](#) in MO2, output to [Patches\Synthesis Patch.esp](#). Patchers listed in run order — do not reorder.

Stage 1 — NPC, AI, And Facegen

- [KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer](#)
- [High Poly Head Vampire Fix](#)
- [HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART](#)
- [FacegenBaseline](#) — after all NPC overhauls installed; fallback to zEdit FaceGen patcher if needed.
- [NPCStatRescaler](#)
- [AIOverhaulPatcher](#) / [ICAIO AI for Mods](#)
- [AI Stealth Overhaul](#) — with RAID.
- [Followers-are-Sneaky](#)
- [FollowerFavorCarryLimitPatcher](#)
- [NpcProtector](#) — flags essential quest NPCs.

- RaceCompatibilityDialogue
- RacialHeights / HarmonizedRaceHeights-Patcher
- SynBanditWarForwarder
- SynOppositeGenderAnimsTweak — **do not enable** (Bashed Patch handles this).

Stage 2 — Encounter Zones

- EZLeveler — configure to unlevelled-band target for OWL/MLU.
- EnemyReleveler — delevel Bruma/Falskaar/Wyrmstooth enemies within new band.
- No More Easy Enemies
- EncounterZoneNames / CellEncounterLevelsInName
- MissingEncounterZonesPatcher
- TrueUnlevelledSkyrim — only if dropping OWL and MLU.

Stage 3 — Leveled Lists And Loot

- OWLLeveledListAddition — adds IA/IW to OWL lists.
- OWLPatcher
- Skyrim-LeveledLoot
- HalgarisConsistentRPG Loot
- Container and Loot Patcher
- LootableCrates, MakeFirewoodPilesIntoContainers, Lootable Things & Training Dummies Patcher
- GeneralStoresIngredientsPatcher
- ImmersiveMusicPatcher / MusicTypePatcher-Revised-2024
- leveledlistresolver — after OWL and MLU.
- Feminized Leveled Lists / Masculinized Leveled Lists

Stage 4 — Items, Crafting, Alchemy

- ApothecaryAutoPatcher — pair with CACO Patcher if CACO in stack.
- BreakdownRecipeGenerator / CreateTemper
- HonedMetalAdditionalIngredients
- Heim Recipe Patcher
- ReProccer Evolved
- Weapon Stat Synthesis Patcher (Nexus) — Elder Wilds config: Damage Floor 4, Ceiling 22, Weight/Value Scale 1.0, Speed/Reach Normalization ON. Ignore List: Reliquary of Myth, ArteFakes, Unique Items Tweaks, Konahrik's Accoutrements. Run after OWLLeveledListAddition, SpeedandReachFixes, AmmoTweaks.
- SpeedandReachFixes
- WeaponSpeedEffectsFix
- SynFixShieldData / SynFixWeaponAttackSpeed
- SynGlovesAddFirstsPerk
- ItemWeightCustomizer / SynPotionWeight
- SlotsSlotsSlots
- AmmoTweaks
- SynCGOStaves — only if CGO staves in stack.

Stage 5 — Magic, Spells, Enchanting

- Engarde_Synthesis
- DisenchantEverything / SmartDisenchantEverything
- Passive Enchanting Experience
- Spell Research Synthesizer — only if Spell Research added.
- StaffGenerator / StaffDuplicator
- SorcererPatcher
- ReadingIsGoodLegacy
- AllBooksHavePerks
- SpellTomePriceFixPatcher / SynSpellTomeNameExtender / DisplaySpellTomeLevelPatcher-local / spelltome_yeeter — pick one.
- SynESLify — **must be last** in this stage.

Stage 6 — Snow, Weather, Region

- BDSPPatcher — **required**. Use BDSPPatcher entry (not Northpoint variant). Run with both BetterDynamicSnow and BetterDynamicAsh keywords active.
- SSBGPatcher
- Nights Adjuster / Darker Weather Nights — pick one.
- SkyVRaan Weather Patcher — only if installed.
- Unique Region Names / Unique Region Names Patcher
- RealisticWaterTwoPatcher
- Synthesis-BlendedShorelinesUniversal
- LandscapePatcher — only enable if landscape texture stack replaced.
- DestructibleSkyrimPatcher

Stage 7 — Trees, Flora, Mesh

- Pine Tree Rescaler
- Tree Scaler, Tree 3D Editor, TreeWindEditor
- FloraFixer
- ImmersiveEquipmentMeshGen / AllGUDMeshGen
- Harvest Those Mammoth Tusks

Stage 8 — Visuals And Lighting

- ELE Patcher — skip (CS-only stack).
- ENB Light Patcher — skip.
- NoShadowsPatch
- Radial Blur Remover
- Remove Edge Glow
- RemoveInteriorFogPatcher — disable if AOS/Sounds of Skyrim present.
- RemoveLandscapeVertexColor

Stage 9 — Audio

- AOSISCSoundPatcher — **required**. AOS and ISC both must be active when run.
- TUDMFootstepPatcher
- Sounds of Seasons
- SFCOPaintingRemover

Stage 10 — Performance And Cleanup

- Grass FPS
- Configurable Grass Remover — enable only if dense forest-floor route adopted.
- NavmeshCollector-Updated — **do not** enable if Bruma or Falskaar in stack.
- Generic Synthesis Patcher — keep ruleset empty until specific conflict identified.

Stage 11 — Utility, Compatibility, ESLification

- Patchifier — generates SkyPatcher/INI patches.
- SynEDIDFixer
- SynStringMerger — disable unless shipping translation layer.
- CellEditorIDFixer — required (Bruma, Falskaar, Wyrmsstooth, Beyond Reach).
- SynPEXPatcher
- SynPerkCOBJPatcher / SynESLify — **keep at end**, ESLify output.

Build Order And Rebuild Triggers

1. **SSEEdit** fast mode after every new plugin.
2. **Bashed Patch** — triggers: any plugin with Bash Tag change, any tweak setting change, any new tagged plugin.
3. **Synthesis** — triggers: any patcher list change, any upstream mod change, any Bash Tag change.
4. **xLODGen + TexGen** — triggers: landscape/terrain/object mesh change.
5. **DynDOLOD** — triggers: worldspace/tree/object/Bashed Patch/Synthesis change. Run twice: Medium to verify, final preset.
6. **Pandora** — triggers: behavior/animation/skeleton change.
7. **BodySlide** — triggers: body/skin/armor mesh change.
8. **Grass Cache** — triggers: grass mod or Worldspaces with Grass SSEEdit Script change.
9. **SSE Display Tweaks + BethINI Pie** review — triggers: lighting/weather/graphics stack change.

Rebuilding one stage does not replace stages after it.

Notes

- Bashed Patch and Synthesis both write into same load-order range. Place Synthesis patch last unless a known conflict needs Bashed Patch to win.
- SynESLify **must** be last in its stage.
- World: Timescale = 20 bakes into saves — never change on a long-running test save.
- Skyrim-LeveledLoot and OWL overlap: run OWLLeveledListAddition first.
- AOSISCSoundPatcher requires both AOS and ISC active.
- HP_NPC_WIGS_TO_HEADPART before KS Hairs Bald Helmets Fixer.
- NavmeshCollector-Updated dangerous with Bruma and Falskaar.
- Record Bashed Patch CRC after every rebuild. Verify by disabling source mods and confirming patch shrinks.

Key Principles

- The patch pipeline is the single source of truth for conflict resolution.
- A patcher or tag exists because a specific mod in the list requires it — never pre-install speculative coverage.
- The rebuild order is designed so a category change only triggers the affected stages.

Testing & Maintenance

MO2 Separator: Performance

All items in this section belong to the Performance MO2 separator.

Part of the Performance and Technical Workflow section.

Performance Testing And Tuning

The goal is consistent frametimes — not just a high average FPS — across the scenarios you actually play.

Tools

Tool	Purpose
NVIDIA FrameView	Lightweight overlay/logging: FPS, frametime, GPU power, thermals. No CPU per-core but lower overhead.
MSI Afterburner + RivaTuner	Full overlay/logging: FPS, frametime, GPU usage, CPU per-core, VRAM, draw calls, temps.
GPU-Z	Sensor logging for GPU clock, voltage, thermals, power limits.
Community Shaders debug overlay	Press F11 for render-time breakdown, draw-call count, VRAM usage.
SSE Display Tweaks OSD	Set ShowOSD=true in SSEDisplayTweaks.ini for basic overlay.
Skyrim console tools	showstats for real-time overlay; sgtm 0.3 slows to 30% for inspecting stutter; tfc 1 freezes camera.
Cathedral Assets Optimizer	Downscale uncompressed/oversized textures for VRAM relief.

Benchmark Methodology

1. Create a stable reference save with fixed weather (fw 10a240), fixed time (set gamehour to 12), tfc 1 for reproducible screenshots. Save as benchmark_ref.ess.
2. Use fixed routes — same save, same path for 60 seconds.
3. Log everything via MSI Afterburner or NVIDIA FrameView CSV.
4. Test one change at a time.

Benchmark Scenarios

Scenario	Location	Teleport	What It Tests
Open world	Whiterun plains west	cow WhiterunWorld -10 0	GPU/CPU balance, grass density, LOD load
Dense forest	Falkreath woods	cow FalkreathWorld -30 -20	Tree rendering, shadow complexity
Pine/marsh transition	Morthal swamp edge	cow HjaalmarchWorld -15 -10	Wetland shaders, mist, mixed flora
City centre (canals)	Riften marketplace	cow RiftenWorld 0 0	NPC count, water reflections, transitions
City centre (castles)	Solitude exterior	cow SolitudeWorld 0 0	Draw calls, shadow cascades, occlusion
Snowy tundra	Dawnstar coast	cow WinterholdWorld 10 5	Snow shaders, volumetric fog
Waterfall coast	Coast near Solitude	cow Tamriel -22 -4	Water displacement, foam, coastal LOD
Large interior	Blackreach	cow Blackreach 0 0	Particle lights, mesh density, alpha sorting
Large combat	Fort Neugrad assault	cow WhiterunWorld 15 -5 then run	AI packages, magic FX, simultaneous actors
Dragon encounter	Open world	player.placeatme 000FEA9F	Skeleton, shout VFX, cell transition
Magic VFX stress	Dense combat + spells	cow WhiterunWorld 0 0 then spawn dragon + 3 fire mages	Simultaneous particles, glow shaders, shadows
Heavy weather	Solstheim ash storm	cow SolstheimWorld 0 0 with fw 10A1E8	Particles, alpha-heavy weather, fog

Record Per Scenario

- Average FPS
- Frametime 99th percentile (stutter floor — >50ms means visible hitches)
- GPU usage % (below 90% = CPU bottleneck)
- VRAM usage (within 500MB of card total = stutter risk)
- Draw calls (above ~10,000 = CPU struggling)

Tuning Knobs (Ordered By Impact)

Stop once worst-case scenario is playable.

- 1. **Grass density** (BethINI > Environment > Grass Density). 40-60 range.
- 2. **Grass render distance** (BethINI > View Distance > Grass LOD Fade). Drop to 50-70 for forest gains.
- 3. **Shadow resolution** (BethINI > Visuals > Shadow Resolution). 2048 is sweet spot.
- 4. **Particle count** (BethINI > Visuals > Max Particle Render Count). 7500 baseline; drop to 5000 if fire/frost causes framedrops.
- 5. **Tree LOD distance** — keep `fTreeLoadDistance=0` (DynDOLOD manages).
- 6. **Object LOD fade** — drop `fMeshLODLevel12FadeTreeDistance` to 6144, `fMeshLODLevel11FadeTreeDistance` to 8192.
- 7. **VSync / framerate cap** — use SSE Display Tweaks `LockFrameRate=60`, `VSync=0`.
- 8. **Skyrim Upscaler** — if GPU is bottleneck, enable with Quality preset.

When To Accept

- Occasional microstutter on cell border crossing is normal (Engine Fixes already mitigates).
- Combat in tight spaces with 6+ actors + magic VFX: if avg FPS >40 with no hitch >100ms, call it stable.
- If a specific mod cuts FPS 30%+ vs its branch alternative, consider swapping.

Benchmark Reports

Export to CSV (NVIDIA FrameView Save CSV, MSI Afterburner [History > Log to file](#)). Keep a [benchmark-sheet.md](#):

Pass	Scenario	Avg FPS	1% Low	GPU%	VRAM	Hitch Max	Delta vs Prev
1	Whiterun	58	42	92%	6.1G	48ms	—

Every tuning attempt recorded in git alongside modlist changes.

Maintenance And Rebuild Epilogue

Patcher Revisit Triggers

Patcher	Trigger	Settings Worth Tweaking
LOOT	Every meaningful load-order change	No custom tweaks
Synthesis	Any patched mod added/removed/updated	Weapon Stat Synth: raise/lower Damage Ceiling; add to Ignore List for new artifact mods
Wrye Bash	Leveled-list-heavy mod added/removed	No per-run settings unless Bashed Patch imports unintended items
Pandora	Animation mod added/removed/reordered; skeleton or behavior change	Direct output to Pandora Output
BodySlide	Body preset/skin texture/armor mod change	No per-run settings beyond chosen preset
Grass Cache	Grass/tree/landscape texture/worldspace change; density INI tweak	Rebuild from scratch
xLODGen	Landscape texture/heightmap/worldspace change; terrain LOD mod change	Quality slider per-run for coastline artefacts
TexGen	Object/tree/building texture changes producing LOD billboards; tree mod swaps	Revisit GrassModelHeightMultiplier and TreeMSAlphaThreshold
DynDOLOD	Worldspace/tree/large-reference/LOD resource change; TexGen output change	Brightness/Contrast for LOD32; DoubleSidedTextureMask for new mountain types

Generator Output Order

- 1. **Pandora** — after animation stack stabilizes
- 2. **BodySlide** — after body/armor changes stabilize
- 3. **Synthesis** — patchers the final stack actually uses
- 4. **Wrye Bash** — only if Bashed Patch still warranted
- 5. **Grass Cache** — after grass/tree/worldspace choices stabilize
- 6. **xLODGen** — terrain LOD first
- 7. **TexGen** — before DynDOLOD
- 8. **DynDOLOD** — last
- 9. **Occlusion** — only if needed on first DynDOLOD run

After generation, verify: `DynDOLOD.esm` at end of ESM block, `DynDOLOD.esp` near end, `Occlusion.esp` after, `Synthesis.esp/Bashed Patch` per tool guidance.

Change Tracking

Keep `changelog.txt` or `build-notes.md` in `Output` separator recording: date/scope of each re-run, settings differing from baseline, branch choices changed, manual INI tweaks, reference-save used.

MCM Settings Recording

1. Screenshot each MCM page; store in `MCM-Reference` under `Output` separator.
2. Use **MCM Recorder (Nexus)** — record/replay via JSON profiles.
3. Cross-check on rebuild.

Mod Update Workflow

1. Read the mod's changelog before updating.
2. Minor version with no record/script changes: replace in-place, re-run LOOT.
3. Records, scripts, or dependencies change: treat as new install — disable old, install new, run LOOT, check xEdit conflicts, re-run affected patchers.
4. Never update DynDOLOD/TexGen/xLODGen mid-playthrough without verifying output is functionally identical. Start new game after LOD regeneration when in doubt.

Playing Forward

Two installations of `Elder Wilds` can look quite different while following the same guide. The rule: **whatever you changed, note it, and re-run only the patchers whose upstream input changed.**

Modlist Separators

Flat separator names sorted by MO2 left-pane load order. Parent categories anchor the hue; sub-separators step up in lightness for visible differentiation.

Foundations (blue)

- #1a3a6b Foundations-
- #255792 Foundations – SKSE & Scripts-
- #3173b8 Foundations – Core Libraries-
- #4a8fd4 Foundations – Mesh & Texture Fixes-
- #6aaae8 Foundations – Targeted Bugfixes-

Graphics (green)

- #0d4a0d Graphics-
- #196a19 Graphics – PGPatcher-
- #268a26 Graphics – Community Shaders-
- #35a835 Graphics – Textures & Meshes-
- #46c446 Graphics – Lighting-
- #59d859 Graphics – Weather & Water-
- #70e870 Graphics – Terrain & Flora-
- #88f088 Graphics – Characters & Creatures-
- #a2f5a2 Graphics – LOD & Distant Detail-

UI (cyan/teal)

- #1b5a68 UI-
- #2a7c8c UI – Framework & HUD-
- #3e9eb0 UI – Inventory & Items-
- #5cbcc9 UI – Map, Dialogue, Menus-

Animations (red-orange)

- #7a1a0a Animations-
- #962d18 Animations – Framework-
- #b44328 Animations – Movement & Idles-
- #d05c3a Animations – Combat-
- #e47850 Animations – Interactions & Traversal-
- #ea9870 Animations – Creatures-

Third-Person (amber/gold)

- #7a5010 Third-Person-
- #926a20 Third-Person – Camera & Movement-
- #aa8430 Third-Person – Combat & Targeting-
- #c4a044 Third-Person – Mounted-

Expanded Systems (purple)

- #3a1070 Expanded Systems-
- #52258a Expanded Systems – Character & Progression-
- #6c3aa6 Expanded Systems – Magic & Perks-
- #8759bf Expanded Systems – Survival & Needs-

-#a27cd4 Expanded Systems – Crafting & Economy-
-#bba0e6 Expanded Systems – Followers & Reputation-

World Feel (brown/amber)

-#6b3a10 World Feel-
-#875020 World Feel – Timescale & Travel-
-#a56830 World Feel – Soundscapes-
-#c08448 World Feel – Nights & Wildlife-
-#d4a264 World Feel – Cities & Landmarks-

World Content (olive green)

-#4a6b18 World Content-
-#608722 World Content – Overhauls-
-#78a530 World Content – Quests-
-#90ba48 World Content – Homes & Bases-
-#aacf6a World Content – Underwater-

NPCs (rose)

-#7a1a3a NPCs-
-#9D385B NPCs – Appearance-
-#C0567C NPCs – Population-
-#E3759D NPCs – Followers-

Enemies & Creatures (bronze)

-#8B5E3C Enemies & Creatures-

Audio (royal blue)

-#1e2a8a Audio-
-#3a4abc Audio – Music-
-#5a70d4 Audio – SFX & Ambience-

Survival & Combat (red)

-#6b1010 Survival & Combat-
-#8a1e1e Survival & Combat – Difficulty & Lethality-
-#a82e2e Survival & Combat – Enemy AI-
-#c25050 Survival & Combat – Resources & Injuries-

Standalone separators

-#C49A31 Legacy of the Dragonborn-
-#808080 Testing & Curation-
-#2F937A Performance-
-#3DAD8F Performance – Strategy-
-#4DC7A3 Performance – Optimization & Configuration-
-#5FDFB6 Performance – Tool Pipeline-
-#74F4C9 Performance – Bashed Patch & Synthesis-
-#8CFFD9 Performance – Testing & Maintenance-
-#A52786 Adult Content-
-#49389F Voicing-

-#6B6B6B Patches-
-#474747 Output-